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Happening today

● **35 WEST** Bengal ministers to be sworn in as part of Cabinet expansion.

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Business as Usual
By EP UNNY



Probe links phone used by Pahalgam attackers to Pak bank under terror scanner

Cellphones imported into Pak in 2021, 2023, not used until attack last year

Deeptiman Tiwary
New Delhi, May 31

INVESTIGATIONS INTO the Pahalgam attack have traced one of the two cellphones used by the terrorists to a consignment imported into Pakistan in 2021, financed by a Karachi-based bank that has found itself

in the crosshairs of terror probes in the past, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

The bank was earlier alleged to be associated with funds of proscribed terror outfit Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT) and Lajnat-al-Dawa, a Kuwait-based foundation with alleged links

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Royal return

With an unbeaten 75 from 42 balls, Virat Kohli took RCB home in the IPL final against the Gujarat Titans at the Narendra Modi Stadium in Ahmedabad, Sunday. The five-wicket win, while chasing 156, made RCB only the third team, after CSK and MI, to win back-to-back titles. PRAVEEN KHANNA [REPORTS, PAGES 18,19](#)

5 medical, engineering students among 6 killed in Delhi building collapse

Alok Singh

New Delhi, May 31

A 26-YEAR-old medical student preparing for the foreign medical graduate exam, a 22-year-old engineering aspirant and three other students were among six persons who died when a five-storey building collapsed in Saidulajab village, near Saket Metro Station, on Saturday night.

According to police, around 20 people, most of them students living in PGs and rented accommodation nearby, had gathered in a kitchen adjacent to the building for dinner when the structure came down around 7.15 pm.



Family members of those trapped, at the building collapse site in New Delhi. SHREYA SINGHA; [RELATED REPORTS, PAGE 3](#)

The sixth victim was Parvati (35), who ran the kitchen and was said to be “preparing parathas for the students” when the building collapsed.

Police said that “prima

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Govt seeks to bring back delimitation Bill, push joint polls by 2029

Liz Mathew
& Arun Janardhanan

New Delhi, Chennai, May 31

IN THE wake of its defeat in Parliament over its attempt to push the delimitation Bill, moves are on within the Government to revive the legislation and also bring in the One Nation One Election Bill — both before the 2029 Lok Sabha elections, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

To this effect, emboldened by its victory in West Bengal, sources said, the BJP is reaching out to regional parties

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

BRENDAN LYNCH LEADS 4-MEMBER TEAM

US team in Delhi today, urgency to finalise deal

Trade talks come as new tariffs set to replace reciprocal tariffs in July

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, May 31

A TEAM of United States Trade Representative (USTR) officials, led by chief negotiator Brendan Lynch, is set to commence negotiations with India over four days starting Monday to finalise an interim agreement.

Government sources said there is a sense of urgency now because a new US tariffs architecture is likely to replace the reciprocal tariffs announced by US President Donald Trump, and deemed illegal by the Supreme Court in February. The new rates under Section 301

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

E. EXPLAINED

Key to investments

For India, finalisation of an interim trade deal is seen as important in restoring confidence among investors. Also, there is a sense of urgency since a new US tariffs architecture is likely to replace reciprocal tariffs before July-end.

THE IDEAS PAGE P 11

INDIA-OMAN PACT HOLDS PROMISES FOR FARMS, FACTORIES & SMALL BUSINESSES



“FTAs with Europe, UK good moves... should ensure industry doesn't put pressure to take rigid positions”
MONTEK SINGHAHLUWALIA
ECONOMIST, [PAGE 15](#)

NATION

NEPAL HAS ALSO ENCROACHED ON INDIA'S TERRITORIES: PM BALENDRA
[PAGE 9](#)

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SAKET BUILDING COLLAPSE

Police had flagged illegal construction to MCD in March

Alok Singh & Drishti Jain
New Delhi, May 31

THE DELHI Police had written to the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) on two occasions in March about ongoing illegal construction atop the four-storey building near Saket Metro station that collapsed on Saturday evening, *The Indian Express* has learned.

Sources said police communicated with the civic body after a local beat constable noticed the construction that allegedly went beyond the permissible limit. Buildings in the area can be up to four storeys high, but several structures reportedly have five to six storeys.

The Mehrauli police station wrote to the office of the MCD Deputy Commissioner (South) on March 3 and March 10, flagging the alleged violations, and offering any assistance that the MCD might need. Sources said the MCD acknowledged receipt of the letters, but no follow-up action was reportedly initiated.

Six people, including five young medical and engineering graduates, were killed after a large portion of the structure at the address Khasra No. 261 on Westend Marg in Saidulajab came down in a heap of rubble on an adjacent tin-roof structure that functioned as a canteen for

students and other local people. The deceased have been identified as Ravi (24), Kapil (28), Nalin Ray (23), Alok (24), Ekta (24), and Parvati (35) who, along with her family, ran the eatery. All the dead were in the canteen at the time.

Sources said the owner of the building, a resident of Vasant Kunj, was allegedly constructing two additional floors, and had given the contract for the job to a South Delhi-based contractor.

Initial investigations suggest that the building's foundation and basement structure were weak. The building housed the offices of startups and other private companies. The owner reportedly owns several plots across South Delhi, and earns rental income from them.

The building itself was mostly empty when it collapsed around 7.15 pm. An individual who was on the ground floor was pulled out from the debris and admitted to hospital.

Police have registered an FIR under Sections 105 (culpable homicide not amounting to murder), 290 (negligent conduct with regard to buildings), and 125(a) (act endangering life or personal safety) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita 2023 (BNS), and launched a manhunt for the owner and contractor, both of whom have been missing since



Chief Minister Rekha Gupta visits the site of the building collapse in Saket on Sunday. SHREYA SINGHAI

the incident. It has also emerged that work at the site had been stopped a few days ago because the contractor was having some payment issues with the workers. Following the collapse, two MCD engineers responsible for the area were suspended for alleged dereliction of duty and negligence. Asked whether construction work had been underway at the site, a senior MCD official said it was possible – and claimed that the now-suspended engineers had, on May 27, booked the property for alleged violations.

“This building was constructed in 2013 with a ground floor and three upper floors. A new fourth-floor construction

had recently been undertaken. The officers should have acted earlier and initiated demolition proceedings,” the MCD official said. Witnesses to the incident said the structure had collapsed “like a pack of cards”.

Shivam, a medical student, said a loud noise had emanated from inside the building. “As we rushed forward, we thought a lift had collapsed. But within seconds, the entire structure started to come down, and we ran back. It then collapsed like a pack of cards in a huge cloud of dust,” he said.

More than a dozen people — mostly medical and engineering graduates — were present inside the kitchen that was

crushed. The library of a coaching institute on the other side of the structure was also damaged.

“The police arrived quickly, but the specialised rescue teams took longer to reach the site. Valuable time was lost,” a witness who gave his name as Aarav, alleged.

DCP (South) Anant Mittal and Mehrauli SHO Inspector Ritesh led the initial rescue operation. Teams from the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) and the Delhi Fire Services continued the operation until late on Sunday evening amid fears that more people could still be trapped under the debris. A total 14 people were rescued from the debris and taken to AIIMS and Safdarjung Hospital. Among the injured are Tarun Kumar (26) from Gurgaon, Saika Khan (27) from Bihar, Neelam Yadav (25) from Saidulajab, Aditya Sharma (24) from Saidulajab, Kshitij Pratap (25) from Noida, Anuj Dixit (25) from Saket, Aastha (25) from Saidulajab, and Vishal (24) from Saket.

MCD officials said that beginning Monday, a survey of highrise buildings would be carried out. “If any violation is found and the explanation is unsatisfactory, we will seal the premises or direct evacuation and demolition,” an official said.

Dreams cut short; for some, a happy day turns out to be last



From left to right: Alok, Nalin Ray, Ekta, Ravi and Parvati. EXPRESS

Alok Singh
New Delhi, May 31

THE FAMILIES of Ravi Prakash (24), Kapil (28), Nalin Ray (23), Alok (24), and Ekta (24) had dreamed of seeing them become doctors and engineers. Ravi and Ekta had completed their MBBS from Kyrgyzstan and were preparing for the Foreign Medical Graduate Examination (FMGE), a screening test mandatory in India.

The other three — Kapil, Nalin, and Alok — were preparing for the Graduate Aptitude Test in Engineering (GATE), which would help them pursue higher studies in technical programmes and Indian Engineering Services to secure government jobs. All of them were natives of different states and

had been living in Delhi in rented accommodations in Saidulajab.

For Kapil, who aspired to become a scientist at the Bhabha Atomic Research Centre, the happiest day of his life turned out to be his last. On Saturday, he performed exceptionally well in an interview. Confident about a positive outcome, with results expected in July, he was overjoyed, according to friends. To celebrate what he believed was his success, he hosted a party for five friends that evening at a canteen near the building that collapsed on Saturday evening, leading to six deaths. The group included Nalin and Alok, who were also preparing for GATE. While some of his friends managed to escape, Kapil was buried beneath the rubble.

Ekta's father, a farmer, had invested everything in his daughter's education. In 2020, Ramesh Chand sold family land to finance her medical studies in Kyrgyzstan. After completing MBBS there, she returned to India and moved to Delhi to prepare for the FMGE. "She was brilliant," her father said. "Becoming a doctor had been her dream since childhood."

Remembering Parvati, the owner of the canteen who also died in the building collapse, a female student said that the shop's affordable prices and hygienic food attracted many living in the area. "She was very humble, and her staff treated customers with respect. During the cylinder crisis, she did not even increase the prices of food," the student said.

Lowest PM2.5 levels since 2015 in May, but PM10 levels remain steady

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, May 31

DELHI RECORDED its lowest PM2.5 levels in May this year in at least a decade. However, PM10 levels logged in May remained almost unchanged from May 2025. This sharp contrast between the concentration of two pollutants, experts say, suggests that rain and winds may have temporarily cleared finer pollutants without tackling the coarser particles from sources that generate them.

Data from the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) show that city's average PM2.5 concentration in May this year

stood at 54 µg/m³ (micrograms per cubic metre), the lowest in May since at least 2015 and nearly half the 114 µg/m³ recorded in May 2017. PM10 levels, in contrast, averaged 175 µg/m³, marginally higher than 173 µg/m³ last May and only slightly lower than the 185 µg/m³ recorded in May 2023.

The divergence between the two pollutants is significant because PM2.5 and PM10 often respond differently to meteorological conditions, experts say. PM2.5 particles are lighter and remain suspended in the atmosphere for longer periods, making them more susceptible to dispersion by strong winds and wash-

• Skywatch



Forecast: June 1, 2026:
Partly cloudy sky becoming generally cloudy sky; a spell of very light to light rain

MAX: 35-37
3°C below normal

MIN: 24-26
2.4°C above normal

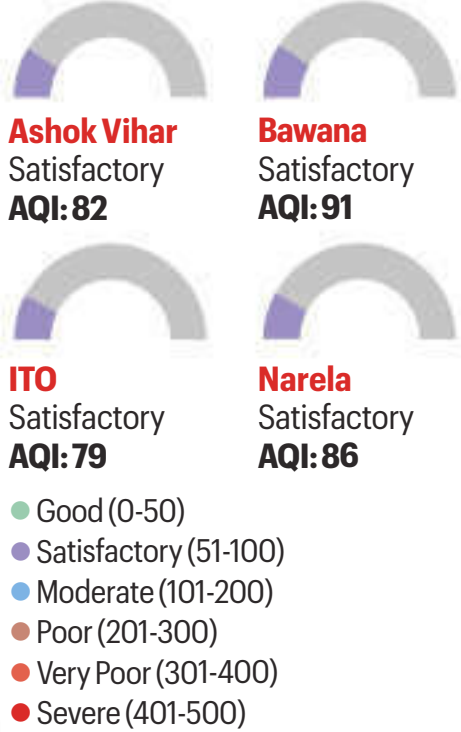
• **Sunrise:** 5:24 AM (June 2)

• **Sunset:** 7:15 PM (June 1)

• **Moonrise:** 8:25 PM (June 1)

• **Moonset:** 6:30 AM (June 2)

• AQI Tracker



out during rainfall events. PM10, is more closely linked to dust resuspension, construction activity, and regional dust transport.

Last May, Delhi logged substantially higher rainfall (185.9 mm) and a lower average maximum temperature (37.6°C) compared to this year. Yet, PM10 levels this May still remained almost identical to those of last year, revealing the persistence of coarse-particle pollution. PM2.5 levels, however, fell from 67 µg/m³ to 54 µg/m³ this year.

The cleaner PM2.5 levels also coincided with favourable weather conditions during the month. As per IMD data, Delhi

received 19.5 mm of rainfall across three rainy days in May.

Delhi recorded an average maximum temperature of 39.5°C in May, marking only a small variation from the 40°C the usually logs for the month. Meanwhile, the average minimum temperature stood at 25.8°C. “PM10 levels have remained relatively high, which suggests that only the finer particles were dispersed temporarily because of weather conditions, rather than there being a substantial reduction in emissions,” said Sunil Dahiya, lead environmental analyst and founder of Envirocatalysts, a Delhi-based think tank.

OBITUARY
26 July, 1948 - 28 May, 2026
Our hearts are heavy with a grief that cannot possibly be conveyed by the limited power of words, yet we are filled with overwhelming gratitude for the extraordinary woman that was Mrs. Veena Thakur. She was a trailblazer long before the world knew how to handle one, learning to drive at just sixteen and steering her own destiny independently from the start. A testament to her resilient spirit and loving sacrifice, she started working while still in school and shouldering responsibilities far beyond her years to support her family. Her entrepreneurial grit and sharp mind were what led her to pursue Economics at Lady Shri Ram College and later run her own factory, breaking glass ceilings at every turn of her life. It is no wonder, then, that she held education in the highest regard and believed in our futures too when we were too young to see it ourselves – from greeting us with a smile every day outside our classrooms when we rushed to her crying as kindergarteners to helping with our homework. She leaves behind a legacy of indomitable courage and selfless love. Rest in peace, Dadi. Though you have left for a better place, your light will never fade and your unbreakable spirit will forever beat within our hearts.
Love you always -
Shambhavi, Kabir, Jay, Prithvi and Nirbhay (grandchildren)
JP Thakur, ex AIG CISE, Husband
Gunjan Thakur, Son
Navita and Pooja Thakur, Daughters in law

‘Rivalry’ led to Paralympic athlete’s killing, kin ‘wanted to see him win medal for India’

Drishti Jain & Nitin Sharma
Ghaziabad, May 31

NEARLY A year-long alleged rivalry between 25-year-old Chirag Tyagi, the Paralympic athlete who was shot dead on May 30 in Ghaziabad, and another Paralympic athlete, who has been apprehended in the murder case and was his junior, preceded the killing, DCP City and Trans-Hindon Dhawal Jaiswal said on Sunday. The autopsy reports have confirmed gunshot injury as the cause of the death.

According to a senior police officer, the victim and the suspect were friends earlier and even stayed together for a few years, while training in Delhi, before the accused returned home last year following disqualification in an event. “They both participated in the same category, for runners who could not see beyond 6 m. But last year, the accused got disqualified at this event after the authorities allegedly found out that he could see. The accused thought that Chirag had filed a complaint against him. However, we have not found an official letter,” an officer said.



Huge crowds gathered at Chirag's home Sunday. SHREYA SINGHAI

On Sunday, over a hundred people gathered at Chirag's house in Ghaziabad's Muradnagar where his body was brought after the autopsy.

Just days before he was killed, Chirag had qualified for the Asian Para Games 2026, to be held in Japan in October, after winning gold and silver medals in the 400 m and 1,500 m races, respectively, in the Men's T12 (Visually impaired athletes) category in the 8th Indian Open Para Athletics International Championship held at Sri Kanteravara Stadium in Bengaluru between May 26 and May 28.

Sanyogita Tyagi, his aunt, said the whole village was preparing for a grand welcome. “He was supposed to come home on Saturday... We had been getting congratulatory calls from relatives. We all were very happy,” she said as she pointed to the medals and trophies in his room.

Villagers affectionately called Chirag “*Toofan*” (astorm) for his speed in 100 m and 400 m races. “We hoped to see Chirag win a medal for India in the Asian Para Games but now he is no more,” Ashish Tyagi, Chirag's cousin, said.

It was difficult for the 25-

year-old to convince his father, being the only child, that he wished to pursue sports and not prepare for IIT, said another cousin, Himani Tyagi (40). “He asked his father to give him some time and showed him he can run at a lightning speed. He started winning district and state-level competitions and later went to nationals,” she recalled. “Chirag had started training under me in 2024. A lot of senior players helped junior players and Chirag also did the same with the accused... he had brought him to train under me in 2024,” said Gajendra Singh, husband of Paris Paralympics medallist Simran Sharma, who was training Chirag before his death.

While the police have said the accused is above 18, her mother claimed that he will turn 18 in November this year. “Since the last seven years, my son has given everything to sports and considered Chirag as a mentor. He had a weak eyesight since he was small, and was keeping very quiet since he was disqualified,” she said, adding that she does not believe that her son could commit such a crime.

Main suspect in Gzb teen’s murder gunned down

Drishti Jain
Ghaziabad, May 31

THE MAIN accused in the Ghaziabad teen murder case was killed in an encounter on Sunday morning, police said. The suspect, Asad, had fired at the police team with the intention of killing them, and had been shot after police retaliated in self-defence, officers said.

The main accused in the alleged stabbing of a 17-year-old boy in Khoda, Ghaziabad, on Thursday, he had been absconding, and a reward of Rs 50,000 had been announced for his capture.

The 17-year-old, whom the accused had allegedly stabbed following an altercation around noon on Bakrid, had succumbed to his injuries the day after, police had said earlier.

DCP Trans-Hindon and City Dhawal Jaiswal said that they received information that Asad was expected to enter the Khoda area to meet some associates and collect money before fleeing elsewhere. “Based on this intelligence, police launched an intensive combing operation and set up checkpoints... During the operation, Asad was spotted in the Vasundhara area riding a motorcycle with an accomplice. When police attempted to stop him and issued warnings, Asad allegedly opened fire on the police team. Police retaliated, and during the exchange of fire, Asad was struck by a bullet,” he said. Asad died during treatment at a hospital, the DCP added.

A constable from the Khoda police station was injured in the alleged exchange of fire, an officer said.

CENTRAL UNIVERSITY OF HARYANA
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Registration Opens for Post Graduate (PG) Programmes
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Central University of Haryana, Mahendergarh invites online Registration Forms for the candidates who have appeared in CUET (PG)-2026 examination conducted by National Testing Agency for admission to the following programmes:

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M.Tech. Energy System and Management, Structural Engineering, Computer Science and Engineering	MBA (TTM) MBA-Tourism and Travel Management
Law LL.B. (3 years), LL.M.	M.Pharm. Pharmacognosy, Pharmacology, Pharmaceutics
M.C.A. Master of Computer Applications	M.Com. Commerce
M.P.Ed. Master of Physical Education	MBA Management Studies
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	Post Graduate Diploma in Rehabilitation Psychology (PGDRP)
	Advance Diploma in Child Guidance and Counselling (ADCGC)

IMPORTANT DATES
Start date for online Registration 22/05/2026 Registration Link
Last date for online Registration 12/06/2026 https://cuhcuet.samarth.edu.in/pg/
For more details and updates please visit www.cuh.ac.in REGISTRAR

Jahangir Aziz
Co-Head of Macroeconomic Research, J.P.Morgan

Siddharth Upasani
Deputy Associate Editor
The Indian Express

How is the West Asia war reshaping global trade and capital flows?

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The Indian EXPRESS
JOURNALISM OF COURAGE

CBSE's OSM CHAOS

The new digital evaluation system, implemented for the first time this year for Class 12 board exams, has been under fire amid claims of tampering of answer books and rushed roll out. With students — worried over college admission deadlines — complaining of challenges related to re-evaluation times, the CBSE said that the Post-Result Activities portal becomes operational from today.

Vidheesha Kuntamalla & Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, May 31

IT WAS not every day that 17-year-old Sachi, a student from Delhi, woke up before 5 am, trying repeatedly to open a website, while the rest of the city slept. But earlier this month, she was trying to open the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) re-evaluation portal — the website had been crashing for days as students across the country tried to obtain scanned copies of their answer books after the declaration of the Class 12 board examination results on May 13.

For days, as she tried, the site would open briefly or freeze. Sachi thought the best bet to access it would be to wake up before dawn when, as she hoped, fewer students would be online. "It finally worked," she recalled, accessing her scanning answer books.

For thousands of students like Sachi, CBSE's On-Screen Marking (OSM), a digital evaluation system introduced for Class 12 board examination for the first time this year, has raised major concerns about possible errors in their result. Many have even questioned if the scanned answer books they accessed even belonged to them.

For, 17-year-old Kushal Jain getting a scanned copy of the Chemistry answer book turned into an ordeal. He got a score of 97 in Physics and Mathematics, each, but only 79 in Chemistry. "I had expected a score above 95. When the results were declared, I assumed there had been a mistake." But the re-evaluation portal, he said, repeatedly malfunctioned and dates for re-evaluation were extended by CBSE.

On May 29, CBSE ultimately announced that the Post-Result Activities portal — for verification and re-evaluation — would only become operational from June 1, saying the delay was necessary to ensure a "transparent and glitch-free process" and maintain the "highest standards and protocols of evaluation."

But students are worried as deadlines are nearing for admissions to the college of their choice. "The registration for Joint Admission Counselling (JAC), Delhi, which conducts admissions to the B Tech and B Arch programmes, closes on June 9. My counselling starts on June 2. CBSE keeps extending the dates and students are stuck in limbo," said Kushal.

"If my marks increase," he added, "my overall percentage crosses 95." But the revised score may arrive after critical decisions regarding the college admissions have already been made.

For students pursuing engineering, like 17-year-old Moksh Yadav, a handful of marks can alter eligibility, counselling prospects and admission outcomes. Many engineering institutions require candidates to secure at least 75% marks in Class 12, in addition to qualifying through entrance examinations such as Joint Entrance Examination (JEE).

However, it was no less than a rude shock for Moksh when he had opened the scanned copy of his Class 12 English answer book — his score was 33 out of 80. "The handwriting was unfamiliar, entire sections were blank and the answer book had only 12 pages," he said. He distinctly remembered using a supplementary sheet during the examination. "The first page looked like mine," he said. "After that, the entire answer book, it seemed, belonged to someone else."

While he hoped to score around 78-80%, the English score brought his overall percentage down. "I wasn't expecting perfection. I just expected fairness," he said.

Moksh hopes to pursue Bachelor of Management Studies at Delhi University and has appeared for the Common University Entrance Test (CUET). "I did not get the marks for which I studied and wrote the examination... this could alter my chances to even qualify JEE," he rued.

After CBSE responded to his re-evaluation complaint by stating that no discrepancy had been found, Moksh turned to social media. Eventually, a legal notice was sent to CBSE. "If the matter remains unresolved, my family is considering approaching the Supreme Court."

Rollout rushed, say evaluators

Even as the CBSE had promised "minimum human errors" with the launch of the new evaluation system, several principals, evaluators and senior teachers who spoke to *The Indian Express* claimed that the rollout was rushed, inadequately tested and difficult to navigate for many teachers.

Minutes of a meeting held last June of the CBSE Governing Body — the Board's highest decision-making body — show that members had recommended the implementation of the OSM system across all subjects only after pilot projects had been conducted in selected subjects and regional offices. According to teachers, this never materialised.

Instead, teachers and evaluators claimed, the dry run was held across five schools involving around 100 teachers in January this year. This, even as the CBSE claimed, that they had been preparing for nearly a year.

Formal onboarding and practice sessions began around mid-February, evaluators said. "A six-month trial run should have taken place," said a headmistress of a private school in South Delhi.

The system frequently struggled under its own weight, said some teachers. "Evaluators were forced to make sense of blurred and poorly scanned answer sheets. At times, the system even logged evaluators out, and when they logged back

in, the sheet appeared as already checked," alleged a teacher, who participated in the evaluation process.

According to school principals, teachers were repeatedly called in to clear backlogs as pending answer books piled up on the portal, particularly in subjects such as Physics.

The transition to a new system was especially daunting for many elderly teachers, the headmistress said, adding, "Some even admitted they did not know how to use a mouse properly."

Teachers said the challenges extended far beyond basic computer literacy. Initially, CBSE required evaluators to assess 20 answer books a day. Later, this daily limit was increased to 25.

Many evaluators found those targets difficult to meet. "I was not able to correct more than 10 sheets," one evaluator said. "Many teachers faced the same situation."

Another teacher described the physical strain of the process. "Teachers were irritated, fatigued and under pressure. They had to sit in front of screens for long hours. For elderly teachers, this can take a physical toll on their bodies."

Several evaluators claimed that some scripts were blurred, poorly scanned or difficult to decipher because of overwritten text and faint handwriting.

Since the answer book appeared as a continuous digital booklet, evaluators often felt they had little choice but to continue assessing it even when the quality was poor. "Once you start the booklet, you have to finish it," one teacher said, adding, "The pressure to meet the minimum requirements often



Drop in pass percentage

CLASS 12 pass percentage dropped from 88.39% last year to 85.29% this year

A LOWER pass percentage than this year was in 2019 at 83.40%.

• The 12-year road to OSM

Early experiment: 2013-14

CBSE first experimented with On-Screen Marking (OSM) in 2013-14 for select subjects and regional offices, working with technology vendors including TCS. While some centres reported satisfactory outcomes, operational and infrastructural challenges prevented the system from being expanded nationwide at the time.

Proposed pilot: 2024-25

CBSE proposed that OSM be implemented from the 2024-25 exams in "small-volume subjects" (those with fewer examinees). Targeted for the pilot were a few subjects in the main examination for both Classes 10 and 12, and the science or mathematics supplementary exams. Class 12 Applied Mathematics was specifically flagged for OSM review.

Controversial implementation: 2026

The system has been used by examination boards like Cambridge (UK), IB, and Pearson for years. CBSE decided to introduce OSM for the evaluation of all Class 12 answer books beginning with the 2026 exams, covering all 116 subjects at full scale. The rollout has run into serious issues, with allegations of marking discrepancies, blurred scans, and technical glitches in the portal.

• STEP-BY-STEP

1 WRITING

- Students appeared for exams at designated CBSE examination centres.

- Answer books were sent to CBSE's regional offices, where they went through a "secrecy" process to conceal identifying details to make sure that evaluation was anonymous.

3 MARKING

- Examiners login credentials; CBSE uploaded marking schemes for all subjects.
- Evaluators read scanned answer sheets online, awarded marks into the digital system.
- Software automatically added the marks to reduce calculation errors.

forced evaluators to compromise and correct the paper fully anyway."

A principal of private school recalled teachers repeatedly struggling to access the platform itself. "The evaluators themselves struggled with credentials and OTPs, often unable to even access the system properly," the principal said.

What CBSE says

As the CBSE continues to be under fire, a fresh statement was put out on Sunday. "We have been closely monitoring the vulnerabilities in the OnMark portal of our service provider that are being flagged in the public domain. An expert team of cybersecurity professionals has been deployed over the last few days from across various arms of the government as well as the IITs to fortify these systems, including taking them over to a more secure set up. The identified vulnerabilities have been contained, and other exploitable weaknesses are being ruled out."

Earlier, officials had told *The Indian Express* that the Board received 2.94 lakh applications seeking copies of 8.56 lakh answer books this year — more than

2 SCANNING

- Each answer booklet was digitally scanned at the regional office.
- Officials were supposed to check whether the scanned pages were clear, complete, and properly uploaded.
- After a second verification, the digitised answer sheets were uploaded to CBSE's OSM evaluation system.

4 SUBMISSION

- Some evaluated answer sheets were supposed to be randomly reviewed by senior evaluators, including Additional Head Examiners and Head Examiners.
- After evaluation and checking, the digitally marked answer books were submitted into the system.

double last year's 1.31 lakh applications for 2.82 lakh answer books. Officials and educators attributed part of the surge to a decline in top scores, with the number of students scoring above 90% falling by around 16% compared to 2025.

The CBSE is also considering imposing a financial penalty on Hyderabad-based vendor Coempt Edutech Pvt Ltd handling the OSM system. *The Indian Express* reported on May 29. Sources said the CBSE has identified 5,000 blurred answer book scans so far and 23 cases where students received scanned copies belonging to another candidate's answer sheet.

However, officials have defended the digital evaluation process, saying it involves three separate layers of quality checks before answer books reach evaluators. Scripts were reviewed during scanning, reviewed again during uploading and evaluators themselves could reject illegible scans.

In the case of mismatched answer sheets, CBSE pointed to the anonymisation stage, suggesting that errors may have occurred while handling the "flying slips" used to conceal student identities before evaluation.

• OSM challenged: Allahabad HC, May 2026

CBSE's OSM for Class 12 has been challenged before the Lucknow Bench of the Allahabad High Court. The PIL alleged that the rushed implementation of the mechanism has caused "systemic institutional failure" in the assessment of students.

Re-evaluation scrapped — Delhi HC (2017)

CBSE had abolished the re-evaluation system for Board exam answer sheets. When the matter came before the Delhi HC, the court was shown answer sheets where completely correct responses had been awarded zero marks. The bench asked CBSE why it had done away with re-evaluation altogether.

COVID evaluation controversy — SC (2021)

After Class 12 Board exams were cancelled due to Covid-19, CBSE adopted a 30:30:40 formula to calculate students' marks based on their performance in classes 10, 11, and 12 respectively. A group of pass-out students petitioned the Supreme Court alleging that their marks had not been computed using this formula. They also alleged that CBSE's dispute resolution mechanism for aggrieved students existed only on paper.

Class 10 Internal Assessment — Delhi HC (2021)

CBSE announced that Class 10 students would be assessed entirely on the basis of internal marks awarded by their schools. An NGO challenged this before Delhi HC, arguing that it created serious risks of manipulation and exploitation of students and parents by schools. The court issued notice to the Central government and the Delhi government, seeking their response to the petition.

Key red flags: the process and debate

Vidheesha Kuntamalla
New Delhi, May 31

The OSM process

Rather than marking the paper answer books submitted by examinees, teachers assess scanned copies of the answer books that have been anonymised and put on a secure digital platform. CBSE adopted OSM this year to make evaluation more uniform, efficient, and secure with less regional variations in marking, no totalling mistakes, and better monitoring of evaluators.

"However, the attempt to speed up the marking process ignores the importance of discussions and collective understanding among teachers that helps them grow in the job," Dr Latika Gupta, assistant professor of education at Delhi University, said.

Not flawed, but...

A study commissioned by Britain's examinations regulator found that "markers using online marking systems showed greater consistency in the application of mark schemes than those using traditional paper-based methods". Assessment researcher Victoria Crisp has argued that digital systems help in standardisation and quality monitoring.

However, Cambridge Assessment researchers have noted that problems relating to scanning quality, software performance and implementation can still affect outcomes.

Edward Vickers, professor of comparative education at Fukuoka University in Japan, said: "The real question with the Indian system and this

current scandal is maybe not the system or the idea behind it, but the practicalities of whether the system was trialled and piloted." According to Vickers, "What seems to have happened suggests that the system wasn't ready, the CBSE itself wasn't ready, the teachers weren't ready."

Outside India

In the UK, the Assessment and Qualification Alliance, Oxford Cambridge and RSA Examination and Pearson Edexcel have used online marking for many years. According to Britain's regulator Ofqual, online marking was introduced to improve quality control, increase efficiency, and strengthen examiner monitoring. The International Baccalaureate (IB), whose examinations are taken in more than 150 countries, also relies heavily on digital evaluation.

But Vickers pointed out that Britain's General Certificate of Secondary Education (GCSE) and A-levels were different because they frequently included long-form written responses and essays. "Technology can help make the process more efficient. But we need to be very careful about seeing technology as taking over the role of actually assessing students' answers... The human markers have to be in charge," Vickers said. **LONGER VERSION** WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM



New CDS General N S Raja Subramani in New Delhi on Sunday. PTI

Gen Subramani takes over as CDS, prioritises tri-services synergy

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, May 31

GENERAL N S Raja Subramani, widely known as an expert on Pakistan and China, on Sunday took charge as India's new Chief of Defence Staff with a primary mandate to implement the ambitious military theatisation plan and bolster tri-services synergy.

Gen Subramani was serving as the Military Advisor at the National Security Council Secretariat (NSCS). He retired as the Vice Chief of Army Staff on July 31 last year. The military officer, shortly after taking charge, said transformation of the armed forces and organisational reforms to enhance tri-services synergy and integration will be his primary focus.

"We will accelerate the development, induction and integra-

tion of indigenous weapons in our armed forces," he said in a brief media statement.

"Our armed forces consistently demonstrated professionalism and operational decisiveness in safeguarding our national interests. We are committed to protecting the sovereignty and territorial integrity of our country," he said.

"I assure citizens of India that armed forces will continue to serve the nation with dedication, courage, honour and professionalism," he said. Gen Subramani noted that he would work towards accelerating the development, induction and integration of indigenous weapon systems into the armed forces.

Calling for "greater collaboration" between the military, industry and academia, the new CDS said the Indian Army, the Navy, Air Force, the defence ministry and the strategic institutions stand united as part of the "whole of nation approach" to strengthen India's security.

Adm Swaminathan new Navy chief

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, May 31

ADMIRAL KRISHNA Swaminathan on Sunday assumed charge as India's 27th Chief of the Naval Staff and immediately prioritised peak operational readiness as his top focus to navigate a fast-evolving regional maritime security landscape. He succeeds Admiral Dinesh Kumar Tripathi, who superannuated after 41 years of distinguished service.



Admiral Krishna Swaminathan

earlier serving as the Flag Officer Commanding-in-Chief of the Western Naval Command.

The new Navy Chief described the regional security environment as "challenging, complex and unpredictable", and asserted that maintaining top-level operational readiness will be his highest priority.

"The Indian Navy stands vigilant to protect national interests...and is very actively deployed in a regional security environment that continues to remain challenging, complex, unpredictable, and uncertain," he told reporters.

F.No. 1-9/2025-Skt.I
Government of India
Ministry of Education
Department of Higher Education

Admission No. 04/2026

Applications are invited for appointment to the post of Vice-Chancellor of Shri Lal Bahadur Shastri National Sanskrit University (SLBSNSU), New Delhi.

The Vice-Chancellor, is the Academic as well as Administrative Head and Is Chief Executive Officer of the University. The eligibility conditions and otherwise for consideration to this post is as under. The candidates shall be:

1). An eminent scholar in the field of Sanskrit and allied subjects and his qualifications shall be as specified in the regulations made under the University Grants Commission Act, 1956 (3 of 1956).

ii). Preferably not more than 65 years of age as on the closing date of receipt of applications as prescribed in the advertisement.

Salary and Service Conditions:

1). The post carries a pay of Rs. 2,10,000/- (Fixed) per month with Special Allowance of Rs. 11,250/- and other usual allowances.

ii). The other terms and conditions of the services will be those as set forth in the Central Sanskrit Universities Act, 2020 and Statutes of the University.

Procedure for appointment:

i). Appointment will be made from a panel of three names recommended by a Search-cum-Selection-Committee constituted in accordance with the procedure laid down in Statutes of the University.

Submission of Application:

i). The advertisement is available on the websites <http://www.education.gov.in> & <https://www.slbsrsv.ac.in>.

ii). Candidates are required to "APPLY ONLINE ONLY" on the Ministry of Education SAMARTH portal as per the link given below: <https://vrec.samarth.ac.in/index.php/>

iii). The Ministry will not be responsible for the delay in receipt of applications for whatever reasons it may be.

iv). The persons who are already in service should apply through proper channel and submit their applications through their employer along with the NOC/Vigilance Clearance Report given by the Chief Vigilance Officer of their Institutions/Departments along with the applications.

v). Incomplete applications/applicants received after the last date of receipt of applications will not be considered.

vi). The above link will be active from 1st June, 2026, 10:00 Hours to 30th June, 2026, 17:00 Hours.

Sd/-
(Dr. Saumya Rajan)
Deputy Secretary to the Government of India
Tel No: 23070182

CBC-21371/11/0003/2627

No.1-1/2026-Skt.II
GOVERNMENT OF INDIA.
MINISTRY OF EDUCATION
DEPARTMENT OF HIGHER EDUCATION
Advertisement No.01/2026
Appointment of Vice-Chancellor of
Central Sanskrit University, Delhi

Applications are invited for the post of Vice-Chancellor of Central Sanskrit University, Delhi. The Vice-Chancellor, being the academic as well as administrative head, is expected to be:

i. An eminent scholar in the field of Sanskrit and allied subjects and his qualifications shall be as specified in the regulations made under the University Grants Commission Act, 1956 (3 of 1956) in this behalf.

ii. Preferably not more than 65 years of age as on the closing date of receipt of applications of this advertisement.

iii. A person possessing the highest level of competence, integrity, morals and institutional commitment.

iv. A distinguished academician, with a minimum of 10 years' experience as Professor in a University or 10 years' experience in a reputed research and/or academic administrative organization with proof of having demonstrated academic leadership.

Salary and Service Conditions

• The post carries a pay of Rs. 2,10,000/- (Fixed) per month with Special Allowance of Rs. 11,250/- and other usual allowances.

• The other terms and conditions of the services will be those as set forth in the Central Sanskrit Universities Act, 2020 and Statutes and Ordinances of the University.

Procedure for appointment

• Appointment will be made from a panel of three names recommended by a Selection Committee in accordance with the procedure laid down in the Central Sanskrit Universities Act, 2020.

Submission of Application

• The advertisement is available on the websites <https://www.education.gov.in> and <https://www.sanskrit.nic.in/>

• Candidates are required to "APPLY ONLINE ONLY" on the Ministry of Education SAMARTH portal as per the link given below: <https://vrec.samarth.ac.in/index.php/>

• The Ministry will not be responsible for the delay in receipt of applications for whatever reasons it maybe.

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• Incomplete applications/ applications received after the last day for receipt of applications will not be considered.

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Deputy Secretary to the Government of India
Tel No.: 23070182

CBC-21212/11/0004/2627

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11%

PAT

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21%

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53.16 MnT

13%

SALES

50.24 MnT

61%

TURNOVER

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22%

PRODUCTION

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New Delhi



Mandarin Connect

NEWLY APPOINTED Indian ambassador to China Vikram Doraiswami has started making waves on Chinese social media. Soon after taking charge earlier this month, he put out a video, in which he speaks fluent Mandarin and introduces the Indian embassy in Beijing and its facilities. The 14-year-old building has official, cultural, economic offices and centres and even has a corner where Indian handicrafts are showcased. Doraiswami, who spent his early years in China as a career diplomat, is trying to reconnect with the Chinese audience with his language skills he learnt during his training there.

Wake-UP Call From The Top

WHILE THE AIMIM may not be a big player in Uttar Pradesh, its state unit chief Shaukat Ali is feeling the heat as elections in the state approach. Ali had a difficult telephonic conversation with party chief Asaduddin Owaisi, who is learnt to have told him that he will be sacked if the party's performance in the state does not improve in the upcoming elections. The AIMIM failed miserably in the 2022 polls in UP, while it has been making gains in neighbouring Bihar. Owaisi gave a very stern message to Ali and told him he will not hear "excuses" — after which Ali has hit the ground running.

Words Of Gratitude

MALVIYA NAGAR MLA Satish Upadhyay came in for praise from Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta for successfully urging her to resume her political journey. A former Delhi BJP chief, Upadhyay was presenting a "report card" related to developmental work in his constituency to the CM at an event on Sunday when the compliment came. Gupta, who was DUSU president from 1996-97, expressed gratitude to Upadhyay for not personally visiting to check on, and encouraging her to gradually return to public life at a time when, she said, she had chosen the role of a stay-home mother over a possible career in politics.

Assembly polls over, Congress prepares for a major shake-up

6 state chiefs may be replaced; AICC may also see changes, Rahul looks to induct fresh faces with 2029 in mind

Manoj CG
New Delhi, May 31

WITH THE Assembly election cycle over and the leadership transition in Karnataka conducted smoothly, the Congress high command has turned its attention to restructuring some state units and reshuffling organisational responsibilities at the All India Congress Committee (AICC) level.

Sources said a revamp of the Punjab Congress was on the cards ahead of the Assembly elections due in February 2027. Punjab Congress chief Amrinder Singh Raja Warring is likely to be replaced, with a section of the leadership pitching for Jalandhar MP and former CM Charanjit Singh Channi to take over. The party's underwhelming performance in the recent local body polls has deepened factional fault lines within the state unit. The party could see leadership changes in as many as six states. While Congress is set to appoint new presidents in Kerala, Tamil Nadu, and Karnataka, discussions are also underway on whether the state chiefs in Rajasthan and poll-bound Uttar Pradesh should be replaced.

In Kerala, state Congress president Sunny Joseph has become a minister in the V D Sa-

theesan government. Lobbying for the top party post has already begun, with caste, community and factional equations coming into play. Lok Sabha MPs Kodikunnil Suresh, Benny Behanan, and Anto Antony are among the contenders along with UDF convener Adoor Prakash and senior leader Joseph Vazhackan.

Those backing Suresh, an eight-term MP and former working president of the state unit, argue that the party should consider appointing a Dalit leader to the post. Others contend that with Christians having backed the Congress in big numbers and the BJP stepping up outreach to the community, Joseph should be succeeded by a Christian leader. In Tamil Nadu, K Selvaperumthagai is set to be removed, with the high command said to be unhappy with his style of functioning.

In Karnataka, the choice of successor to D K Shivakumar, who is set to take over as CM, is linked to the impending Cabinet reshuffle. While Satish Jarkiholi, a minister in the Siddaramaiah government, is viewed as the frontrunner, sources said the final decision would depend on the Cabinet appointments. AICC's Haryana in-charge B K Hariprasad is also learnt to be in the running. Shivakumar is expected in Delhi for consulta-

tions on Cabinet formation and sources said a decision on the next Karnataka Congress chief could be taken before his swearing-in on June 3.

Rajasthan Congress president Govind Singh Dotasra has held the post since July 2020, while Ajay Rai has headed the Uttar Pradesh unit since August 2023. Sources said the leadership was weighing whether both state units require a change at the top. The party's state unit in Andhra Pradesh is also likely to see a leadership change, with current state president Y S Sharmila likely to be nominated to the Rajya Sabha from Karnataka, a promise that the leadership made to her before she joined the party ahead of the 2024 polls.

The decision to reappoint Girish Chodankar as Goa Congress president, however, has triggered disquiet within the state unit. Assembly elections in Goa are due in February 2027. Chodankar had resigned as state chief in March 2022 following the party's defeat in the Assembly polls. Apart from changes in state units, a reshuffle at the AICC level is also under consideration. Sources said the leadership was dissatisfied with the performance of several state in-charges. The proposed changes were discussed during a meeting between Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi and Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge, sources said. Gandhi is understood to be keen on bringing in fresh faces at the top as part of the preparations for the 2029 Lok Sabha elections.



TMC supreme Mamata Banerjee meets party MP Kalyan Banerjee at his Kolkata residence on Sunday. PTI

TMC MP alleges attack by BJP workers outside police station

Sweety Kumari
Kolkata, May 31

TMC MP Kalyan Banerjee staged a sit-in protest on Sunday, alleging that he was attacked and injured on his way to Chanditala police station in Hooghly district to submit a memorandum against the arrest and detention of party workers there. The incident came just a day after TMC general secretary Abhishek Banerjee was assaulted in Sonarpur, South 24 Parganas.

Kalyan claimed that stones were pelted at him by BJP workers, causing a head injury that knocked him down. Holding a handkerchief to his head, the MP sat on the road in protest directly in front of the police station, accusing police of inaction and urging the public to join his demonstration. "MPs are being targeted, especially those who maintain that they will continue to fight for the TMC," he said.

"I was coming alone; there was no one with me. BJP members used abusive lan-

guage and hit me on the head with a deuce ball. My head is bleeding... Now people will decide whether it is right or wrong that MPs are being continuously targeted." Following this, Kalyan filed a complaint at the Chanditala police station.

However, SP (Hooghly Rural) Kumar Sunny Raj said the initial inquiry showed no physical altercation had taken place. The SP said that a probe was underway, and relevant video footage was being reviewed to ascertain the facts.

Reacting to the incident, BJP leader Sukanta Majumdar questioned the authenticity of the attack, and said, "We condemn such incidents as no violence is acceptable in a democracy... However, he (Kalyan Banerjee) had previously given jobs only to his close aides, and there is deep resentment among the public. Let police investigate. It won't be a surprise if the probe reveals this was orchestrated by someone from their own party or a rival faction within the TMC."

5 arrested day after assault on Abhishek

Tanusree Bose
Kolkata, May 31

FIVE PERSONS, including two women, have been arrested in connection with the assault on TMC MP Abhishek Banerjee in Sonarpur in South 24 Parganas district, West Bengal, Saturday.

The accused were identified in videos uploaded on social media after the attack on him. "Five persons were taken into custody. Two more have been detained... We are looking into the videos, and further probe is on," a senior police officer, Sonarpur, said. The five arrested persons included Nirjala Sengupta, Debasish Dutta, Kajol Das, and Akash Gayen, a local youth.

On Saturday afternoon, Banerjee was attacked by a mob in Sonarpur while on his way to meet the family of a TMC worker who was killed in an alleged post-poll violence.

35 ministers to take oath today, says Suwendu

Atri Mitra
Kolkata, May 31

THREE WEEKS after Suwendu Adhikari was sworn in as Chief Minister along with five Cabinet ministers, the BJP government in Bengal is set to expand its Council of Ministers on Monday.

"Tomorrow, a full-fledged Council of Ministers of the elected nationalist government will be formed by the verdict of the people of West Bengal. For the purpose of expanding the Council of Ministers, 35 ministers of the West Bengal government will take their oaths at Nabanna at 11 am. His Excellency the Governor Shri R N Ravi will administer their oaths at Nabanna," Adhikari posted on X in Bangla on Sunday.

While the government is yet to announce the list of additional ministers, Adhikari can induct a maximum of 38 more ministers. The 91st Constitutional Amendment caps the size of the Council of Ministers to 15% of the strength of the House. For Bengal, which has 294 MLAs in the House, the figure is 44. With the five Cabinet ministers already sworn in representing women (Agnimitra Paul), Matuas (Ashok Kirtania), Rajbangshis (Nisith Pramanik), and tribals (Kshudiram Tudu), party leaders said the expanded Council of Ministers will see representation from other communities.

A party leader said that actor-turned-politician Rudranil Ghosh may get included in the extended Cabinet. Two journalist-turned-politicians, Swapan Dasgupta and Jagannath Chattopadhyay, are also likely to get important berths in the Cabinet. Dasgupta, a former Rajya Sabha MP, may be in the running for Minister for Higher Education.

BJP sweeps 3 of 4 municipal corporations in Himachal, Congress retains Palampur

Saurabh Parashar
Shimla, May 31

IN A major political setback for the ruling Congress in Himachal Pradesh, the BJP emerged victorious in three of the four municipal corporations that went to polls, strengthening the Opposition's position and providing an early indication of the political mood ahead of the 2027 Assembly elections.

The BJP secured clear majorities in the municipal corporations of Solan, Mandi and Dharamshala, while the Congress managed to retain only the Palampur Municipal Corporation. The outcome assumes political significance as each municipal corporation is associated with influential political leaders from both the parties.

Terming the results a hard lesson for the Congress, former CM and LoP Jai Ram Thakur said, "CM Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu tried his best to woo voters in ULB polls by making tall promises but people rejected them." However, Congress leader Naresh Chauhan said the polls involving about 15% of the state's electorate can't determine the broader public mandate.



LoP Jai Ram Thakur and MLA Anil Sharma celebrate after BJP's win in Mandi, Himachal Pradesh, on Sunday. ANI

Accepting Congress's defeat in three Municipal Corporations, CM Sukhu accused the BJP of creating a misleading narrative around the overall outcome of the Urban Local Bodies (ULBs) polls. At his official residence Oak Over, Shimla, Sukhu said that despite the BJP's victories in three Municipal Corporations, the Congress had emerged stronger in the overall ULB elections by winning 29 out of 53 urban bodies, including one Municipal Corporation. He said the BJP won 21 urban bodies and in three, the Congress and the BJP are on equal numbers.

The CM acknowledged the Congress had failed to meet expectations in the urban body elections, particularly in Solan and Mandi, but asserted that local political dynamics and the influence of sitting legislators played a decisive role. "Municipal Corporation polls are always influenced by the local MLAs. Around 30-40% of the votes in such polls can be attributed to the sitting MLA's influence. Sharp and effective MLAs such as Anil Sharma in Mandi, Sudhir Sharma in Dharamshala and Ashish Butail in Palampur have their own political impact."

Taking a swipe at Jai Ram, Sukhu questioned the BJP's attempt to credit the Mandi victory to the opposition leader. "The BJP won the Mandi Municipal Corporation, but all the credit goes to local MLA Anil Sharma and not Jai Ram Thakur. The influence of late Pandit Sukham still works in Mandi. Anil Sharma is a four-time MLA from Mandi and does not belong to any faction."

In the four Municipal Corporations, 63 wards out of 64 went to poll. BJP won 37 wards, Congress won 23 and Independent candidates won three wards in Solan, Mandi and Dharamshala each. The total voting percentage in the elections was 63.65% on May 17. The complete results of 250 Zila Parishads (District Councils) of the 251 are yet to come.

Meanwhile, political analysts have attributed the Congress victory in Palampur largely to the personal influence and organisational strength of local Congress MLA Ashish Butail. A Congress leader said, "In Palampur, this municipal corporation poll was not Congress versus BJP. It was Ashish Butail versus the BJP."

Press Trust of India
Kottayam, May 31

VICE-PRESIDENT C P Radhakrishnan on Sunday said youngsters would end up following the "cockroach", in a veiled reference to the online satirical platform Cockroach Janta Party, if positive activities and achievements were not reported adequately. He stressed that constructive journalism is essential to guide society and strengthen public confidence.

Speaking as the chief guest at the celebrations marking the 140th anniversary of the Malayalam daily Deepika, Radhakrishnan said positive developments should receive greater attention in the media so that young people are exposed to the right information and role models. "Positive activities should be reported well. Only then will youngsters receive the right information. Otherwise, they will lose interest and end up following the 'cockroach'," he said.

He said that as India marches forward with confidence and aspiration under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the role of responsible media institutions becomes even more



Vice-President C P Radhakrishnan with Kerala Governor Rajendra Viswanath Arlekar and CM V D Satheesan in Kochi on Sunday. PTI

significant. "We want to be the most developed nation by 2047. That cannot be achieved without the contribution of every section of society." He also said he was not against freedom of expression but questioned the tendency to give disproportionate attention to issues that may not stand the test of time.

Apparently referring to the buzz generated by the Cockroach Janta Party, particularly among youngsters, he questioned whether something truly deserved so much attention in a single day. "If something is genuinely good, people will continue to recognise its value after a

week, 10 days, or even a month." "Nobody knows about them. All of a sudden, they are everywhere. That cannot last," he said, while stressing that noble ideas and positive messages should reach every nook and corner of society and contribute to nation-building. He said that the nation's development is not the duty of one single individual, one single party, or one single government. "It is the primary duty of every citizen of this country. So we should not see politics in everything; we should see development in everything. Journalism can play the most important role."

● POWER TRANSITION IN CONGRESS MAY FORCE THE PARTY TO LOOK BEYOND ANTI-INCUMBENCY AS IT PREPARES TO FINALISE ITS STATE LEADERSHIP TEAM WITH THE 2028 ASSEMBLY POLLS IN MIND

The Shivakumar effect: Why BJP may have to rework its Karnataka playbook

CAPITAL CONTEXT BY LIZ MATHEW

A WEEKLY LOOK AT POLITICS IN A STATE FROM THE VANTAGE POINT OF NEW DELHI

THE CONGRESS high command has carried out the transition of power in Karnataka without encountering any hurdles, elevating Doddalahalli Kempegowda Shivakumar as Chief Minister, and in the process appears to have unsettled the NDA and the BJP's political strategies in the state.

The developments in the Congress appear to have forced the BJP to defer the announcement of a new state party president, which has been pending for months.

On Thursday, the party announced new chiefs for Punjab, Haryana, Delhi, and Tripura. A BJP insider said Shivakumar, or DK as he is popu-

larly known, has not yet proven himself as an able administrator. But if he manages to do that in the next couple of years, things could get tricky for the party, he added.

"Among the electorate in the state, he is not known as an able administrator who can deliver good governance. DK, who has an image in Karnataka of a go-getter with his money and muscle power, just has to get his governance right. Nothing else can then hold him back. If he delivers good governance, the NDA will have to go beyond counting on the anti-incumbency factor," said the source.

Since replacing the popular and astute Siddaramaiah, Shivakumar has so far got his optics right. He has not uttered a single word against the high command despite "an undue" delay in keeping its promise to make him the CM after the first

half of the party's term.

With the oath-taking ceremony a couple of days away, the CM-elect will look to ensure his powerful Vokkaliga community, which makes up an estimated 10% of the population, locks in behind the Congress ahead of the 2028 Assembly elections.

BJP leaders said Shivakumar is a successful businessman with a base in Bengaluru and maintains strong bonds and influence over several BJP leaders, including MLAs, from the region.

"How the party will deal with Shivakumar at the top is still to be seen, given the long association many of these leaders have with him," said a former BJP MP.

"The ED had initiated a (money laundering) probe against Shivakumar. The party may have an idea on centring its campaign on the corrupt



Ex-Karnataka CM Siddaramaiah's son Yathindra Siddaramaiah meets CM-designate D K Shivakumar in Bengaluru on Sunday. ANI

image of the government. We have to see how it is going to unfold," the leader said.

The Lingayat challenge

For the BJP, which heavily

banks on the Lingayat vote bank comprising an estimated 11.1% of the population, keeping this support base intact is a challenge as the party has many Lingayat leaders who pull it in different directions,

but none as strong as former CM B S Yediyurappa. While his son and current state BJP president B Y Vijayendra is still waiting for his formal appointment under BJP's new national president Nitin Nabin, another Lingayat leader, Basanagouda Patil Yatnal, has been expelled for six years for anti-party activities.

"Even if Vijayendra is appointed again, transitioning from Yediyurappa to him in the context of keeping the Lingayat votes still has challenges," said a state party leader. Several party leaders say the Congress having a Vokkaliga leader leading it has strengthened Vijayendra's prospects of leading the BJP in Karnataka as the party looks to consolidate its support among Lingayats. But appointing a Lingayat leader as the state chief will also force the party to carefully manage Union Minister Shobha Karandlaje, an articulate and popular Vokkaliga leader.

Karandlaje, who commands a reputation for fearlessness, is no longer considered a leader from the "Yediyurappa camp". Though widely blamed for the BJP's 2023 Assembly poll debacle — having served as the election management committee convener — her political clout ensures she cannot be easily sidelined.

Another challenge for the BJP will be North Karnataka, home to former BJP strongmen, the Bellary brothers, and the Hyderabad-Karnataka belt, where the Congress has traditionally been strong. If the party chooses to appoint a young leader in the state, there will be a struggle with the old leaders who might be fading away but still remain influential.

JD(S) at risk?

Shivakumar's appointment has also dampened, if not dashed, the dreams of BJP ally, Janata Dal (Secular) leader, and

former CM HD Kumaraswamy.

The Union Minister, who shares a good rapport with the BJP's national leadership but has several detractors in the state BJP, harboured hopes of becoming the CM again. He is learnt to have begun attempting to convince the national leadership of the BJP to back him as the NDA's CM candidate. But with Shivakumar at the helm, Kumaraswamy, also a Vokkaliga, faces an uphill battle to get the Vokkaliga community's backing and, as a result, may have a tough time convincing the BJP leadership in Delhi now.

A BJP source said with Shivakumar as CM, there was a chance of the JD(S) imploding as "DK would see to it that there is a flow of leaders and cadre" from the H D Deve Gowda-led party to the Congress. "The JD(S) leadership's biggest task now will be keeping its flock together," the party insider added.





Government of Haryana

A New Chapter in Haryana's Growth Story



“ हरियाणा की डबल इंजन सरकार विश्व स्तरीय अवसंरचना निर्माण के लिए प्रतिबद्ध है। विकसित भारत बनाने के लिए हरियाणा का विकसित होना बहुत ज़रूरी है।”

-Narendra Modi

Haryana is no longer just an agricultural powerhouse.

It is now emerging as a driving force of India's technology, manufacturing and economic growth.

The State Government has introduced 10 policies designed to attract investment, accelerate innovation, and create large-scale job creation.

Launch of the Make in Haryana Policy and other Sectoral Policies

By

Sh. Nayab Singh Saini

Chief Minister, Haryana

In the august presence of

Rao Narbir Singh

Industries Minister, Haryana

June 1, 2026 | 11:00 am | Gurugram

Industrial & Manufacturing Growth Policies

Make in Haryana Industrial Policy

Toys and Sports Equipment Manufacturing Policy

Pharmaceutical and Medical Devices Manufacturing Policy

Digital & Technology Economy Policies

New Haryana Data Centre Policy

Global Capability Centre (GCC) Policy

IT-ITeS, AI and Emerging Technologies Policy

ESDM Policy

Animation, Visual Effects, Gaming, Comics (AVGC-XR) Policy

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Coal dispute: Pregnant Dalit woman dies; BJP seeks probe

Shubham Tigga
Ranchi, May 31

WHAT BEGAN as a dispute over leftover coal collected from a railway siding ended in tragedy in Jharkhand's Bokaro district, where a 25-year-old pregnant Dalit woman died after she intervened in an altercation among local residents, triggering arrests, political allegations and demands for a high-level probe. The incident took place Friday night at Dhaura coal site under Bermo police station limits.

According to police, Anita Devi was among a group of women who had gathered to collect leftover coal from a railway siding area — a common practice among local families who use it for household needs. Investigators said a quarrel broke out over the sharing of the coal, escalating into a physical confrontation. By the time the scuffle ended, Anita Devi had collapsed. She was rushed by family members to the Regional Hospital in Dhori, where doctors declared her dead.

The circumstances surrounding her death are now under investigation. Bermo police station in-charge Rohit Kumar said preliminary findings suggest there was pushing and scuffling during the altercation and that Anita, who was pregnant, fell unconscious during the incident. "Women in the locality regularly collect leftover coal from the siding area for household use. The dispute appears to have started over sharing of the coal," Kumar said. "No visible external injuries have been found so far. The exact cause of death will become clear after medical examination and further probe."

On Saturday, Anita's husband, Mahesh Bhuiyan, filed a police complaint, alleging that the altercation had turned violent. He also claimed that police were attempting to shield those responsible for his wife's death. Following the complaint, police launched raids and arrested six people. In his statement, Mahesh alleged that the dispute originated over the collection and distribution of coal from the railway siding area, which many local residents depend upon for daily use. He also highlighted that Anita was pregnant at the time of the incident. The BJP described the incident as a "brutal murder" and

accused the district administration of attempting to manage the fallout. Party leaders alleged that arrests were made only after they threatened to launch a road blockade in Bokaro. BJP state general secretary Amar Kumar Bauri demanded the arrest of what he termed the "main conspirator", compensation for the victim's family and an inquiry into the conduct of police and medical officials involved in the case. The party has also sought a probe into the role of district authorities and local police in handling the matter. Police, however, have maintained that the incident stemmed from a local dispute.

'RIGHT OF SEX WORKERS WITHOUT RIGHT TO SEX WORK' SC asks govt to make law exempting trafficked sex workers from prosecution

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, May 31

UNDERLINING THAT there can't be a one-size-fits-all approach in the application of the Immoral Trafficking Prevention Act (ITPA) to tackle commercial sexual exploitation (CSE), the Supreme Court has laid out an elaborate 'Victim Protection Plan', securing the rights of "voluntary" sex workers, and called upon the government to consider amending the law to exempt trafficked victims from being prosecuted for prostitution. It also sought that the new law protects the victims from "sexual abuse" by police personnel when in custody.

A bench of Justices J B Pardiwala and R Mahadevan, which exercised powers under Article 142 of the Constitution, said in its May 29 judgment that the plan which details "the manner in which preventive, protective and rehabilitative measures are to be taken to safeguard the fundamental rights of the victims of trafficking for CSE...would hold the field until the Parliament enacts a law on the subject". The court noted that "rights of sex workers can exist without there being a right to sex work".

The 297-page judgment sought to distinguish those trafficked for prostitution from adults who indulge in it "voluntarily" and said that "by conflating prostitution and trafficking", the Act as it stands processes "those trafficked against their will...those who were trafficked but continue voluntarily..." and "those who have chosen sex work for themselves...through the same mechanism under Section 17, without differentiation."

It said that "ITPA's failure to accord rights and protections to" the latter "combined with the deep social stigma attached to sex work, results in voluntary adult sex workers being iso-

lated, marginalised, and unable to access protections that the law extends to them".

Writing for the bench, Justice Pardiwala said, "The larger society's view of sex work is deeply rooted in moral judgment... This attitude is perhaps most starkly reflected in the deeply derogatory terminology that continues to be used in common parlance in Hindi and English to describe voluntary adult sex workers. The consequences of this stigma are severe and far-reaching."

The new plan, with an emphasis on dignity and human rights, says, "Victims shall not, at any stage, be treated as criminals or subjected to measures associated with criminal liability."

The court said that "for victims trafficked for CSE, the crime violates their right to live with dignity directly, i.e., it commodifies, impoverishes, and stigmatises. But the absence of dignity also precedes the crime, i.e., lack of access to minimum material necessities, is predominantly what makes victims vulnerable to traffickers in the first place."

A one-size-fits-all approach, applied to the heterogeneous group of 'victims of trafficking for CSE', is unlikely to serve their interests properly. In fact, it might lead to unintended consequences.

The court laid down that when sex workers are produced before a Magistrate, he or she "must conduct an initial threshold inquiry into whether the person before him is a voluntary adult sex worker who does not wish to be subjected to long term safe custody".

"Where the victim clearly and unequivocally states that she is engaging in prostitution voluntarily and does not wish to be placed in long-term safe custody...the Magistrate shall pass an order directing a preliminary inquiry into whether her engagement in prostitution is voluntary in nature," the court said.

Explaining why the magistrates should have the option of placing the victim under custody upon investigation, the bench said, "It is a known fact that traffickers exercise deep and pervasive control over their victims through...physical force, psychological manipulation, coercion, and sustained intimidation," adding that the victim's consent may be exploited in such cases.

The court pointed out that "the legal infrastructure addressing human trafficking for the purposes of CSE in India is broad but fragmented, comprising multiple statutory instruments" and called upon the government to come out with a "separate and comprehensive legislation on trafficking, one that addresses not only trafficking for CSE but all other forms of exploitation".

It referred to the "continued prevalence of instances of abuse and reports indicating the complicity of police officers in the crime of trafficking" and urged the government to create a specific offence where police officers "compel" or "seduce" a victim in their charge or custody to "illicit sexual intercourse", and a rebuttable presumption that a police officer who "delays" the production of a rescued victim before a magistrate has "wrongfully confined her".

The court also laid down elaborate procedures for police raids to rescue victims including that "no person shall be abused either verbally or physically" and "the manner in which the persons are rescued must not involve elements of unnecessary physical force or manhandling".

The court further added, "The members of the rescue team shall endeavour...to identify whether the persons intended to be rescued are voluntary sex workers or not..."

"It must be ensured that while photography and videography of the rescue site is done, the victims are excluded."

SALUTE THE SOLDIER



family fondly remembers Sub Rajinder Kumar (DODA SAHAB) who left us for his heavenly abode on this date of 01 Jun 2024.

COMMANDING OFFICER & ALL RANKS

14 DOGRA



BORDER SECURITY FORCE
CONSTABLE ASHOK KUMAR MALHOTRA
68 BN BSF
02.03.1971 - 01.06.1994

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Constable Ashok Kumar Malhotra on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal injuries in an IED Blast triggered by militants in area of Doda, J&K and made supreme sacrifice in the line of duty.



CONSTABLE CHANDRMA SINGH
132 BN BSF
15.01.1967-01.06.1990

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Constable Chandrma Singh on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal bullet injuries during a counter terror operation in area of Naugam, J&K and made supreme sacrifice in the line of duty.



CT DEEPAK SINGH
182 BN BSF
03.03.1991-01.06.2012

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Constable Deepak Singh on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained grievous bullet injuries in cross border firing in area of BOP Regal, Jammu and later succumbed to his injuries at GMCH Jammu.



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e-Procurement Tender Notice (Paper Notification)

TGSPDCL intends to float tenders for Supply and Installation of materials required for Implementation of Auto Reclosure functionality in IED relays of 11kV OH Feeders in Metro Zone area of the TGSPDCL on e-procurement platform. For further details of above, please visit <https://tgspowerpower.org> and www.telangana.gov.in

Phone:- 040-23431321 Sd/-
R.O. No.: 3294/PCCL/ADVT/2026-27, Date:- 30-05-2026 CHIEF ENGINEER (PROJECTS)



UJVVN Ltd.
(An Uttarakhand Govt. Enterprises)
H.O. "UJJWAL" Maharani Bagh, GMS Road, Dehradun-248006
Telephone: 0135-2763809 Fax: 0135-2763508
CIN No. U40101UR2001SGC025866 Website: www.ujvvn.com

RO No. 461 NOTICE INVITING TENDER Date: 30.05.2026

Office of the Executive Engineer, PCMC(GV), Mayapur, Haridwar invites sealed & separate tender from interested bidders. Brief summary of tender is given below:-

- Tender Notice Reference:** NIT No.- 08/2026-27/EE/PCM(GV)/Mayapur.- Works Related to Roof Leakage Treatment of Type IInd Qtrs (Club Side) at Chilla.
- Estimated Value of Tender:-** Rs. 24.98,699.19 only, excluding GST.
- Date of availability of bid document on website:-** 30.05.2026 from 13:00 Hrs.
- Last Date for Submission of Tender:-** 20.06.2026 upto 13:00 Hrs.

For eligibility criteria and full and further details kindly visit our website. The tender can be downloaded from our website i.e. <http://ujvvn.com> and tender cost shall be paid at the time of submission of the tender.

Executive Engineer, PCM (GV),
Mayapur, Haridwar

"AVOID WASTEFUL USE OF ELECTRICITY"

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita-2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Mohd. Azeem, S/o Abdul Sutar, R/o J-1234/48, Gali No. 7, Jafrabad, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 63/2021, U/s 394/397/114/34 IPC, P.S. Civil Lines, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Mohd. Azeem** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Mohd. Azeem** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Mohd. Azeem** accused of **FIR No. 63/2021, U/s 394/397/114/34 IPC, P.S. Civil Lines, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **11.07.2026**.

By Order - **Sh. Abhishek Goyal**
Additional Session Judge-03, Central
Room No. 143, Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DP/6935/N/2026

Classifieds

PERSONAL

I,CHITRANSHI,D/o CHETAN GUPTA,ADD M-62, 3RD FLOOR,ABOVE MAIN ROAD,SAKET, New Delhi-110017,have changed my name to CHITRANSHI GUPTA

0040858096-1

I,BALDEV RAO,F/o KUMAR AJEY resident of H.No-118,VPO-SIRISIYA, Police Station-Bhairoganj,West Champaran,Bihar-845101,have changed my name,from BALDEV RAO to BALDEO RAO,vide affidavit, dated.30/05/2026

0040858096-2

I, SUMITRA JAUNSARI alias SUMITRA VERMA W/o LATE RATAN SINGH JAUNSARI, R/o 42, Inder Road, Dalanwal, Dehradun G.P., Chakrata, Dehradun, Uttarakhand-248001, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as SUMITRA VERMA.

0071039105-1

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SITUATION VACANT

OTHERS

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GOVERNMENT OF MADHYA PRADESH
DIRECTORATE OF URBAN ADMINISTRATION AND DEVELOPMENT DEPARTMENT
6 NO., BUS STOP, SHIVAJI NAGAR, BHOPAL, M.P.

N.I.T./No./07/2026/ 7737 Dated 26-05-2026

Notice Inviting Tender (NIT) (Second Call)

Urban Administration & Development Department invites online bids from eligible and experienced agencies for empanchment of Trenchless Technology Agencies for execution of water & sewerage and underground utility works.

The bid document shall be available online from 27.05.2026, and bids must be submitted on or before 11.06.2026 in accordance with the terms and conditions of the RFP available on the e-procurement portal and NIT/Tender ID is .

The Tender details are as follows-

Work Name	Earnest Money	Cost of Bid Document (Inr)	Duration
Empanchment of Trenchless Technology Agencies for execution of sewerage and underground utility works.	Deposit (EMD) 1,50,000/-	10,000/-	The empanchment shall be valid for 1 year, extendable up to 1 year based on performance.

Note:

- Interested bidders may view the RFP on the website www.mptenders.gov.in.
- The Bid Document shall be available only online from 27.05.2026 to 11.06.2026.
- Pre Bid meeting date 02.06.2026
- Any amendments / corrigendum to the NIT, if issued, shall be published only on the website and shall not be published in newspapers.

(Pradeep S. Mishra)
Engineer in Chief
Urban Administration & Development Department, Bhopal, M.P.

G-13709-26

OFFICE OF THE PRINCIPAL P.K.S. GOVERNMENT COLLEGE KANINA, (MAHENDERGARH) HARYANA

Tender notice for security of premises (Chowkidar) and horticulture work

Sealed tender is hereby invited on contract basis (for Security of premises (Chowkidar) and Horticulture work) services in P.K.S. Government College Kanina from the interested and eligible Cooprtive L & C societies (approved by Govt. of Haryana) having at least three years' experience in similar services in prescribed form. Interested service agencies can collect tender forms from the Office of Principal, P.K.S. Government College Kanina on any working day between 09:00 AM to 02:00 PM by paying Rs. 500/- (Payable through demand draft/ Banker cheque of any nationalized bank drawn in Favour of Principal P.K.S. Government College Kanina). All terms and conditions will be attached with the form.

Last dated of receipt of sealed tender document: 09-06-2026
Date of Opening of tender: 11.06.2026

Sd/-
Principal
P.K.S. Government College Kanina



कार्यालय अधीक्षण अभियन्ता, यांत्रिक मण्डल, उत्तराखण्ड पेयजल संसाधन विकास एवं निर्माण निगम, हरिद्वार, उत्तराखण्ड- 249401 फोन: 01334- 292995 Email: semchharidwar@gmail.com

पत्रांक : 90 /निविदा / 22 दिनांक : 30.05.2026

ई-निविदा सूचना

निम्नलिखित कार्यों हेतु अहं फर्मों से ई-निविदा पोर्टल www.uktenders.gov.in पर निम्न विवरणानुसार आमंत्रित की जाती है:-

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2	जनपद पौड़ी गढ़वाल की बैरवगढ़ी पंपवे०योजना में ऑन ग्रिड सोलर प्लांट अधिष्ठापन कार्य।	2950.00	78000.00	06 माह
3	जनपद पौड़ी गढ़वाल में उत्तराखण्ड पेयजल निगम के कार्यालय यांत्रिक शाखा कोटद्वार में ऑन ग्रिड सोलर प्लांट अधिष्ठापन कार्य।	3540.00	98000.00	06 माह
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6	जनपद पौड़ी गढ़वाल की घुडदीड़ी पंपवे०योजना में ऑन ग्रिड सोलर प्लांट अधिष्ठापन कार्य।	2360.00	57000.00	06 माह
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8	जनपद पौड़ी गढ़वाल की सबदरखाल पंपवे०योजना में ऑन ग्रिड सोलर प्लांट अधिष्ठापन कार्य।	5900.00	317000.00	06 माह

- पोर्टल पर ई-निविदा उपलब्ध कराने की तिथि /समय :- 01.06.2026 समय 16:00 बजे तक।
- ई-निविदा को अपलोड करने की अंतिम तिथि /समय :- 15.06.2026 समय 17:00 बजे तक।
- प्री-बिड मीटिंग की तिथि व समय:- दिनांक 04.06.2026 समय 14:00 बजे स्थान: कार्यालय अधीक्षण अभियन्ता, यांत्रिक मण्डल, उत्तराखण्ड पेयजल निगम, हरिद्वार।
- EMD सम्बन्धी प्रपत्र जमा करने की अंतिम तिथि दिनांक - 16.06.2026 समय 17:00 बजे तक।
- तकनीकी बिड खुलने की तिथि /समय :- 17.06.2026 समय 11:00 बजे, स्थान : कार्यालय अधीक्षण अभियन्ता, यांत्रिक मण्डल, उत्तराखण्ड पेयजल निगम, हरिद्वार।

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अधीक्षण अभियन्ता

'Cross-border love': PoK man breaches LoC, now in custody

Bashaarat Masood
Srinagar, May 31

A SOCIAL media romance prompted a 22-year-old resident of Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK) to cross over into the Uri sector of north Kashmir, where he was detained by the Army and handed over to the Jammu and Kashmir Police, sources said. The Army's Srinagar-based Chinar Corps said in a statement on Sunday that an intruder from PoK was "intercepted by alert Chinar warriors while crossing the Line of Control in Uri sector".

"The vigilant troops maintained restraint while challenging the intruder and surgically apprehended the individual," it said. Sources identified the man as 22-year-old Zeeshan Ahmad, a resident of Rankeri village of Haveli Kahuta in PoK. He was detained near Silikote, a border village of Uri in Baramulla district. Sources said that during preliminary questioning, it was revealed that he crossed the LoC to meet a woman from a border village in Uri with whom he had developed a romantic relationship. They purportedly connected through social media and fell in love, sources said.

"They first met through social media and developed a love affair. It was during their routine talks that he told her about his problems and family disputes," said a source, adding, "The girl advised him to escape the problems by crossing over into J&K and settling here."

As per sources, the woman had advised Ahmed to cross the LoC and surrender to the Indian Army so that he gets a lenient punishment. "She told him that once the punishment period is over, he can settle in the Valley," sources said. The woman was also called in for questioning to corroborate Ahmed's version of events. Sources said the woman corroborated his story.

While prima facie, it appears to be a case of cross-border love, sources said, authorities were probing all possibilities: "The Army, together with police, are trying to find out if the love story is a cover-up for something else."

MANN KI BAAT

‘You’ll bring glory to the country’: PM praises sprinters Gurindervir, Kujur

Express News Service
New Delhi, May 31

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi praised sprinters Gurindervir Singh and Animesh Kujur, both of whom broke the national record in the 100-metre race thrice at the recent National Senior Athletics Federation Competition in Ranchi, and also interacted with them in his monthly Mann Ki Baat radio programme on Sunday.

“Just a few days ago, the National Senior Athletics Federation Competition was held in Ranchi, Jharkhand. Nearly 800 athletes participated in it – from all over the country. During this, four national records were broken in four different events. Gurindervir Singh, Vishal TK, Tejaswin Shankar, Dev Meena, and Kuldeep Kumar... These friends set new records in different categories. First of all, I congratulate all of them,” the Prime Minister said.

“Friends, one event that is being widely discussed across the country is the 100-metre race. Within just two days, the national record in the men’s 100-metre race was broken three times. The two athletes who achieved this feat are Gurinder Singh and Animesh Kujur. I thought I’d talk to these two athletes this time on ‘Mann Ki Baat.’

The PM said, “The competi-

tion you’ve participated in is to enhance the nation’s prestige, to take the country to this position in the future, and done with a positive spirit. And I believe that this sportsman spirit of yours... to play, also to challenge each other, also to strive to get ahead, and to help each other to move ahead – this is a wonderful job you’ve done. My heartfelt congratulations to you, my best wishes, and you’ll bring glory to the country...”

Modi also recounted his recent visit to the Netherlands, adding that ancient copper plates from the Chola period were returned to India during this visit. “Recently I had the opportunity to visit the Netherlands in Europe. I attended several meetings there. During this time, a moment arrived that filled every Indian with pride. In a special ceremony held in the Netherlands, ancient copper plates from the Chola period were returned to India. The Prime Minister of the Netherlands was also present at the event. I have been receiving continuous messages from India and abroad regarding these copper plates. People are sharing joy and expressing pride.”

“The Tamil community around the world is also particularly enthusiastic about this,” he said.

‘Encroached India land’: Nepal PM triggers a row

Shirish B Pradhan
Kathmandu, May 31

NEPAL PRIME Minister Balendra Shah on Sunday said he has learnt about his country “encroaching” territories in India, as he sought to answer questions in parliament on a long-running border dispute and instead triggered a controversy.

In his maiden appearance in the parliament session that started May 11, Shah also said India and Nepal have agreed to take the help of historians, surveyors and experts to seek a resolution, adding that Kathmandu has also taken up the matter with China and the UK.

Hours later, Nepal Foreign Ministry said the PM’s comments were related to “no-man’s land encroachments” and “cross-border occupation” between the two countries, rather than any territorial claims.

Nepal and India have had an old boundary dispute over Lipulekh, Limpiyadhura and Kalapani, with both countries claiming the areas. India maintains that the territories are part of Uttarakhand and has said



Nepal PM Balendra Shah

the issue should be addressed through bilateral dialogue.

There was no immediate response from India on Shah’s comments but earlier this month, while rejecting Nepal’s objection to the Kailash Mansarovar Yatra through the long-established Lipulekh Pass, it had dismissed Kathmandu’s territorial claims over the region as an “unilateral artificial enlargement” that New Delhi finds “untenable”.

On Sunday, Shah said: “The Nepal government has officially sent a diplomatic note to India, mentioning the issue of encroachment of territories by India, including Lipulekh, and we have already received their

response. Both the countries have agreed to resolve the issue sitting together with the help of historians, surveyors and concerned experts through diplomatic means.” When specifically asked by a lawmaker about the government’s view on the dispute concerning the Limpiyadhura, Lipulekh and Kalapani areas, Shah said: “You will be surprised to know about a fact, which I learnt recently, only after becoming the PM. It is not only India that has encroached Nepalese territories, but Nepal has also encroached India’s territories in many places. Now both countries should study facts and sit together as friends and resolve the issue.”

The three places are located near the trijunction of India, Tibet and Nepal. Shah said Kathmandu has also taken up the matter with China and the UK. He said he raised the matter with the UK because it dates back to a period when the British left the region.

His comments about Nepal encroaching Indian territories triggered a controversy with opposition lawmakers, includ-

ing Basana Thapa of the Nepali Congress and Ramesh Malla of the Nepali Communist Party, demanding that they be expunged from the parliamentary record. They said the PM should either provide evidence to support his claim or withdraw the statement. Former Nepal Ambassador to India Nilambara Acharya told Kantipur online media portal that Shah has “no information regarding Indian territories being encroached by Nepal.”

Asserting that Nepal’s current border is based on the Sugauli Treaty of 1816, Nepal’s Foreign Office said, “Limpiyadhura, Lipulekh and Kalapani and Susta in Nepal-India border area are territories that remain to be demarcated.”

“There are problems relating to cross-border occupation and no-man’s land (Dasgaja) encroachments in some other areas besides these. What the Prime Minister mentioned in Parliament was related mainly with Dasgaja encroachment and cross-border occupation,” the Foreign Ministry spokesperson said in a statement. PTI

CBSE: Monitoring vulnerabilities flagged in portal

Express News Service
New Delhi, May 31

THE CENTRAL Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) said on Sunday that it is “closely monitoring the vulnerabilities” that have been flagged in the On-Screen Marking (OSM) portal that was used for the class 12 exam this year.

It said an expert team of cybersecurity professionals has been deployed to fortify its systems.

“We have been closely monitoring the vulnerabilities in the OnMark portal of our service provider that are being flagged in the public domain. An expert team of cybersecurity professionals has been deployed over the last few days from across various arms of the government as well as the ITs to fortify these systems, including taking them over to a more secure set up. The identified vulnerabilities have been contained, and other exploitable weaknesses are being ruled out,” the Board said in a statement on Sunday.

“We are grateful to all alert citizens and ethical hackers pointing out such weaknesses, and have gotten in touch with some of them directly.”

Last week, after a social media user on X said that they were able to hack the OSM portal in February, the Board had maintained that the portal was not compromised and that no security breach has come to light on the portal used for evaluation. The CBSE had said then that the portal the user was referring to was only used for testing, and not for the actual evaluation process.

BRIEFLY



Police personnel rescue pilgrims in Champawat on Sunday. PTI

UTTARAKHAND

SDRF rescues over 50 pilgrims from swollen river in Champawat

A TRAGEDY was averted at Sri Reetha Sahib Gurdwara in Uttarakhand’s Champawat Sunday after over 50 pilgrims, trapped in a swollen river during the annual Jod Mela, were rescued. SDRF personnel had been deployed at the fair venue in advance, keeping in view the heavy rush of pilgrims and weather conditions, officials said. Over 50 pilgrims, bathing at the confluence of Ladihya and Ratiya rivers before heading to the gurdwara for *darshan*, were trapped in the middle of surging waters. All of them were evacuated safely and no casualties were reported, SDRF Commandant Arpan Yaduwanshi said, adding that the advance deployment helped them ensure a swift response. PTI

Man held for installing camera in washroom

A JUNIOR revenue assistant in the District Rural Development Agency (DRDA) in Odisha’s Jagatsinghpur, Sanjay Adhek (35), was arrested Saturday for allegedly installing a spy camera in the women’s washroom of the office, police said Sunday. Adhek had allegedly installed the spy camera inside the washroom in March with the “ill intention of capturing private activities of the office’s women employees,” Jagatsinghpur SP Ankita Kumar Verma said. Further probe is underway. PTI

UP: Two youths die after being run over by train

TWO YOUTHS died after being hit by a train on the Deoria-Gorakhpur rail section in Uttar Pradesh’s Deoria Sunday, police said. During the probe, police recovered packets of suspected cannabis from Kishan (18) and an unidentified man (around 24 years). Based on this, police suspect that the two youths were sitting on the railway track consuming intoxicants when they were struck by the train. Police said further probe is on to ascertain circumstances leading to the incident. PTI

Noida engineer missing near Pindari Glacier, rescue efforts underway

His camera found on riverbank after he told porter to go ahead: Officials

Aiswarya Raj
Dehradun, May 31

A 36-YEAR-OLD man from Noida has gone missing while on a trek from Pindari Glacier in Bageshwar district of Uttarakhand, police said.

Rescue personnel, including from the State Disaster Response Force (SDRF), have been conducting search and rescue operations since Friday, when Abhishek Chauhan, an engineer, went missing.

His camera was found on the banks of the Pindar River, which flows in the area, rescue officials said.

He was accompanied by a porter and was returning to Khati, the last village on the Pindari Glacier trek. The trek takes eight days and the glacier is at an altitude of 3,800 metres above sea level. According to Circle Officer Ajay Sah, Chau-

han had told the porter to go ahead, but failed to reach the scheduled meeting point.

“He said he had to capture a few pictures and would meet him (the porter) at the Maggi point a few kilometres ahead. When the porter could not find Chauhan, he searched the area. As hours passed, the porter informed the police on Friday evening,” said Sah.

The rescue effort has been conducted in a 9-km radius over the last two days. A drone has been deployed to scan the area, where multiple spots remain inaccessible. SDRF Commandant Arpan Yaduwanshi said that a team of 15 personnel was dispatched to the area. The operation had to be called off on Saturday due to heavy rainfall and inclement weather.

“A team was deployed along the Pindar River, and they found his camera on the banks of the river. We have been searching for him along the banks. The weather remains adverse, rendering it difficult to sustain the rescue operation. One team each from the forest (department) and police have also been searching the area,” Yaduwanshi said.



Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi interacts with a group of students in Delhi, Sunday. PTI

CBSE ROW: RAHUL MEETS STUDENTS, TAKES DIG AT GOVT

‘Revealing chat with fellow anti-national Soros agents’

Express News Service
New Delhi, May 31

LOK SABHA Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi on Sunday targeted the Centre over the CBSE On-Screen Marking (OSM) row, and put out a video of his interaction with a group of students, describing them as brave young Indians who asked the Modi government simple questions but received “insults instead of answers”.

Asserting that the students deserved a bright future, Gandhi said: “We will make sure they get it.” Posting the video on social media, Gandhi described the interaction as a “revealing chat with my fellow ‘anti-national Soros agents.’” “Vedant and his friends are brilliant, brave young Indians who asked CBSE and the Modi government simple questions — but got insults in-

stead of answers,” Gandhi said in his post on X, with the video of his interaction.

Vedant, a Class 12 student, had alleged on social media that the answer script uploaded to him by CBSE during the verification process was not his own. He claimed the handwriting, answers, and even attempted questions did not match with what he had written in the examination hall. His posts went viral, prompting widespread scrutiny over the CBSE’s evaluation and OSM systems.

Gandhi is seen having an informal chat with Vedant and other students about their experiences. He also joked about how they were labelled “Pakistanis” and “deep state agents” after raising what he called legitimate concerns and issues.

“You are students. You are asking for your answer sheets,

that’s all. Now, suddenly, you have become anti-nationals. You have to accept the problem if you have to solve the problem. You are refusing to accept the problem and blaming the poor kids and saying ‘you are deep state, you are spies, terrorists,’” Gandhi says in the video, attacking the government over the OSM controversy. “Were you also called terrorists? Tell me!” Gandhi asks Vedant, his brother and some other students in the 90-second clip, apparently part of a larger interaction.

During the interaction, Gandhi also jokes and tells the cameraperson: “Bhaiyya, show the faces of these ‘terrorists!’” After allegations on social media, the CBSE had clarified that its OSM portal was not compromised, and no security breach has come to light on the portal that was used for evaluation.

‘He is a drug addict’: Family of Mumbai man accused in Pak-linked terror module

Manish Kumar Pathak
Mumbai, May 31

“THEY THOUGHT it was easy money. They never imagined the matter would escalate to this level,” claimed a neighbour of Sajid Shaikh alias Arbaz Khan, one of the eight people arrested by the Delhi Police Special Cell for allegedly being part of a terror module linked to Pakistan’s intelligence agency ISI and a Pakistani gangster.

Investigators allege the network was run by Shahzad Bhatti, a Pakistan-based social media influencer who built a following through religious commentary and nationalist videos under the “333” banner, and who Indian agencies believe has been attempting to expand his network in India by radicalising unemployed youth and offering financial inducements to carry out terror-related activities.



The locality where Sajid Shaikh stayed. EXPRESS

Tauqeer Shaikh from Mumbai in Thane district are among those arrested in the case. Their relatives, however, insist the two had no intention of carrying out terror activities and were drawn into the racket through online contacts offering money transfers.

Sajid Shaikh’s maternal uncle said Sajid had struggled with drug addiction for years and had been thrown out of the

house around four months ago because of his substance abuse.

Tauqeer Shaikh’s family earlier lived in Kurla (East) before shifting to Mumbai a few years ago. A neighbour said Sajid and Tauqeer had known each other for several years and would often meet.

Sajid lost his father at a young age, while his mother died of tuberculosis around six years ago. Following her death, he stayed

with his grandmother in a rented house near the Burma railway track in the Nehru Nagar area of Kurla (East).

Speaking to *The Indian Express*, Sajid’s maternal uncle Iqbal Shaikh said, “Arbaz had developed a drug addiction at a very young age when he was around 15-years old. In an effort to help him overcome the habit, I admitted him to a de-addiction centre in Titwala. He was there for almost four months but the treatment did not yield any significant improvement.”

When Sajid’s grandmother passed away, he returned for her last rites but never went back to the rehabilitation centre.

“My sister was suffering from tuberculosis. Before her death, she asked me to take care of her son. That is why I sent him to the de-addiction centre and spent money on his treatment. But when there was no improvement, I gradually lost hope,” his uncle said.

2 weeks after launch, Halwara airport suffers damage during heavy rain; inquiry ordered

Divya Goyal Gopal
Ludhiana, May 31

THE NEWLY operationalised, Halwara civil terminal (Ludhiana airport) sustained structural damage after heavy rains and thunderstorm lashed the city on Saturday, just two weeks after the first flight commenced on May 15.

The Punjab government’s Public Works Department (PWD), that supervised the construction of the terminal building has blamed “strong winds and thunderstorm” for damage and said that immediate repairs were ordered to ensure passenger safety.

The terminal building was constructed by PWD hired private company M/S Synergy Thrislington, based in Himachal Pradesh. The company deals in pre-fabricated steel buildings. The total cost of Halwara airport project was Rs 54 crore, of which Rs 22.50 crore



Sections of false ceiling and roof panels came off after heavy rain

were spent on terminal building and the rest on tarmac area, parking etc. The airport became operational on May 15, when Air India commenced its inaugural flight service between Halwara and Delhi.

The infrastructural damage to the building came to light on Sunday after passengers and airport staff noticed water leaking from multiple points, along with sections of the false ceiling and roof panels coming off fol-

lowing the heavy downpour.

However, Airport Director Jagir Singh confirmed that no passengers or staff members suffered injuries and that immediate repair work was underway. “Heavy rain and thunderstorms continued throughout the day Saturday, leading to some minor infrastructural damage. Immediate repairs are being executed. The water leakage occurred after a section of the false ceiling was

compromised,” he said.

Ludhiana Deputy Commissioner Himanshu Jain said, “I have ordered an inquiry by the Additional Deputy Commissioner (Jagraon) to assess the extent of the damage. Immediate repairs have been mandated to ensure passenger safety.”

Speaking to *The Indian Express*, PWD executive engineer Pardeep Kumar, who supervised the terminal construction, said that the building has not suffered any damage. “It is in good condition and functioning in a satisfactory way. Yesterday, during heavy rain, one aluminium sheet on the outer facade of the building got loose. The matter was immediately brought to the notice of airport authorities as the operation and maintenance contract is already in force. The PWD contractor and departmental staff immediately visited the site and rectification work has already been initiated.”





Austerity is needed, but energy security requires breaking silos in government



OVER THE BARREL
BY VIKRAM S MEHTA

THE PM has issued a clarion call for energy austerity. This is timely because even when the Straits of Hormuz reopen, India will continue to face elevated energy prices and supply uncertainty. World-wide, stocks of crude oil and petroleum products have been depleted. These will have to be replenished. Eight refineries in the Persian Gulf and Qatar’s Ras Laffan LNG terminal have been damaged.

This will keep the petroleum market tight. In addition, while a “no war-no peace” scenario (like the relationship between North Korea and South Korea, or the current ties between India and Pakistan) may continue indefinitely, India cannot discount the possibility of miscalculation, misadventure, and/or misunderstanding triggering a violent rupture.

The PM’s call does, however, raise several questions. Who, other than the PM, has the executive mandate within our administrative and institutional set-up to put flesh on his directive? Who will define the targets to be achieved? Who will highlight the cross-cutting linkages within the energy sector (petroleum, coal, renewables, power, nuclear) and between energy and other economic sectors (fertiliser, food, water, environment, semiconductors, heavy industry) to ensure a “whole-of-system” approach to the management, monitoring, and evaluation of

energy policy and security?

The answer is no one. There is no individual or institution with executive authority over energy. Some years ago, I proposed that the government revert to the *status quo ante* of 1992 and establish a Ministry of Energy, with the Minister ranked alongside the Ministers of Defence, Home, Finance, and External Affairs as one of the senior-most members of the cabinet. I suggested that the current cabinet-level ministries of petroleum, coal, renewables, and power be subsumed under this ministry.

This suggestion had no takers, possibly because it was politically infeasible. With 23 political parties in the coalition government, all of whom had to be accommodated, a proposal that reduced the size of the cabinet was never likely to gain traction. Today, this is no longer a constraint. The proposal could therefore be brought back to the table. I would suggest that NITI Aayog be directed to lead a discussion on the subject.

That said, I recognise that administrative and institutional change is never easy. Powerful vested interests must be navigated. A second-best option would, therefore, be for the PM to create a “Department of Energy Resources and Security” (DERS) within the Prime Minister’s Office, headed by a cabinet-ranked official and staffed by a multidisciplinary cadre of skilled specialists.

The purpose would be to supplement, not duplicate or dilute, the responsibilities of the existing energy-related ministries. They would continue “as is”. There would be no change to the present administrative structure. Specifically, I would recommend that DERS be vested with executive responsibility for the following five functions.

First, to provide a platform for a

The government should consider enacting an ‘Energy Responsibility and Security Act’ that defines the roles and responsibilities of every citizen in securing energy ‘atmanirbharta’ and sustainability

“whole-of-system” integrated approach to energy policy planning, implementation, monitoring, and evaluation (*à la* the Chief of Defence Staff). Most importantly, it should identify, study, and evaluate intra-energy and energy-non-energy economic, social, and environmental linkages to ensure efficiency of use, supply resilience, competitiveness, and decarbonisation.

Second, to ensure symmetry of investment across the energy value chain (generation, transmission, storage, distribution). Currently, this requires coordination among multiple ministries at the Centre and between the Centre and states. Lack of symmetry results in avoidable economic loss. According to economist Swaminathan Aiyar, 4 GW of solar energy is stranded in Rajasthan alone because of inadequate evacuation capability. Third, to provide a platform for “India Energy Inc.” to leverage its market power to secure energy at competitive prices, attract risk capital for the development of indigenous energy resources, and forge multilateral and bilateral research and technology partnerships.

Fourth, to serve as the “Energy Ombudsman”. Currently, there are a plethora of energy regulators. All have well-defined roles and responsibilities, but there is overlap and, on occasion, contention. The ombudsman should streamline and standardise energy regulation, particularly in relation to strategic reserves, inter-state wheeling of power, EV charging infrastructure, battery technology, time-of-day pricing, and dispute resolution. It should create a database of energy regulations worldwide, establish a forum for information exchange and best practices, and supervise the development of regulatory talent. Finally, DERS should serve as

the nodal communication point for energy-related matters. Energy is a politically sensitive subject. The PM currently bears the mantle of educating the public on the macroeconomic and cross-cutting ramifications of energy. This responsibility should devolve to DERS.

In this context, the government should consider enacting an “Energy Responsibility and Security Act” that defines the roles and responsibilities of every citizen in securing energy *atmanirbharta* and sustainability, while laying out a roadmap towards these objectives. DERS should take the lead in preparing the first draft.

The ripple effects of the closure of the Straits of Hormuz bring to mind the response economists at the London School of Economics gave Queen Elizabeth when she asked how such a conglomeration of brilliant people had failed to anticipate the economic and financial crisis of 2008. They explained that while “everyone seemed to be doing their own job properly” and “on its own merit”, there was “no one who saw the whole picture” and appreciated that “while individual risks may rightly have been small”, the collective impact of these risks could trigger a systemic collapse.

This answer mirrors the problem of energy policy in India. Those involved with energy appreciate the nature of our energy challenge. They know what must be done. But because each of them has a mandate over only one component of energy policy, they lack a line of sight on the systemic consequences of seemingly “small” failures. This must change. We need to break silos and create a system that enables executive oversight over the totality of energy policy and security.

The writer is chairman and distinguished fellow of the Centre for Social and Economic Progress

Interpreting Harappa, the Shereen Ratnagar way



JAYA MENON

SHEREEN RATNAGAR, who passed away recently, was known for her research centred on the Harappan civilisation. It is not surprising that she chose to work on the trading encounters between West Asia and the Indian Subcontinent in the third millennium BCE, given her training in Archaeology at Deccan College, Pune and the Institute of Archaeology, London, where she specialised in Mesopotamian archaeology. This became the object of her doctoral research at JNU. The book that emanated from her research (*Encounters: The Westerly Trade of the Harappa Civilisation*) was not a mere detailing of goods and objects that were moved between the Harappan region and areas to the west such as Mesopotamia, Bahrain and Oman; rather, the book, and particularly its second edition (*Trading Encounters: From the Euphrates to the Indus in the Bronze Age*), provided a nuanced interpretation of these transactions. In an interview on *harappa.com*, Shereen writes that her focus on the socio-economic and political, in contrast to what other archaeologists at the time in India were writing, was wrought by her training at JNU. It is this focus, towards archaeological context and away from solely concentrating on the object, that lies at the heart of Shereen’s work.

Archaeology in India, till about the 1980s, had largely remained at the documentation stage, in a more cultural-historical frame, with the focus on “filling the gaps” and recovering occupation sequences at various sites. In contrast, Shereen’s life-long work to make sense of what had been, and was being, archaeologically recovered from Harappan sites, pointed to new ways of understanding the data. Her way was to lean heavily on the theoretical and the anthropological, which is interesting given the colonial roots of Archaeology and the strong link the discipline has always had in the Subcontinent with History. In that sense, Shereen’s most significant work is the less well-known *Enquiries into the Political Organisation of Harappan Society*, where she explored the nature of Harappan polity. Her thesis in this book, on a topic that re-

mains contentious, is a riveting one. Shereen’s third book, *The End of the Great Harappan Tradition*, was an attempt to parse the available data on this question and critiqued the standard explanations of Harappan “decline” prevailing at that time.

Shereen also engaged in more public-facing writing. Understanding Harappa was a small but informative book intent on making the Harappan civilisation accessible to most readers. One of her later works, *Makers and Shapers*, looked at everyday technologies like house construction to bring out the labour dimension, and especially the implications for production that took place within households.

Shereen’s uncompromising courage was apparent in her intervention in the Babri Masjid dispute. She joined Professor Dhaneishwar Mandal to dissect a photograph from B B Lal’s 1970s excavation at the Babri Masjid, which aimed to show what were called “pillar bases”. The stratigraphic evidence, which they closely studied, showed that none of these “pillar bases” belonged to a single stratum and, hence, they could not have been part of a single structure. Mandal and Ratnagar were among the few archaeologists to visit the Babri Masjid site and raise questions about the 2003 excavations. In her own words: “No social science proceeds in an ideological vacuum... Being ‘apolitical’, in turn, often amounts to an acceptance of the *status quo*.” Her words continue to be relevant considering the times through which we are currently living.

Shereen’s no-nonsense attitude often filled her students with dread, a feeling I remember all too clearly as her doctoral student. At the same time, during our discussions about chapters over a cup of coffee, it was also visibly clear when an innovative idea or thought of mine would delight her. I recall at the conference that some of us students organised for her Festschrift, the one person who was all set to actively contribute, take notes, and discuss most animatedly was Shereen! That’s how she was.

The writer is a retired professor, Azim Premji University, Bhopal

Safer motherhood begins before pregnancy



BHASKAR PAL

YOUNG WOMEN in urban India today are choosing to delay starting a family in pursuit of careers and stability, yet they are surrounded by anxiety-inducing conversations about fertility and late pregnancies. In contrast, many women in rural settings conceive much earlier but often navigate pregnancy with far less access to a consistent continuum of antenatal and postnatal care. In both cases, the question arises: Are we doing enough to safeguard them by providing a full spectrum of maternal care?

A new study in *The Lancet Obstetrics, Gynaecology & Women’s Health* shows India’s maternal mortality ratio has fallen from 384 deaths per 100,000 live births in 2000 to just 88 in 2023 — one of the steepest declines anywhere in the world. Sustaining that momentum now requires turning our attention to a condition that shapes how safely a woman experiences pregnancy long before she reaches the labour room: Anaemia.

The NFHS-V shows that 57 per cent of women aged 15-49 are anaemic, up from 53 per cent in the previous survey. Anaemia compounds the risks of haemorrhage and infection and can contribute to both maternal deaths and pre-term labour. Iron deficiency accumulates over years. Inadequate dietary diversity and heavy menstrual blood loss deplete iron stores long before a woman becomes pregnant. This is why a life-cycle approach matters. Iron and folic acid supplementation, already embedded in national programmes, must reach women early. Oral iron remains the standard first-line therapy for mild to moderate anaemia because it is accessible, affordable, and effective when taken consistently. However, adherence is difficult, absorption is unpredictable, and for some women there simply is not enough time. A woman diagnosed with severe anaemia at 32 weeks of pregnancy cannot wait three months for her haemoglobin levels to rise through daily tablets. For her — and for women who cannot tolerate oral iron — intravenous iron, particularly a formulation called Ferric Carboxymaltose (IV-FCM), is a critical option.

Postpartum haemorrhage is one of the leading causes of maternal deaths in India. There are, however, proven interventions. The E-MOTIVE bundle, tested across more than 200,000 births in resource-limited settings, reduced severe bleeding outcomes by 60 per cent.

Safer motherhood begins with better nutrition, earlier testing, timely treatment, and a health system that supports women at every stage of life. Collaborative platforms such as the ADHUNA initiative, which brings clinicians together to strengthen provider awareness and share practical tools, demonstrate what becomes possible when knowledge, training, and practice move in the same direction. That effort must now become broader, better coordinated, and sustained so that both public and private healthcare systems can help women enter pregnancy with strength.

The writer is president, Federation of Obstetrics and Gynaecological Societies of India

40 YEARS AGO

June 1, 1986



Plan to bomb plane foiled

A PLOT to blow up an Air India plane, scheduled to leave New York for Delhi, has been foiled with the arrest of five Sikhs in a co-ordinated operation by Canadian and American intelligence services. All the five Sikhs are understood to be members of the hardline Babbar Khalsa group of Talwinder Singh Parmar. They were arrested near Montreal. Informed sources said that all five had “smoking guns”, and the intelligence agencies have irrefutable proof against them.

Venkataramiah panel stays on

THE UNION government has extended the

term of the Venkataramiah Commission till June 10 at the request of the Haryana government. However, this will not come in the way of the transfer of Chandigarh to Punjab on the stipulated date, June 21. The decision to extend the term of the commission was taken at a meeting of the Political Affairs Committee of the Cabinet, presided over by Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi. The decision was taken after hectic lobbying and consultations, on the question of transfer of territories.

Lanka willing to resume talks

SRI LANKA President J R Jayawardene expressed his willingness to send representatives to India to resume the dialogue for

the resolution of the island nation’s ethnic problem. Jayawardene conveyed this to the Indian High Commissioner, J N Dixit, when he called on him prior to his departure for New Delhi to attend the conference of Indian envoys in South and West Asia.

TR Mahalingam dead

THE INCOMPARABLE flautist, T R Mahalingam, known as Mali to music lovers, died in Ambattur at his brother’s residence following a heart attack. He was 59. He is survived by his American wife. He had no children. Mali returned from New Delhi after attending a function held to bring out the Festival of India commemorative album of music the evening before.

Amid rising inflation, RBI cannot neglect growth

THIS WEEK, the Reserve Bank of India’s Monetary Policy Committee will deliberate on fine-tuning its stance on the repo rate — the interest rate at which India’s central bank lends money to commercial banks. Typically, when prices threaten to rise at a rate faster than what the RBI finds prudent, the central bank raises the repo rate to contain inflation. On the face of it, India is facing such a phase, with the war in Iran and the blockade of the Strait of Hormuz keeping the prices of crude oil and other critical imports high. Not surprisingly, inflation has started rising quickly. Wholesale inflation has already crossed the 8 per cent mark, and it’s only a matter of time before its effects filter through as higher retail inflation for consumers. Retail inflation has already spiked to 3.5 per cent after the RBI had brought it down to 2 per cent in the last financial year. Moreover, a weak monsoon could affect the farm sector and raise food prices. Most economists outside the RBI and the government expect retail inflation to rise further to 5 per cent and stay at that level for the rest of the year. Given that the RBI targets a retail inflation rate of 4 per cent, many do not rule out a repo rate hike.

However, the RBI’s choice may not be as straightforward as it seems. For one, the current rise in prices stems from a lack of supply of crude oil and other products. In the short term, there is little that the RBI can do to boost crude oil supplies. Raising interest rates may dampen India’s growth momentum at a time when it needs a more conducive environment. A US-Iran peace agreement, resulting in a swift boost to oil supplies and a quick moderation in oil prices, cannot also be ruled out completely. Also, at 5 per cent, inflation would still be within the RBI’s comfort band of 2 to 6 per cent.

The more important issues to watch this week will be the RBI Governor’s commentary on the state of the economy. Two issues will be of particular interest. One, the rupee’s exchange rate. Does the RBI want to prioritise maintaining an adequate amount of forex reserves and let the rupee find its own level, or is it willing to draw down these reserves to ensure that the rupee doesn’t slide beyond a certain point? Two, what needs to be done for India to attract foreign capital. The RBI’s stance will be keenly watched.

Shereen’s work to make sense of what had been, and was being, archaeologically recovered from Harappan sites, pointed to new ways of understanding the data. Her way was to lean heavily on the theoretical and the anthropological

FREEZE FRAME

BY EP UNNY





India-Oman pact holds promises for farms, factories and small businesses



PIYUSH GOYAL

THE INDIA-Oman Free Trade Agreement that comes into force from June 1 is a defining milestone in Prime Minister Narendra Modi's mission to create global pathways to prosperity for India's students, artisans, women, farmers, fishermen and MSMEs by opening new markets and accelerating job creation.

India has a deep economic and people-to-people connect with Oman, home to nearly 7 lakh Indians, including merchant families whose roots there go back 200-300 years. Indian remittances from Oman amount to about \$2 billion annually, while more than 6,000 Indian enterprises operate there.

The Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) between the two countries significantly deepens economic and strategic ties. It immediately gives 100 percent duty-free market access in Oman to 98 per cent of tariff lines covering 99.38 per cent of exports. This marks a dramatic improvement over the pre-CEPA system that allowed only 15.3 per cent of India's exports enter Oman at zero duty. Goods from India that currently face a 5 per cent import duty in Oman, worth about \$3.64 billion in exports, will become more competitive.

For India's MSMEs, the agreement could be transformative as many sectors that gain from CEPA are dominated by small businesses. Iron and steel, textiles, leather, auto components and industrial equipment are some of the sectors where MSMEs are expected to get large international orders, which will boost production, investment and hiring.

In an era of growing global instability, the CEPA offers Indian exporters a crucial opportunity to diversify markets and reduce dependence on traditional destinations facing economic slowdown and rising trade barriers.

Job creation: The trade pact benefits labour-intensive sectors such as textiles and apparel, leather & footwear, food processing, marine products, gems and jewellery, and select engineering segments, which are major employers in India.

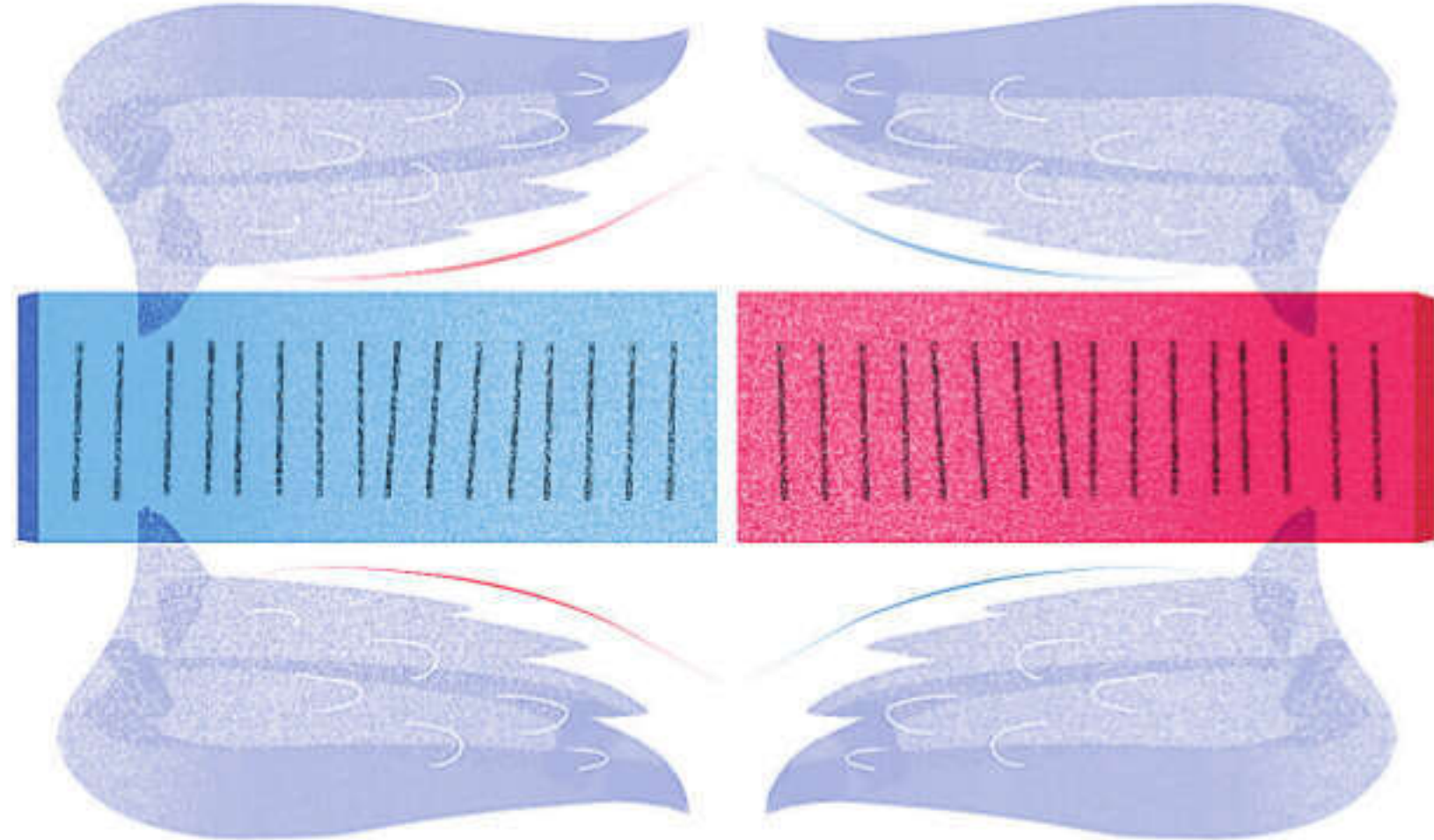


ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

Increased textiles exports to Oman will boost production and create jobs across major clusters such as Tirupur, Surat, Ludhiana, Panipat, Coimbatore, Karur, Bhadohi, Moradabad, Jaipur, and Ahmedabad. Artisans and weavers across India will also gain from higher international demand for their products.

Numerous jobs will also be created in major leather and footwear hubs across India, particularly in Tamil Nadu, Uttar Pradesh and West Bengal as well as parts of Maharashtra, Punjab, Karnataka and Madhya Pradesh among others.

The gems and jewellery sector is another example of how the CEPA will accelerate employment growth. India already has strong capabilities in cut and polished diamonds, gold and silver jewellery, and handmade jewellery production. With tariff barriers removed, Indian exporters will get a decisive competitive edge over European and Asian rivals. The industry estimates that exports to

Oman could grow by as much as USD 150 million over the next three years. This is expected to create substantial employment opportunities in jewellery-making clusters across West Bengal, Tamil Nadu, Maharashtra, Rajasthan, and Gujarat.

Farmers and fishermen: To safeguard domestic farmers and sensitive agricultural interests, India has given no tariff concession for major products such as wheat, rice, maize, millets, dairy, fruits, vegetables, edible oils, oilseeds, tea, coffee and honey.

India will get a competitive advantage over rivals in butter, honey, sweet biscuits, eggs and some confectionary products, which will increase demand for the country's farm produce and boost rural incomes.

The agreement also provides for acceptance and recognition of India's National Programme for Organic Production (NPOP) certification, which will give enormous opportunities to Indian farmers to sell organic output to Oman, which is a major food importer.

Marine products also have huge untapped potential. Oman's imports of marine products was about \$119 million between 2022 and 2024. Imports from India

stood at only \$7.75 million, giving enormous opportunities for Indian seafood exports such as shrimp and frozen cuttlefish. The labour-intensive marine products industry is likely to generate additional jobs in fishing, processing, packaging, cold-chain logistics, and export operations.

Pharma and traditional medicine: Indian medicines approved by regulators such as USFDA, EMA, UK MHRA and TGA will receive automatic marketing authorisation in Oman within 90 days — a major win for Indian pharma exporters.

Significantly, CEPA creates opportunities for India's traditional medicines services. It provides for joint research in traditional medicine.

Services and mobility: Another important dimension of the agreement lies in services and mobility. Oman has undertaken commercially meaningful commitments in sectors of major export interest to India, including professional services, computer and IT services, education, healthcare, tourism, research and development, and environmental services. Indian professionals in areas such as accounting, engineering, medicine, construction, education, and consulting are expected to benefit from improved market access.

Oman has agreed to enhanced mobility commitments for Indian professionals and workers. Intra-corporate transferees and contractual service suppliers will be allowed stays of up to four years, while business visitors and independent professionals will receive easier temporary entry provisions. It has raised the ceiling for intra-corporate transferees from 20 per cent to 50 per cent.

The Modi government's initiatives to sign trade pacts with developed countries is part of the Prime Minister's mission to improve the life of every Indian. The agreement with Oman is a reminder that trade is a powerful instrument of growth, job creation and shared prosperity. In a fragmented and protectionist world, PM Modi is sending a clear message that the new, confident India will not retreat behind walls. It will rise through partnerships, competitiveness and global engagement.

The writer is Union Minister of Commerce and Industry, Government of India

In a fragmented and protectionist world, PM Modi is sending a clear message that the new, confident India will not retreat behind walls

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

A troubling failure

THE DISRUPTION caused by a technical glitch during one of the country's most important entrance examinations is deeply concerning ('Another NTA exam mess: Tech glitches disrupt CUET, retest for over 3,700', IE, May 31). While the NTA and its technology partner have assured that the problem was resolved and compensatory time was provided, the fact that over 3,700 candidates had to be offered a retest reflects the scale of the disruption. Examinations such as CUET determine admission to prestigious universities and shape the academic future of lakhs of students. Any technical failure can cause immense stress and affect performance.

Sanjay Chopra, Mohali

The right precedent

THE TIMELINE spelt out for verdicts — within three months from the date of reserving the order — is a step in the right direction. Under trials continue to languish in jail despite hearings being completed. The Supreme Court's insistence that bail orders be issued on the same day — or at the latest, the next day — is therefore both humane and constitutionally necessary ('Bail to verdict: SC pushes High Courts to speed up justice,' IE, May 30). It is lamentable that over 64 lakh cases are pending in HCs across the country. The latest directions are an attempt to institutionalise discipline within the judicial process.

SS Paul, Nadia

The Quad potential

THE CONTINUANCE of the Quad hinges on the fact that it has forged mechanisms for sustained diplomacy rather than idealistic promises. ('The quiet work that sustains Quad,' IE, May 29) Minilateralism like the Quad survive through political cohesion, adapting to competing priorities of the various member states. Its ability to stay the course is a testament to its collaborative alignment. But skepticism remains about its ability to evolve beyond its current capacity.

Raghvi Sharma, Sunam



R SWAMINATHAN

THERE WAS a great sense of optimism nine days ago when Donald Trump held a summit phone call with Pakistan, Saudi Arabia, Qatar, the UAE, Bahrain, Egypt, and Turkey — and spoke separately with Israel — to announce that a US-Iran MoU was close to being finalised. However, the MoU, now labelled the Islamabad Declaration, continues to hang fire.

Under its provisional framework, Iran will reopen the Strait of Hormuz to pre-war commercial shipping levels within 30 days of signing the MoU, though restrictions will remain in place for military vessels. In return, the US will gradually lift its naval blockade, temporarily suspend oil export sanctions, and pledge comprehensive sanctions relief alongside the unfreezing of Iranian assets upon a final agreement. On the nuclear file, Iran will formally reiterate its commitment to never pursue nuclear weapons. Concessions on this issue will be linked to the US sanctions relief. Notably, the MoU does not include any reference to Iran restricting its missile capabilities or its support for regional proxies.

Trump's announcement about the interim MoU led to rare public backlash from Republicans, who saw it as a premature capitulation that leaves Iran strategically intact. This reaction was expected, given that mainstream Republican criticism of the 2015 Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA) has remained one of the

Trump is now in a worse position than at the start of the war due to the blockade of the Strait of Hormuz

most significant foreign policy battlegrounds of the past decade. To manage the backlash, Trump publicly instructed his negotiators not to rush the final text until they secure a better deal. He framed the MoU as a vehicle to expand the Abraham Accords, declaring it mandatory for Muslim nations involved in the Iran talks to join the Accords — notwithstanding the fact that none of these countries will be in a position to alter their policies until a solution to the Palestinian issue is accepted. The US's limited attacks on southern Iran last Monday and Thursday, along with its green-lighting of Israel's latest major military operations in Lebanon, should also be viewed in this context.

The fact that Iran has not broken off negotiations despite recent US strikes and Israel's massive offensive in Lebanon suggests that Tehran wants to avoid escalation, opting instead to maintain pressure on Washington to accommodate its interests. Iran has the advantage of time. Tehran is operating on the realisation that Trump's military threats lack follow-through. And while it seemed imminent that the MoU would be concluded soon — especially given Trump's statement that he would make his final decision following last Friday's meeting — there has been no movement forward.

Iran is insistent that the war must end on all fronts, including in Lebanon. Despite fierce opposition from Israeli PM Benjamin Netanyahu, Washington is proposing that the 60-

Trump's Iran challenge — to go beyond Obama's deal

day ceasefire extension apply to Lebanon, while explicitly preserving Israel's right to act against immediate threats from Hezbollah. However, Trump is in a weaker bargaining position with Iran than Barack Obama was in 2015. He is now in a worse position than at the start of the war due to the blockade of the Strait. Having altered the maritime status quo, Iran is now positioned to influence both the pace and the content of the peace talks.

Nevertheless, Trump must secure nuclear concessions that go far beyond the original JCPOA parameters. Unlike the sunset clauses of the JCPOA — under which critical restrictions on Iran expired after 10 to 15 years — this baseline requires Iran to accept a complete enrichment moratorium and a subsequent permanent cap. Kazakhstan, already hosting an IAEA low-enriched uranium bank, has emerged as a possible destination for Iran's 60 per cent enriched uranium. At the same time, Washington faces a major impasse over maritime sovereignty, as Iran continues to insist on long-term control of maritime passage through the Strait of Hormuz. In the end, a diplomatic breakthrough is still achievable if both parties accept compromises and secure enough narrative leverage to satisfy their domestic bases.

The writer is former Governor for India at the IAEA, Vienna, former Ambassador to Egypt and former Permanent Representative to the Arab League



deepen substantially. The private sector, including much of the fintech and healthtech built on DPI rails, runs overwhelmingly on foreign cloud. Owning the application layer while renting the infrastructure layer is a form of digital tenancy.

None of this calls for digital isolationism. The question is not whether to engage with foreign digital infrastructure, but how to reduce strategic vulnerability to an acceptable level.

Four levers are available. First, data localisation — requiring sensitive data to reside within Indian territory — is necessary but insufficient if the cloud on which it sits remains foreign-controlled. Localisation must be accompanied by genuine operational sovereignty, including the ability of Indian authorities to audit and, in extreme conditions, take over critical infrastructure. Second, India needs a credible domestic cloud capability. Megh-Raj and emerging Indian data-centre investments are a start; The goal should be ensuring that critical workloads have a sovereign fallback. Third, the DPI substitution logic — which gave India UPI instead of PayPal, and ONDC instead of platform monopolies — must be extended to AI. Indian models for agriculture, health, education and governance are both strategically important and commercially viable. Fourth, India's DPI partnerships with countries across Africa, Latin America, and Southeast Asia lay the foundation of an alternative digital order — one in which the Global South has a collective voice in setting the rules.

India's DPI story is genuinely world-class. But the journey is not complete. Building sovereign application-layer infrastructure while remaining structurally dependent on foreign cloud, foreign AI, and foreign chips is an unresolved vulnerability — one that the Nayara episode previewed and future geopolitical turbulence will test again. The countries that exercise genuine digital sovereignty in 2035 will be those that understood, in time, that sovereignty lives in the infrastructure — and not just in the apps built on top of it.

The writer is the former chairman of TRAI, secretary to the Government of India and CEO of the National Health Authority. Views are personal

From Subbamma's kitchen to Mantralaya

in our family. She managed her household, and through all of it, she kept the dream alive for her daughter.

Before all of us, there was Anna Rajam George. In 1951, her interview board told her the IAS was not for a woman. Her appointment letter added: "In the event of marriage, your service will be terminated." She became the first woman Secretary to the Government of India, built India's first computerised port and received the Padma Bhushan.

Every step forward had to be fought for. The first woman CEO of a zilla parishad was met with "Bai nako", not a woman. The District Collector, always a man's chair from the days of the British, also yielded slowly. The more prominent divisional headquarters postings held out longer still.

I was among the early batches posted to

one such district, Aurangabad, known for severe scarcity, communal tension, and frequent visits by high-profile political dignitaries. On one of my early field visits to Sillod, I found both sides of the road lined with people. When I asked if they had any problem to bring forward, they said: "Nust bagayla alo." We just came to see a woman as a collector. The real question, present on every face, was whether a woman could handle what this district demanded.

Three years later, I returned to Sillod,

The climb is not finished. In every tehsil office and police station, women are still at that early stage, still the first, still proving themselves

eight months pregnant. Those three years had been a war against severe drought. Hundreds of water bodies were desilted through *shram daan*, villagers and district administration working shoulder to shoulder to catch every drop of rain. One of those *talavs* was in Sillod. They had named it Radha Talav. I stood there in the heat of Marathwada, carrying new life, and my eyes filled with gratitude. Not pride. Gratitude. For being accepted.

Women in the IAS grew from 15 per cent in the 1970s to 41 per cent of the 2023 batch. One in five secretary positions in the Government of India is now held by a woman.

This is clearly visible in Maharashtra. In July 2024, the three most senior All India Services posts were simultaneously held by women for the first time in any Indian state's history: Chief Secretary, Director

General of Police, and Principal Chief Conservator of Forests. In March 2026, Ashwini Bhide became the first woman to head the BMC in its 160-year history. Five women Additional Chief Secretaries, seven Municipal Commissioners, and nine Collectors now serve across the state. I am one of the five at Mantralaya.

But the climb is not finished. In every tehsil office and police station, women are still at that early stage, still the first, still proving themselves. The journey from Subbamma's kitchen to Mantralaya was not won based on gender. It was won based on work. That is the only currency that has ever counted. That is the only one that should.

The writer is a serving IAS officer, currently Additional Chief Secretary, GAD Services, Maharashtra

NETANYAHU SAYS ISRAEL WILL TIGHTEN GRIP ON HEZBOLLAH-CONTROLLED AREAS

Israeli forces push deeper into Lebanon; complicates Iran deal

Israel re-captures Beaufort castle after 26 years

Melanie Lidman, Kareem Chehayeb & Cara Anna Tel Aviv, May 31

ISRAELI FORCES are making their deepest incursion inside Lebanon since they withdrew from the country over a quarter-century ago, despite a nominal U.S.-brokered ceasefire and the first direct Israel-Lebanon talks in decades. It's a challenge in the emerging deal to extend the Iran war ceasefire as Tehran wants it to end fighting in Lebanon, too.

On Sunday, Israeli forces seized a symbolic fort in southern Lebanon, Beaufort castle, perched at over 700 meters (3,000 feet) above sea level.

It offers commanding views across Lebanon and into northern Israel.

The site has been a military asset for close to a millennium.

The taking of Beaufort castle, near the city of Nabatieh, followed days of airstrikes and intense fighting in nearby villages between Israeli troops and Hezbollah militants.

Israel says it is targeting the Iranian-backed Hezbollah mili-



Smoke billows following Israeli strikes, as seen from Nabatieh, Lebanon, on Sunday. REUTERS

tant group, which has a strong political presence in southern Lebanon and has launched thousands of missiles and drones at Israeli soldiers in southern Lebanon and at northern Israel.

Israel has warned Lebanese civilians across the south to evacuate or risk being in the line of fire. Lebanese Prime Minister Nawaf Salam on Saturday accused Israel of "implementing a policy of total destruction of cities and towns."

The Israeli military's

Arabic-language spokesperson, Avichay Adraee, posted photographs on X showing Israeli troops walking outside the castle, and Defence Minister Israel Katz wrote on X that they raised an Israeli flag over the castle. Israeli troops previously captured the castle in 1982 and held it until they withdrew from Lebanon in 2000.

"Twenty six years after the withdrawal from the security zone in Lebanon, the Israeli flag has returned to fly on the peaks that overlook the Galilee

towns," Katz said Sunday at a memorial ceremony for Israeli soldiers killed in its previous occupation of southern Lebanon.

Katz said Israel intends to hold the castle as its troops work to destroy thousands more homes that he says were used by Hezbollah and other military infrastructure in southern Lebanon.

On Sunday, Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu noted that Beaufort is "a symbol of a heroic battle for our fighters, but was also a symbol

E. EXPLAINED

The strategic value of Beaufort Castle

Beaufort castle dominates southern Lebanon from a high ridge near the border, giving whoever controls it a clear military view into both Lebanon and northern Israel. Its centuries-long history as a fortress and battlefield also makes it a powerful symbol in the Israel-Hezbollah conflict.

of deep division between us." "The occupation of Beaufort is a dramatic stage and a dramatic shift in the policies we are leading," Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said, citing the military occupation of security zones in Syria, Lebanon and Gaza along Israel's borders.

There was no immediate comment from Hezbollah or the Lebanese government on the Israeli push. Over 3,300 people including dozens of children have been killed in Lebanon since the fighting began on March 2, two days after the Iran war started. About 1 million people have been displaced.

Palestinian man shot and killed at West Bank barrier near Jerusalem

Associated Press Cairo, May 31

A PALESTINIAN man was shot and killed by Israeli forces on Sunday at a concrete barrier separating the occupied West Bank from Jerusalem, the Palestinian Health Ministry said.

The ministry identified him as 26-year-old Imad Haroun Ishtayeh from Salim town, east of Nablus. It said Israeli forces shot him in a thigh in al-Ram town, and he was pronounced dead at the Palestinian Medical Complex in Ramallah.

Footage circulating online showed people carrying his body and climbing down a ladder that had been placed against the wire-topped barrier, while traffic continued to roll by and a horn blared. Israeli police didn't immediately respond about the shooting.

Ishtayeh was apparently attempting to cross from the West Bank to Israel. Many people have been shot trying to cross the barrier, including a 44-year-old father who was killed earlier this month. An increasing number of Palestinians from the West Bank have tried to enter Israel illegally to work in recent years. Tens of thousands of Palestinians had held Israeli work permits, but access was sharply restricted after the attack by Hamas-led militants on southern Israel on October 7, 2023.

• BRIEFLY

LAOS

Heavy rains threaten to delay search for 2 missing in cave



Rescue workers during the operation to free the five trapped. FILE

HEAVY RAINS threatened to delay the search for two people missing in a flooded cave in Laos on Sunday, after the rescue of five other people who were trapped underground for over a week. Finnish diver Mikko Paasi, one of the first international rescuers to arrive at the site, told The Associated Press that rain had filled the cave up to the second chamber, preventing divers from entering the cave until pumps can lower the water level. The seven entered the cave last week to look before being trapped by a flash flood. REUTERS

TURKEY

8 dead, 33 injured after bus crashes, catches fire

A BUS crashed and caught fire in western Türkiye early Sunday, leaving eight people dead, including a 9-month-old baby boy, local media reported. The bus crashed into highway barriers in Denizli province at while carrying 38 passengers and three staff from Izmir to the Mediterranean city of Antalya, the Demiroren News Agency said. Some 33 people were injured in the incident. AP

CHINA

5 killed in illegal mine collapse in Yunnan province

A MINE shaft collapse during an illegal mining operation in China's southwestern Yunnan province killed five people and injured one, state media reported. The incident occurred around 4:30 am on Sunday in Yunnan's Huize County, state news agency Xinhua reported, citing local authorities. The report did not specify what mineral was being mined. REUTERS

• NEIGHBOURHOOD WATCH

BANGLADESH

Fire at a gas lighter factory kills 5 people

A FIRE broke out at a factory manufacturing gas lighters near Bangladesh's capital on Saturday, leaving at least five people dead, authorities said. The blaze broke out in the Kadamtali area of Keraniganj near Dhaka. Seven firefighting units were deployed to extinguish the blaze. PTI

PAKISTAN

5 policemen killed in attack in KPK province

UNIDENTIFIED ARMED assailants opened fire at a police van, killing five policemen in Pakistan's Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province on Sunday, officials said. District Police Officer (DPO) Saud Khan said that all five police personnel in the van have been killed during the attack. PTI

5 Ebola patients recover as Congo opens new treatment centre

Associated Press Bunia, May 31

FIVE PATIENTS have recovered from a rare type of Ebola virus, the head of the World Health Organization said Sunday during a visit to Bunia in eastern Congo, a city at the heart of an outbreak.

"Four people will be discharged today and there was one that was discharged the day before yesterday," WHO Director-General Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus said during the opening of a new Ebola treatment centre in Bunia, the

capital of Ituri province.

"Of course, we're still working on vaccines and treatments but that doesn't mean that people cannot recover from Ebola," he added.

The WHO said Friday a patient had recovered from the Bundibugyo virus, the current species of Ebola, which has no approved treatment or vaccine. It was the first documented recovery of a confirmed Bundibugyo patient during the current outbreak. The health organisation said authorities have reported 134 confirmed cases in Congo and neighbour-



The Evangelical Medical Center in Ituri province, DRC on Sunday. REUTERS

ing Uganda, including 18 confirmed deaths as of May 29. Baraka Bulambulu, one of

those who recovered, told The Associated Press on Sunday that community members

feared contracting an unknown illness from them, keeping their distance while delivering food and medicine.

He said the uncertainty was overwhelming, as he and other patients believed they might die without knowing what disease they had, though testing eventually confirmed Ebola.

"Being able to come out of this alive is an immense source of happiness," Bulambulu said.

"Many people who were in the same situation died," Ezo Etienne, a nurse, said his symptoms began during ward rounds when he suddenly felt dizzy,

then rapidly deteriorated into vomiting, intense itching, severe diarrhea and extreme weakness. He was tested seven times before Ebola was confirmed.

His treatment remained purely to treat the symptoms: medications to control vomiting, fluids to prevent dehydration and pain relievers. "That was all they could provide," he said. He urged the public and healthcare workers not to dismiss early symptoms, warning that misinformation leads many people to believe they have been poisoned rather than seeking hospital care.

Over 45 killed in blast at mining explosives store in Myanmar

Associated Press Bangkok, May 31

A BLAST on Sunday at a building in northeastern Myanmar said to have been storing explosives for mining has killed more than 45 people, according to rescue workers and independent media reports.

About 70 other people were injured in the explosion that took place around noon in the village of Kaungtup, in Namhkam township.

The area, located about 3 km south of the Chinese border, is under the control of the Ta'ang National Liberation Army, an ethnic armed group which has engaged in sporadic fighting against Myanmar's central government.

A rescue worker who rushed to the site of the blast told *The*

Associated Press that 46 bodies, including six children, had been recovered by Sunday evening and taken for cremation.

The rescuer, who spoke on condition of anonymity for security reasons, said 74 injured people had been transported to the township hospital and rescue operations were continuing.

Another rescuer in Namhkam, who also spoke on condition of anonymity, said about 40 people were killed and more than 100 houses near the blast site were damaged.

Myanmar media outlets, including Shan State's online Shwe Phee Myay news agency, reported death tolls ranging from 50 to 55. They published photos and videos showing smoke from the explosion and damaged buildings and debris in its aftermath.

US strike kills 3 on suspected drug boat in the Pacific

Washington: The US military said it carried out another strike Saturday on a boat accused of smuggling drugs in the eastern Pacific Ocean, killing three men in the fourth attack this week and putting the total death toll at 205.

US Southern Command announced the strike with its usual language that the vessel was "engaged in narco-trafficking operations" and operated by a designated terrorist organization. It provided no evidence for the allegation.

The attack brings the death toll to 205 in a series of US strikes that began in early September, with other attacks announced on Tuesday, Wednesday and Friday. The Trump administration has declared that the US is at armed conflict with Latin American drug cartels, saying they are behind the flow of drugs into American communities. AP

Ukraine hits Russian energy sites, denies attacks on nuclear plant

Associated Press Kyiv, May 31

UKRAINE DENIED Moscow's claims on Sunday that a Ukrainian drone struck the Russian-controlled Zaporizhzhia nuclear plant, as Kyiv launched fresh strikes overnight on Russian energy sites.

Ukraine's General Staff on Sunday said Ukrainian drones had struck the Saratov oil refinery in southwestern Russia, causing a "large-scale fire." It said the extent of the damage was being clarified, and claimed the refinery has been supplying Moscow's war effort.

The refinery belongs to Russia's state oil enterprise, Rosneft, and produces diesel and gasoline among other types of fuel. The Russian local governor, Roman Busergin, said Ukrainian drones had damaged "civilian infrastructure", but did not immediately give details. *Astra*,



Firefighters at a site of a Russian drone strike, in Dnipro region, Ukraine on Sunday. REUTERS

an independent Russian news channel, said an oil refinery was on fire in the city of Saratov.

Ukraine has stepped up its attacks on Russia's oil and gas facilities in recent months, arguing the energy sector both funds and directly fuels Moscow's 4-year-old invasion.

Drone debris also set fire to a fuel depot in Russia's southwestern Rostov region, which

borders Russian-occupied eastern Ukraine, local Gov. Yuriy Slyusar reported on Telegram on Sunday. He said residents of nearby homes were evacuated.

Ukraine's General Staff on Sunday confirmed its forces were behind the strike on the facility in the town of Matveev Kurgan. Local authorities there earlier said a drone strike on the depot caused a massive blaze.

• TOURISM IS A VITAL ECONOMIC PILLAR ACROSS ASIA, DRIVING JOBS, GDP GROWTH AND FOREIGN EXCHANGE EARNINGS IN COUNTRIES SUCH AS THAILAND, VIETNAM, CAMBODIA, THE PHILIPPINES AND NEPAL

Soaring prices during war jeopardize travel to tourism-dependent countries in Asia

Anton L Delgado & Chan Ho-Him Bangkok, May 31

WITH SUMMER around the corner, soaring prices and other complications from the war with Iran are straining the tourism-dependent economies of countries in Southeast Asia, including Thailand and Vietnam.

The region's peak tourist summer season is at risk as elevated jet fuel costs coupled with ceasefire uncertainties prompt flight cancellations and higher ticket prices.

Tourism in Asia has yet to fully recover from the COVID-19 pandemic. Now, many countries are coping with the war's

repercussions for global energy supplies and prices, which hit Asia first and hardest. Some families are pulling back on travel as visiting gas stations and grocery stores gets more expensive worldwide. Crowds have thinned at some places once synonymous with travel.

"With gasoline prices rising and tourism declining, how can we make money?" asked Siv Pech, a 58-year-old tuk-tuk driver in Siem Reap, home to Cambodia's centuries-old Angkor Wat temple complex.

Tourism is an economic lifeline for many developing nations. It contributes nearly 13% of gross domestic product in Thailand and nearly 9% in Viet-

nam, and it underpins millions of jobs in Cambodia. Travelers bring in much-needed foreign currency for import-dependent economies such as the Philippines and Nepal.

Those tourism dollars are more critical than ever as war-driven spikes in oil prices push up the cost of fuel imports, especially for parts of the world that relied on the Strait of Hormuz off Iran's coast as a conduit for much of their oil and gas.

The war will determine which tourism businesses can survive long enough to benefit from the eventual return of travelers, said Jitsai Santaputra of The Lantau Group, an energy industry consulting firm.



A crowd of tourists take pictures of a passing train at the Mae Klong Railway Market near Bangkok, Thailand on December 6, 2025. FILE

"This, happening within five years of each other, first the pandemic and now the war, is horrible for the tourism industry," she said.

Jet fuel shortages and surging costs have led Vietnam Airlines, the Malaysia-based AirAsia

group, Hong Kong's Cathay Pacific and other carriers to cut flights or re-adjust schedules.

European carriers face a squeeze from similar issues.

Airspace closures across the Persian Gulf early in the war and the intermittent closures of certain Gulf airports cut off key layover locations for Asia-bound flights or forced commercial airplanes to take longer, costlier routes.

Airfares have jumped, with airlines like Air India and Cathay Pacific implementing sharp increases in fuel surcharges.

Cathay Pacific's fuel surcharge for medium-haul flights has jumped to 633 Hong Kong dollars (\$80) from 264 Hong

Kong dollars (\$34) before the war. For long-haul flights, it increased to 1,362 Hong Kong dollars (\$174) from 569 Hong Kong dollars (\$73).

"Jet fuel prices remain at highly elevated levels" and have increased cost pressures, said Lavinia Lau, Cathay's chief customer and commercial officer. Travellers are booking closer to their departure dates, she said, indicating growing unease.

Sandra Awodele, a freelance travel writer in the Washington area, often plans year-round international trips and hoped this summer would finally be the one she crossed Asia off her bucket list.

In March, she began plan-

ning a long-awaited vacation to Thailand, envisioning one to two weeks of exploring. Her plans hit a wall when she checked airfares. "I looked at flight options and that's where it ended," Awodele said.

On the ground, rising fuel costs in tourism-dependent Southeast Asia are squeezing taxi and ride-hailing app drivers.

Pech, the Cambodian tuk-tuk driver, said he used to earn up to \$20 a day totting tourists around Siem Reap. That's plummeted to about \$5 a day.

His gas bill eats half of that. The rest goes to food. "Some days, I don't earn even a cent," he said. AP

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If there are questions of current or contemporary relevance that you would like explained, please write to explained@indianexpress.com

ECONOMICS

How China’s reduced oil imports have helped India



SUKALP SHARMA

THE WEST Asia war and the consequent closure of the Strait of Hormuz have constricted crude oil flows and sent prices spiralling, particularly for Asian economies such as India. The situation, however, could have been much worse had it not been for one country — China.

Beijing is the world’s largest crude oil importer, but has sharply reduced its imports amid the crisis. This has freed up supplies from regions unaffected by the strait’s closure — Russia, West Africa, the Atlantic Basin, and non-Hormuz-dependent West Asian nations — and allowed the likes of India, South Korea, Japan, Thailand, and Singapore to snap them up. So far, this has blunted the oil shock and prevented a deeper supply crunch and even higher prices in the region.

Why China cut oil imports

Before the war, 40-50% of India’s oil imports came via the strait. India is the world’s third-largest consumer of crude oil with an import dependency level of more than 88%.

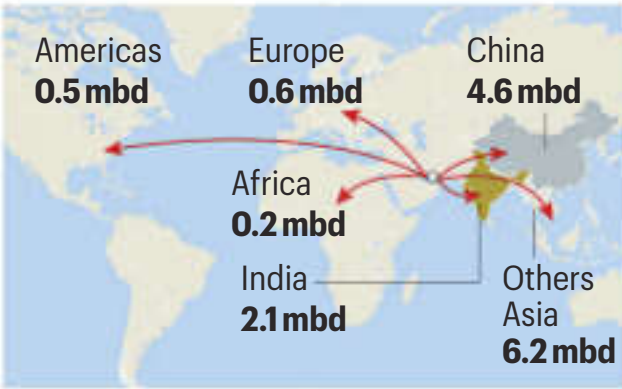
“Chinese crude imports in May month-to-date are tracking around 6.6 mbd (million barrels a day), the lowest level since 2016. Compared with last year’s average, imports from Russia, Africa, and parts of the Americas have declined materially, effectively freeing additional barrels into the broader Asian market,” Sumit Ritolia, manager, modelling and refining at commodity market analytics firm Kpler, said in a recent note.

China’s refinery crude intake has dropped to around 13.5 mbd in May — down 1.92 mbd versus the 2025 average — but the decline in oil demand continues to trail the drop in supplies. This means that China has been drawing on its huge on-shore oil inventories. Preliminary data corroborates that trend.

Apart from its massive oil inventory and

Most crude via Strait of Hormuz goes to Asia

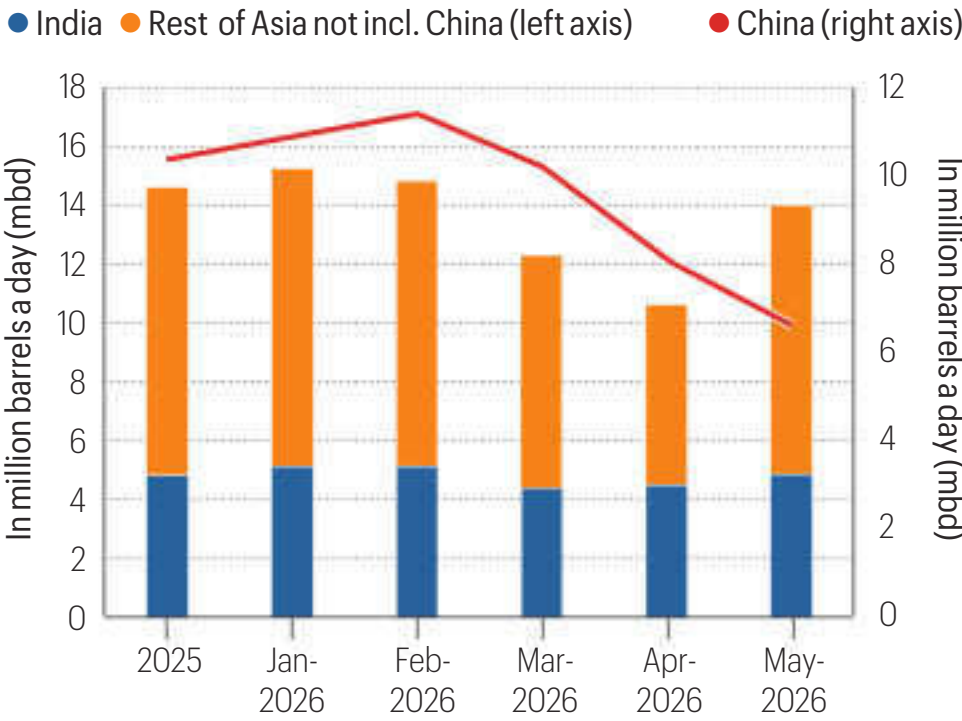
In 2025, nearly 15 million barrels a day (mbd) of crude oil, 34% of global crude trade, passed through the Strait of Hormuz. China and India combined received 44% of these exports.



NOTE: TOTAL FIGURE MENTIONED IN CHART INTRO DOES NOT MATCH THE SUM OF ADDING INDIVIDUAL NUMBERS DUE TO DESTINATIONS NOT INDICATED. SOURCE: INTERNATIONAL ENERGY AGENCY ANALYSIS BASED ON KPLER.

Sharp dip in China’s crude imports

Chinese crude imports in May month-to-date are tracking around 6.6 mbd, the lowest level since 2016



NOTE: DATA AS OF 25TH MAY, SOURCE: KPLER

strategic crude petroleum reserves, Beijing’s current reluctance to import oil at normal levels is partly because high fuel prices and tepid economic activity have dampened oil demand, while accelerating the energy transition in the country.

“...refiners across South Korea, Japan, Southeast Asia, and India have been able to secure more crude supply than initially expected, allowing refinery throughput to hold up materially better than earlier base-case assumptions despite tighter Middle Eastern flows and Strait of Hormuz disruptions. This has helped Asia (ex-China) refinery runs recover more strongly than initially expected in May, although overall refining activity remains heavily disrupted versus normal conditions,” Ritolia said.

How China’s reduced imports impacted India

India’s crude imports in May have been strong. While the 2025 average stood at around 4.8 mbd, May imports are currently tracking around 5 mbd, potentially the highest monthly import in May ever, supported primarily by stronger Russian and Venezuelan crude imports, as per Kpler.

Impact on India

India is among the three Asian economies — along with Thailand and South Korea — most vulnerable to high oil prices, according to a Nomura report

Every 10% oil price increase typically widens India’s current account deficit by 0.4% of the GDP

Industry experts and analysts say that oil prices would have been a lot higher had China maintained its crude import levels.

“Physical crude oil benchmarks appear to have settled into a \$100-\$120/bbl (barrel) range over the past two months, after the initial wave of panic buying during the first month of the US-Iran war briefly pushed prices above \$150/bbl. Beyond SPR (strategic petroleum reserve) releases by multiple countries — particularly the accelerated drawdown in US stockpiles — one key reason oil prices have not sustainably moved above \$150/bbl despite a structural supply loss of 8 mbd from the Middle East is the absence of Chinese buying in the market,” said Muyu Xu, senior crude oil analyst at Kpler.

Given its high oil consumption and import dependency, India is already bearing the brunt of high oil prices. The country imports 1.8-2 billion barrels of oil a year, and every \$1-per-barrel increase in price bumps up its oil import bill by up to \$2 billion on an annualised basis.

According to a March report by Nomura, India is among the three Asian economies most vulnerable to high oil prices,

the other two being Thailand and South Korea. It also said that every 10% oil price increase typically widens India’s current account deficit by 0.4% of the GDP. Crude oil alone is India’s largest merchandise import.

According to Commerce Ministry data, crude oil imports in 2025-26 stood at about \$135 billion. If oil prices sustain at \$100 per barrel in the current financial year and import volumes don’t decline, the oil import bill could be upwards of \$200 billion for the year. If the price sustains at a much higher level, the implications would be even graver.

Will China continue to hold back?

If Beijing’s imports remain subdued, other Asian refiners are expected to continue benefitting from relatively improved oil availability in the foreseeable future. But any significant recovery could rapidly tighten oil supply in Asia — unless the Strait of Hormuz disruption is resolved.

The current pattern is expected to persist in the near term, as refiners continue to keep run rates low while staying on the sidelines of the physical crude market. According to Xu, Chinese state-owned refiners are heard to be planning to keep June and July refinery run rates largely unchanged, even as fuel demand typically starts to pick up during the summer season.

China’s independent refiners have also cut back significantly on buying oil from the spot market amid a surge in Russian and Iranian oil prices, which formed a large part of these refiners’ crude slate.

“That said, if the US were to maintain the blockade on Iranian cargoes, Chinese independent refiners would have to turn to alternative supplies — most likely Russian crude — and compete for barrels currently taken by other buyers such as India. Given elevated prices, they are more likely to further cut run rates,” Xu said.

So, there could be further oil inventory drawdowns in China, which may prompt Beijing to release state oil reserves, or even step up crude purchases. Unless oil flows through the strait normalise, China will have to take a call on when to step up oil imports, which is when the real oil shock would be visible.

FINANCE

Unaffordable homes: UN report lists factors behind housing crisis

Devansh Mittal

New Delhi, May 31

ACROSS COUNTRIES, housing prices are slipping out of the budget of large sections of the population. The world is in the midst of a housing crisis as more people move to urban areas and not enough houses are being built, according to a recent report by the United Nations. The report also flags financialisation as one of the major factors behind this crisis.

What is the global housing shortage?

Up to 3.4 billion people — four out of every 10 people worldwide — lack access to adequate housing. Of this, more than a billion live in informal settlements such as slums, according to the report by the United Nations Human Settlements Programme (UN-Habitat), the highest recorded number.

The report was released at the 13th World Urban Forum, organised by UN-Habitat in Baku, Azerbaijan.

If a household spends more than 30% of its budget on housing, it is considered stress burdened. Globally, 44% of households spend more than 30% of their income on rent.

For prospective buyers, affordability is measured using the house price-to-income ratio: housing is considered affordable

when the median house price is no more than three times the median household income, while ratios above five indicate severe unaffordability.

Central and Southern Asia, including India, has seen the sharpest relative rise in price-to-income ratios — up 73% between 2010 and 2023. In 2018, more than half of new housing units built in the eight largest Indian cities were in the affordable housing segment. This has declined to fewer than two out of every ten units built by 2025, the report notes. Developers prioritise luxury units due to higher margins and demand, placing homeownership out of reach of most families.

What are the roots of the crisis?

The roots of the crisis go back to the post-World War II period, the report notes. Facing severe housing shortages and economic depression, governments invested heavily in public housing. But international agencies, including the United Nations, International Labour Organisation (ILO) and World Bank, rarely supported this model. Instead, they advocated greater private sector involvement, arguing that mass public housing was too costly, especially for newly independent and transitional economies.

This critique of public housing laid the foundations of two dominant approaches

Multiple reasons

- In some cases, well-intentioned housing subsidies also contributed to price increases by raising purchasing power without expanding supply.
- Declining interest rates from the 1980s further encouraged investment in real estate, intensifying demand and price growth.

that continue to shape housing policy: “aided self-help” — where households build or improve homes with support — and the “enabling approach”, under which governments facilitate construction by private players, community associations and others. Yet these programmes often failed to reach the poorest households and sometimes displaced the very populations they intended to support, the report states.

The state has not only built fewer homes but often built them in the wrong locations. An analysis of annual Delhi Development Authority (DDA) reports by the Centre for Policy Research’s Cities of Delhi project, directed by Partha Mukhopadhyay and Patrick Heller, found that the agency consistently fell behind housing targets. “We calculate that of the 979,073 houses built between 2003 and 2010, fewer than 23,000 (2.3%) were built by the DDA,” it said.

The report also notes that housing must be developed where livelihoods and social infrastructure such as parks exist, otherwise people are unwilling to relocate. More than 50,000 government-built flats remain unoccupied on Delhi’s outskirts due to poor connectivity, lack of livelihoods and political tussles.

What is financialisation and what are its impacts?

According to the report, financialisation

is one of the major drivers of the crisis. It refers to the increasing involvement of financial actors, investment instruments and large pools of capital in housing and land markets. In India, Non-Resident Indians (NRIs) and investors purchase luxury housing as investment.

Access to home loans in India increased after liberalisation in 1991 made homeownership more widely accessible.

However, the report states that globally this increased availability of credit allowed lending to grow faster than the construction of new homes. This created loops in which easier access to credit pushed up prices more quickly than supply could respond.

The effects of financialisation vary depending on local conditions, regulation and supply. In markets with limited supply, informal incomes or weak tenant protections, increased capital flows can lead to evictions, rent hikes and speculative redevelopment.

The report also notes that in better-regulated environments with stronger planning systems, investment has supported new construction, upgrades of older housing, and professionally managed rental stock.

The reporter attended the World Urban Forum in Baku on the invitation of UN-Habitat.

POLICY

Religion and the tribal identity: Why ‘delisting’ debate refuses to die down

Shubham Tigga

Ranchi, May 31

WHEN THE Census process started in Jharkhand on May 16, an appeal began circulating among Adivasi communities: don’t mention “Hindu” in the religion column; instead, write “Sarna”, the traditional tribal faith, or “others”. Around a week later, a large Adivasi gathering in New Delhi demanded “delisting” from the Scheduled Tribes (ST) category for tribal people who convert to Christianity or Islam.

These two recent developments have revived the long-running debate around religious identity among Adivasis, not only in Jharkhand but elsewhere too.

The ST status

Scheduled Tribes in India are those recognised under Article 342 of the Constitution as eligible for certain benefits and State support. “Delisting” refers to the demand that tribal people converting to Christianity or Islam should not continue receiving the

benefits for STs. Among the major voices raising this demand are Adivasi Hindus.

But another section of Adivasis, from the Sarna community (which does not identify as either Hindu or Christian), argues that if religion becomes the basis for removing tribal status, the same rule should apply to tribal people who have converted to Hinduism.

This comes amid the recent Supreme Court observation reiterating that Dalits converting to Christianity or Islam cannot continue to claim Scheduled Caste status under Article 341. However, Article 342, which deals with STs, does not explicitly mention religion.

The debate

The Janjati Suraksha Manch (JSM), affiliated with the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh’s (RSS) tribal outfit Akhil Bharatiya Vanvasi Kalyan Ashram, organised the New Delhi gathering on May 24. Attended by Union Home Minister Amit Shah, it saw several Adivasi groups, including some

from parts of the Northeast, backing the delisting demand.

However, the Sarna community and the Christian Adivasi Mahasabha organised a similarly large counter-rally in Chhattisgarh’s Jashpur district. Adivasi activists from Jharkhand and Chhattisgarh, especially followers of the Sarna faith, extended support to Christian Adivasis and distanced themselves from organisations seen as close to the RSS.

The Delhi event, notably, triggered another controversy. Home Minister Shah used the word “vanvasi” while talking about delisting, leading to protests in Jharkhand. Protesters argued that the word, meaning “forest dweller”, reduces tribal identity only to geography. “Adivasi”, which means “original inhabitants”, carries a political and historical identity linked to land and indiginity.

Origins of the demand

The roots of the delisting idea are often traced to Baba Kartik Oraon, a prominent



The event in Chhattisgarh’s Jashpur district on May 24. EXPRESS

Adivasi leader who later became a Union Minister in Indira Gandhi’s Cabinet. Kartik Oraon lost his debut Lok Sabha

election in 1962 from Lohardaga, an ST-reserved constituency. He argued before the Patna High Court that since his opponent had converted to Christianity, he no longer was a tribal from the Oraon community and should, therefore, be disqualified.

The Patna High Court, however, held that Oraon is “primarily a tribe and ethnic identity, not merely a religion”. It observed that Christian Oraons retained their clan system, and continued to observe tribal customs and festivals. The judgment noted they are “Oraons first and Christians next”.

This High Court judgment is often cited by opponents of the delisting demand to argue that religion is immaterial in determining ST identity.

In August 1967, when Kartik Oraon was a minister in Indira Gandhi’s Cabinet, the government introduced the ‘Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes Order Amendment Bill’ in Lok Sabha to revise the inclusion and exclusion of castes and tribes across India. It was referred to a Joint Parliamentary Committee the next year in March.

The committee, in its report on November 17, 1969, proposed amending the Bill to exclude Christian and Muslim tribal converts from the Scheduled Tribe category. The government, however, expressed reservations over the proposal. Parliament never adopted it.

Tribal people and groups affiliated to the RSS and BJP have often invoked Kartik Oraon to claim that Adivasis are Hindus and cannot remain Christian while enjoying Constitutional protections for STs.

Kartik Oraon himself, however, had a different view. In his book, *Bees Varsh Ki Kaali Raat*, he defines Adivasi faith as “Adi Dharma”, an indigenous religion that existed before Hinduism. While he does argue that converted Christians should not continue receiving ST benefits, he states that Adivasis are not Hindus, questioning under which *varna* (Brahmin, Kshatriya, Vaishya or Shudra) they could be placed within the Hindu social order.

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Economy

ANALYSTS EXPECT MPC TO LOWER GROWTH PROJECTIONS FROM ITS EARLIER FORECAST OF 6.9%

Reserve Bank may defer rate hike despite inflationary pressures

George Mathew
Mumbai, May 31

THE RESERVE Bank of India's (RBI) Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) is widely expected to remain in a wait-and-watch mode on June 5 and defer any move to hike interest rates despite mounting inflationary pressures from rising crude oil prices.

RBI policymakers face a complex balancing act as the ongoing conflict in West Asia threatens to push up energy costs, disrupt global supply chains, and trigger volatility in financial markets, at a time when sustained capital outflows and pressure on the rupee add to macroeconomic concerns.

Against this backdrop, the RBI is likely to reassess both its growth and inflation projections, with risks emanating from elevated oil prices, uncertainty in global trade, adverse weather conditions and geopolitical tensions clouding the economic outlook.

No tightening now, but later this year?

The RBI had kept the main policy instrument, the repo rate (interest rate at which it lends money to commercial banks), unchanged at 5.25% in the April

policy review. In doing so, it underscored a cautious and calculated approach, as economic risks resulting from the West Asia conflict have darkened both global and domestic outlooks.

In the absence of a clear risk of headline inflation spilling over into core inflation (a measure that excludes the change in prices of food and fuel) and signs of unanchored inflationary expectations, the central bank is likely to view the energy shock as a supply-side price catalyst. It could defer tightening policy at the upcoming meeting, as per Radhika Rao, Senior Economist and ED, DBS Bank.

"An argument can, nonetheless, be made on the need to tighten policy in the second half of calendar year 2026 if the conflict continues, to attract rate-sensitive flows," Rao said. "Add to this, the inflation rationale has also gained credibility amid successive pump price increases (7% over the past two weeks), a pickup in food, impact of prevailing heatwave conditions and rising business inflation expectations, all of which point to mounting underlying price pressures," Rao said.

CareEdge Rating said it expects the MPC to adopt a wait-and-watch approach amid external volatility, assessing

• INFLATION DYNAMICS

AN ARGUMENT can be made on the need to tighten policy in the second half of calendar year 2026 if the conflict continues, to attract rate-sensitive flows, says Rao



INFLATION RATIONALE has gained credibility amid successive pump price increases (7% over the past two weeks), pickup in food, impact of prevailing heatwave conditions and rising business inflation expectations, all of which point to mounting underlying price pressures, she said

FUTURE TRAJECTORY of policy rate will depend on MPC's assessment of evolving inflation dynamics, which are significantly influenced by external factors

whether current price pressures are transient or persistent, based on external developments. India's still-benign retail inflation, at 3.48% in April and below the RBI's 4% medium-term target for more than a year, gives the central bank room to stay on hold rather than rush into policy action.

Growth may be slashed

Economic growth in FY27 is expected to remain below the economy's estimated potential growth rate of 7%, as projected by the Economic Survey. This strengthens the case for the RBI

to remain comfortable with a lower real policy rate for the next few quarters, particularly as growth continues to require policy support.

Unless there is clear and sustained evidence that higher input costs are feeding into household inflation expectations, the central bank is unlikely to go for a rate hike. The future trajectory of the policy rate will depend on the MPC's assessment of evolving inflation dynamics, which are significantly influenced by external factors. If conflict persists and inflation risks become en-

trenched in household expectations, rate hikes could be considered toward the end of the year, CareEdge Rating said.

Analysts also expect the MPC to lower growth projections from its earlier projection of 6.9%. "MPC will also remain attentive to growth risks. We project FY27 GDP growth at 6.7%, assuming crude oil averaging \$90. However, prolonged conflict and oil prices around \$110 could lower growth closer to 6%," CareEdge said. It expects Q4 FY26 GDP growth to moderate to around 6.8-7.0%, compared with 7.8% in Q3FY26.

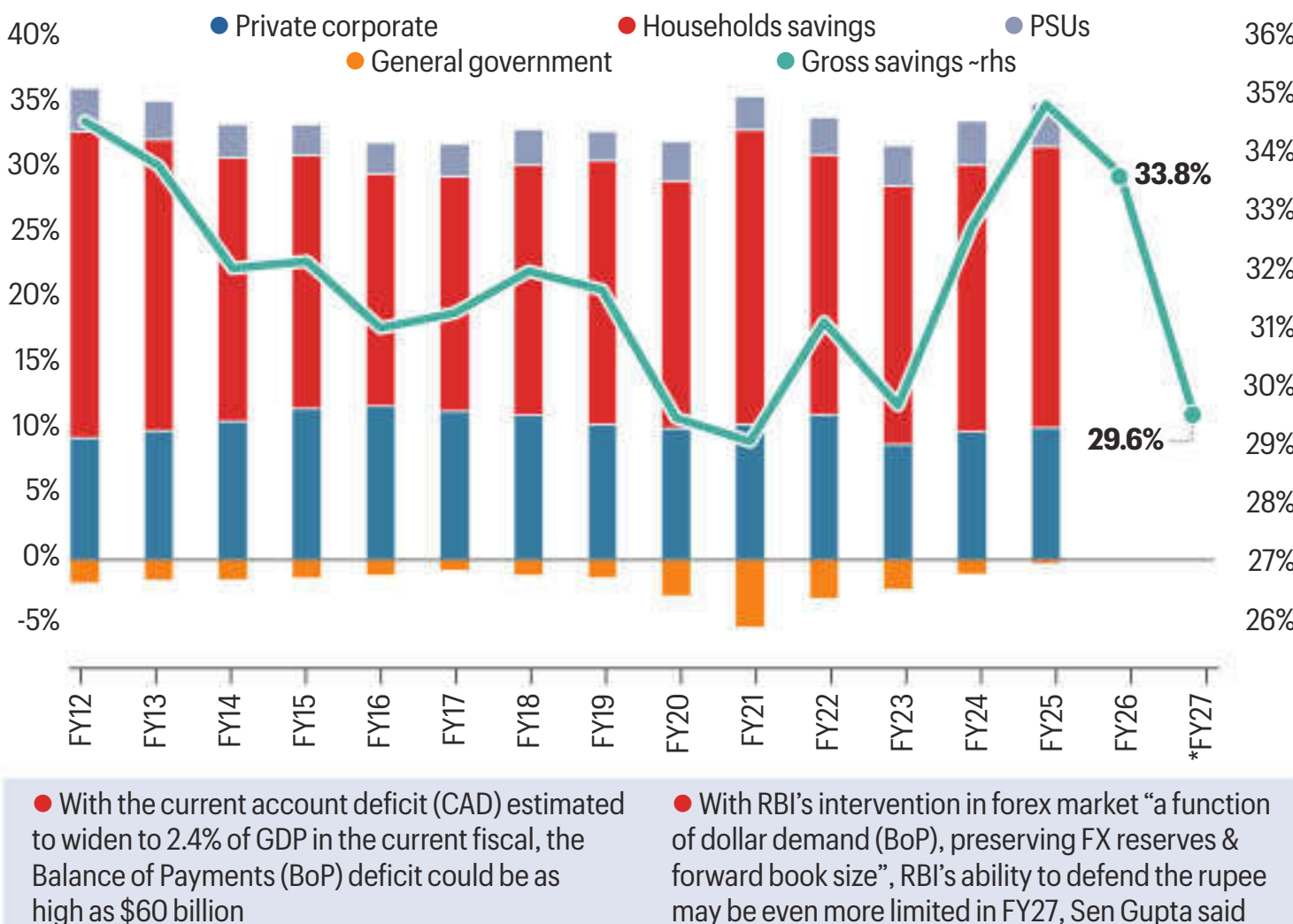
Q4FY26 remained partially insulated from the adverse effects of the crisis, as the first two months of the quarter were relatively unaffected.

The RBI's Annual Report said the West Asia conflict and risks such as higher energy prices, supply chain disruptions, financial market volatility, global trade uncertainty and weather disruptions could affect growth and inflation in the short term. In a highly uncertain global environment, continuous assessment of the evolving developments is warranted to frame the appropriate policy response on an ongoing basis, the central bank said.

FULL REPORT ON
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• Foreign savings key to counter domestic savings slowdown

India's gross domestic savings may decline to 29.6% of GDP in FY27 from 33.8% in FY26, according to IDFC First Bank's Chief Economist Gaura Sen Gupta. Why? On one hand, while the government's fiscal deficit is seen rising due to the surge in fuel prices, the same factor is set to lower savings by households and companies. To counter this slowdown in domestic savings, it's crucial to attract foreign savings, Sen Gupta said in a report on Friday.



Rupee defence to liquidity: RBI earned over Rs 4 lakh cr in FY26, spent a third of it

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, May 31

LAST WEEK, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) transferred a record dividend of Rs 2.87 lakh crore to the Centre for 2025-26. Unlike companies that transfer a portion of their profits to shareholders, the RBI must hand over its entire gain to the government. But how did it end up generating such a big profit?

First and foremost, the RBI's objective is not to make a profit; it just so happens that the actions it must take to achieve its objectives — ensuring adequate supply of money (liquidity) in the banking system, appropriately investing its foreign exchange reserves, and maintaining order in the bond and foreign exchange market — result in a lot of revenue.

In 2025-26, the RBI's total income was a record Rs 4.28 lakh crore, up 26% from the previous year. Of this, it spent about a third, or Rs 1.41 lakh crore. But how did the RBI earn so much and what did it spend on?

Supporting the rupee

Last year was highly turbulent: tariffs, wars, and the AI boom led to foreign investors dumping Indian shares and debt, while India's gold and silver import bill hit new highs. This led to the rupee falling by 10% against the US dollar. The byproduct of the RBI's attempts to defend the rupee was the largest income stream for the central bank.

The RBI shores up the rupee by selling previously-bought foreign currency. The difference in cost and selling price represents a pure profit. For instance, if a dollar was bought for 75 rupees and sold at 95, that's a profit of Rs 20. All in all, the RBI sold \$195 billion of foreign currency on a gross basis in 2025-26.

This led to what is called an 'exchange gain from foreign exchange transactions' of Rs 1.69 lakh crore, 52% higher from 2024-25.

The RBI does not disclose the average historical cost of

• How RBI earned and spent money in FY26

	2024-25 (Rs cr)	2025-26 (Rs cr)
Interest from rupee securities	85,525	117,740
Interest from foreign securities	97,007	107,679
Interest on foreign deposits	36,195	27,407
Net interest on liquidity operations	-10,120	-19,163
Exchange gain from forex transactions	111,143	168,906
TOTAL INCOME	338,308	427,684
Printing of notes	6,373	4,875
Employee cost	9,147	10,136
Provisions	44,862	109,380
TOTAL EXPENDITURE	69,714	141,092
Dividend to government	268,590	286,588

NOTE: INTEREST ON LIQUIDITY OPERATIONS INCLUDES LAF, SDF, MSF SOURCE: RBI

the foreign currency it holds or sells.

Consequences of rupee defence

Selling forex has consequences which the RBI must negate. And these actions generate more income.

When the RBI sells dollars, it gets rupees in return. This reduces the availability of Indian rupees — or, rupee liquidity. Unaddressed, this rupee liquidity shortage would raise market interest rates.

In 2025-26, the RBI did not want interest rates to rise (it cut the repo rate by 125 basis points). So, it had to infuse rupees into the Indian market to nullify the impact of its dollar sales. It did so by buying central government bonds worth nearly Rs 9 lakh crore from those who hold them — banks, for instance. These bonds, and those it already held, provided an interest of Rs 1.18 lakh crore to the RBI last year.

While these government bond purchases infuse long-term liquidity, short-term mismatches require the RBI to lend and hold banks' money. On the whole, these short-term operations saw the central bank pay out Rs 19,163 crore as interest.

The RBI also earns interest on the foreign securities it holds

as part of its foreign exchange reserves. In 2025-26, this interest income rose 11% to Rs 1.08 lakh crore. It also received Rs 27,407 crore as interest on its foreign deposits.

Cost of operations

Two expenditure items are straightforward but minor in the overall scheme of things. Printing of new currency set back the RBI Rs 4,875 crore, while employee cost rose 11% to Rs 10,136 crore.

The big chunky expenditure was provisions. Like any other bank, the RBI must set aside money if its loans — in the RBI's case, investments — are doing poorly. This happens when the value of its holding of domestic and foreign securities falls due to a rise in yields, which is what happened in 2025-26.

Money also had to be set aside for the losses being incurred by the RBI on its forward contracts — another instrument used to defend the rupee last year. All put together, the net provision made by the RBI on account of these three issues was a massive Rs 1.09 lakh crore.

The provision would have been higher had the Contingent Risk Buffer not been cut to 6.5% of the balance sheet from 7.5%.

• BRIEFLY

China factory activity stalls in May, PMI shows

Beijing: China's factory activity stalled in May as new export orders contracted and input costs kept rising, an official survey showed on Sunday, adding to concerns the world's second-largest economy is losing momentum despite pockets of strength in services and high-tech manufacturing. The official manufacturing purchasing managers' index (PMI) dropped to 50 from 50.3 in April, matching the forecast in a *Reuters* poll of economists and straddling the 50-mark separating growth from contraction, as per a survey by the National Bureau of Statistics. REUTERS

US-Iran talks, RBI's decision to drive markets

New Delhi: Developments around US-Iran situation, crude oil prices, and the RBI's interest rate decision will determine the trend in the equity market in an event-heavy week ahead, analysts said. The final HSBC Manufacturing PMI reading for May will be announced on Monday, followed by the Services PMI and Composite PMI data on Wednesday. These indicators will provide key insights into demand trends, business activity, and growth resilience across sectors, Ajit Mishra, SVP, Research, Religare Broking Ltd, said. PTI

LIC plans foray in fintech, says CEO

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, May 31

INSURANCE GIANT LIC is actively considering establishing a fintech arm either through strategic investment or organic way to cater to its growing digital needs, Chief Executive Officer (CEO) and Managing Director R Doraiswamy said.

"Naturally, to meet the modernisation requirement and particularly to bring innovation, we are engaging both

fintech and insurtech players and we are getting a lot of new things being developed by such players," Doraiswamy said.

On the other side, he said, "we are a big financial institution investing in multiple organisations and we also look at strategic investments in any specialised player as a way of improving the returns on the policyholders' funds."

Talking about Life Insurance Corporation of India's IT journey, he said, it was one of

the early adopters of digital technologies.

"We have built our own core competence in developing our business applications by building up a software development centre. We have sizable number of people working in our IT department creating the IT solutions for us but that does not mean that we can be totally self-dependent. We engage a lot of IT service providers for the new infrastructure and platforms," he said.

India, Oman FTA to come into effect today

Mukesh Jagota
New Delhi, May 31

THE INDIA-OMAN Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) will take effect on Monday, extending zero-duty access on 98% of tariff lines, which cover 99.4% of India's exports to Oman. In return, India will open up 77% of its tariff lines for Oman, covering 94% of its total exports to India. This is In-

dia's 15th bilateral trade agreement. For India, the most visible gains lie in merchandise exports. Oman's gains are concentrated in energy and industrial inputs, said Ajay Srivastava, founder of GTRL. With over 6,000 India-Oman joint ventures and Indian investments exceeding \$7.5 billion — mainly in the Sohar and Salalah free zones — the CEPA is as much a strategic pact as a trade deal, he added. FE

• PREVAILING GLOBAL UNCERTAINTY IS DRIVING ADOPTION OF MULTI-CURRENCY FRAMEWORKS, WITH THE EURO AND SWISS FRANC EMERGING AS PREFERRED ALTERNATIVES, SAYS UBS

Ditching the US dollar: How family offices are reacting to geopolitical risks

George Mathew
Mumbai, May 31

THE SWISS bank UBS, a global wealth manager, stated in a report on Thursday (May 28) that many family offices are considering reducing their exposure to the US dollar or diversifying regionally amid rising geopolitical risks.

A family office is essentially a private wealth management advisory firm that serves ultra-high-net-worth individuals (UHNIs) and their families in managing and growing their wealth across generations.

Often, family members hold a share in most of the family offices' assets. In India, too, outbound investments routed through family offices for HNIs are now a topic of discussion amid the broader outbound fund flows.

Drawing on insights from 307 family offices across more than 30 markets, the report highlighted a notable shift in currency positioning. "65% of family offices expect confidence in the US dollar's reserve status to weaken, with many reassessing exposure to USD-denominated assets," the report said.

Another major theme was artificial intelligence (AI) as the leading global investment.

UBS said 65% of family offices have already invested across the AI value chain, including data centre infrastructure, software platforms and producers of semiconductors.

Slight shift from dollar, North America still key

Each of the family offices analysed in the report managed an average of \$1.3 billion in assets. Participating families



65% of family offices expect confidence in US dollar's reserve status to weaken. REUTERS

had an average net worth of \$2.7 billion, and their total wealth amounted to \$627.4 billion, UBS said. It found that prevailing geopolitical uncertainty, especially with recent events in

• GLOBAL SHIFT

● Drawing on insights from 307 family offices across more than 30 markets, the report highlighted a notable shift in currency positioning

● Another key theme was AI as the leading global investment. 65% of family offices have already invested across the AI value chain.

● North America accounts for the largest share of allocations among geographies, yet family offices seek to reduce concentration risk

West Asia, is driving broader adoption of multi-currency frameworks, with the euro and Swiss franc emerging as preferred alternatives.

Among geographies, North

America continues to account for the largest share of allocations, yet family offices are actively seeking to reduce concentration risk. Increasingly, they are planning to expand exposure to Asia Pacific, Greater China and Western Europe, reflecting a structural shift.

UBS found that family offices in the Middle East demonstrated the highest level of planned portfolio change globally, with 82% intending to adjust strategic allocations. Their portfolios remain anchored in North America (50%), but with meaningful exposure to Western Europe and the Middle East, reflecting a hybrid investment approach. Family offices in the US exhibit the strongest home bias globally, with 88% of portfolios allocated to North America. This implies confidence in the depth, liquidity and resilience of do-

mestic capital markets.

Rise of AI, despite bubble concerns

While AI remains the top investment theme (65%), those surveyed also show heightened interest in defence and security infrastructure (39%) and broader infrastructure investments (35%). It may potentially reflect geopolitical considerations alongside growth opportunities, the report said. There are also concerns that certain AI stocks are overvalued at the moment, and an 'AI bubble' could burst when actual revenues fall behind the market hype. "AI continues to stand out as the defining investment theme of this decade," said Yves-Alain Sommerhalder, Head of Global Wealth Management Solutions

at UBS. "Family offices are approaching it with both conviction and selectivity, seeking opportunities across the value chain while balancing long-term growth potential with risk discipline," he added.

Family offices are allocating funds towards power and resources (37%), infrastructure (37%), and AI-enabled healthcare (33%), recognising the broader ecosystem required to support and scale AI adoption, according to the report. By contrast, crypto and digital assets remain a niche allocation, with only 24% of family offices investing in them, typically at low single-digit levels. Allocations are usually modest (around 1%).

Gaps in governance, succession planning

While family offices continue to professionalise investment operations, the report highlights persistent gaps in governance frameworks, succession planning and next-generation engagement, creating potential risks to long-term continuity. Operationally, many family offices have adopted institutional-grade practices: 68% have formal financial performance measurement processes, 60% operate with investment committees, and over half use structured budgeting frameworks, reflecting a growing level of rigour and oversight, UBS said. However, this progress is uneven. Fewer than half have implemented formal governance frameworks with board-level oversight, and only 35% have a defined succession plan for the family office itself.

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NEWSMAKERS IN THE NEWSROOM

WHY MONTEK SINGH AHLUWALIA

Few understand India’s political economy as Montek Singh Ahluwalia does. After his graduate studies at Oxford and a stint in the World Bank, he returned and served the government in various capacities; as Commerce Secretary and Finance Secretary in the early 1990s, he helped shape India’s response to the balance of payment crisis of 1991, setting in motion its transformation into a market-linked economy by dismantling the licence raj and ushering in reforms across sectors. As Deputy Chairman of the Planning Commission in the UPA government (2004-14), he had the then Prime Minister Manmohan Singh’s ear, and coordinated India’s actions following the 2008 global financial crisis. He is sharp, and can sense what investors are looking for in the India story.

P Vaidyanathan Iyer: Could you take us from 2000 onwards, the first 13-14 years and the next 13 years?

We have had three different governments in this period. The Vajpayee NDA from 1998 to 2004, the UPA from 2004 to 2014 and the current Modi NDA from 2014 to today. It is fair to say that all three have talked about the need for reforms and also made some progress, broadly following the direction set in 1991. However, the 1991 reforms were transformational, dismantling decades of licence permit raj controls. What has happened since then is much more gradualist. The fact that governments under different political parties moved forward broadly in the same direction is good news. It shows that there is a broad consensus beneath political polemics. It is particularly important that parties opposing reforms when in Opposition, adopted them when in office, as happened in the case of Aadhaar and also with the GST. However, the pace of movement has been far too slow. I think we are now at a stage when this sort of gradualism will not be enough.

P Vaidyanathan Iyer: So, what’s the India story now?

The world is preoccupied with too many things and India is not a focus of attention. This is in some ways an advantage. But we should try to reestablish a positive India story.

The positive features about India’s economy are well-known. We have favourable demographics; the economy grew at 8 plus per cent over an extended period before 2010 highlighting the strengths of the Indian private sector; infrastructure and logistics are improving though more needs to be done; the digital public infrastructure has expanded over the past 10 years, leading to an increase in financial inclusion.

All this is good but it is not enough. To reestablish the India story we need a much clearer articulation of how we intend to deal with the immediate challenge we face as a result of the oil crisis and the longer run challenge of how to accelerate growth to achieve Viksit Bharat.

P Vaidyanathan Iyer: Let’s start with the balance of payments. How do you see India’s prospects given there’s no immediate end to the war? Does the three years of continuous pressure on the balance of payments worry you?

As you say there is no immediate end to the war in sight but it does seem as if both the US and Iran want to avoid escalation. There is still considerable uncertainty about when oil supplies will return to normal but earlier fears of oil going beyond \$120 have subsided. Even if we assume that the US and Iran reach a satisfactory agreement in the next two weeks, it will still take time for movement through the Strait of Hormuz to get back to normal. And since many countries have drastically reduced their strategic stocks, they will want to build them up as soon as possible.

All this means oil prices which, are currently below \$100 per barrel which is a third higher than in the previous year, may remain at that level for some time. We need to outline a credible strategy for managing the balance of payments in this situation.

As you point out, we had a problem even before the oil price shock. For the past several years, we have run a relatively modest current account deficit averaging around 1.5 per cent of GDP, which was more than offset by a capital account surplus of over 2 per cent of GDP. That surplus declined sharply after 2023 and has almost disappeared in 2025-26. We have seen sharp fall in net Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) and the net flow of foreign portfolio investment has turned negative.

The disappearance of the surplus on capital account would have posed problems even without the rise in oil prices. As it is the higher oil prices will worsen the current account deficit could worsen to say 2.2 per cent of GDP in the 2025-26. To manage this with low capital flows, we have to cut the current account deficit and increase capital flows as much as possible. If things look as if they are going to come back to normal sooner than people think, we could allowing the reserves to take some of the hit.

A conventional response when trying to reduce the current account deficit is to allow the currency to depreciate. This has happened over the past year and I think the RBI did the right thing by allowing the depreciation to take place. This is not to say that continuous depreciation will solve the problem. We have to avoid creating self-perpetuating expectations, which can worsen the situation. That is best done by taking other actions to contain the current account deficit and also taking steps to revive capital inflows as much as we can.

A second sensible response is to let the increase in oil prices be passed through into the economy. That too has happened. The increase is modest and the government has also taken some of the hit by lowering excise duties.

P Vaidyanathan Iyer: What else should we do?

Our performance in export of goods has been quite poor for the past several years and this weakness needs to be addressed.



ON NEED FOR NEW BILATERAL INVESTMENT TREATIES

We have a reputation of being ‘investor unfriendly’ because of retrospective taxation and arbitrary changes of policy which are often adverse to foreign investors



ON COMPANIES INVESTING ABROAD

Setting up subsidiaries abroad is a natural way for them to expand. If in the next 20 years we don’t see more Indian manufactured products abroad, then the Indian private sector can be said to have failed the country

are also subject to extensive administered controls determined by state regulatory commissions, which are heavily influenced by state governments. Fertiliser prices are grossly distorted at present with urea being sold to farmers at 10 per cent of the cost of imported fertiliser. We need to review these controls and come up with a policy where these prices respond to global market conditions. Where the resulting price would hit vulnerable sections, we should compensate them through a direct cash transfer. Fortunately, the Aadhaar-based digital system now makes it possible to do this. These changes can be made over a five-year period but continuing with gross distortions in key prices is not feasible.

Managing water scarcity is another problem since water is not priced. Some of what we are doing, for instance, expanding use of methanol to mix with petrol and diesel may not be economically viable if water is properly costed. Large expansion of data centres will also come up against constraints of available water. These are very important problems which need to be spelt out and addressed.

Aakash Joshi: What did you make of the piece Surjit Bhalla wrote for The Indian Express (on May 23)?

Surjit holds the bureaucracy — which he calls the ‘deep state’ — responsible for perpetuating policies which prevent investors from investing in India. I don’t agree with his deep state description, but I agree that we need to review our policies to see why they discourage investors. That’s why I have recommended setting up a high-level committee, drawn from outside the government with its report being released for discussion. Relying on inside groups, whose reports are not made public cannot yield results. Some of the problems which concern foreign investors also trouble domestic investors, so solving them will be a double whammy.

Anil Sasi: One reason for the adverse net FDI inflows is that our manufacturers are not investing here, but outside.

I don’t think we should restrict our companies from investing abroad. Many Indian companies in the IT sector, pharmaceuticals and also others are working in a highly competitive global environment and they want to expand their footprint. Setting up subsidiaries and acquiring companies abroad are natural ways for them to expand and we should not stop it.

In the longer run, this will lead to a larger presence of Indian products and brand names abroad. That has not yet happened, but it is the next stage. If in the next 20 years we don’t see any many more Indian manufactured products abroad, then the Indian private sector can be said to have failed the country. But we should not end up in a situation where they say ‘we were keen to do this, but you didn’t allow us to expand abroad’. Many people say that some of the outward investment may represent Indians wishing to leave the country. We should look into why they want to do this and correct the domestic policy failures that generate this behaviour.

Liz Mathew: How much do you think economic issues influence a voter?

That is a very good question. As an economist, I always hope that politicians can sell a policy which will yield results in the longer run even if is not a winner in getting votes. So politicians have to select a package which also provides some tangible results in the short run. I know it is not easy, but that is the real job of politicians.

Sukalp Sharma: Given the global energy shock, do you feel it would be prudent if the government implemented demand suppression measure on fuel consumption?

If by demand suppression you mean raising fuel prices, yes that is the way to go. We have raised prices a little and the government has also taken a hit. They may have to do more if oil prices move up. If however, you mean ‘managing demand’ through some form of rationing, I feel that would not be workable. You cannot do it by saying only 15 litres will be available at the petrol pump at any given time. It will only lead to use of multiple pumps. You would have to issue entitlement certificates against which petrol and diesel can be bought. That is an impossible administrative task and will also be a disaster. You can be sure that such permits if issued to users would be sold in the black market.

Sukalp Sharma: You spoke of how fuel price deregulation is only on paper. Is a deregulated system better in times of volatility?

As I said, we announced that the administered price system was dismantled in 2002 but we didn’t really deregulate. I think as a matter of policy we should implement effective deregulation. Remember that as the number of vehicles increases, we need to ensure that more and more of them are EVs. Raising the price of petroleum products is a way of encouraging EVs. It is better than subsidising them. Perhaps, the NITI Aayog should prepare a discussion paper outlining how we can move to deregulated petroleum prices over say, a period of five years.

‘FTAs with Europe, UK good moves... should ensure industry doesn’t put pressure to take rigid positions’

Economist Montek Singh Ahluwalia on the need for a strategy for managing the balance of payments, price signals being suppressed, managing exports and why rupee depreciation, for the moment, is a good thing. The session was moderated by P Vaidyanathan Iyer, Managing Editor, The Indian Express



Economist Montek Singh Ahluwalia (right) in conversation with P Vaidyanathan Iyer, Managing Editor, The Indian Express, at the Noida office ABHINAV SAHA

Vietnam and Bangladesh, benefited from the China Plus One opportunity, but we did not. The root problem is that Indian industry has been excessively shielded from international competition making us less competitive in exports. The problem was worsened because import duties were raised on a number of items from 2016 onwards. These were inputs of MSMEs which also do a lot of exports. Since the rupee has weakened, these duties should now be lowered. It will help MSMEs and exporters.

The FTAs signed with Europe and the UK are very good moves, but they will only become operational when many details that need to be resolved are agreed upon. We should ensure that domestic industry does not put pressure on our negotiators to take rigid positions on these details on protectionist grounds. We should obviously protect substantive national interests but we should ensure that the FTAs become operational as soon as possible.

The Asia region is projected to be the fastest growing region in the years ahead, and we need to integrate more with this region. We decided not to join RCEP in 2015 probably because Indian industry was unwilling to face competition from China. We should now apply to join the Comprehensive and Progressive Agreement for Trans Pacific Partnership (CPTPP) where China is not a member. It will send a clear signal that India is determined to integrate more fully with the world economy.

The fall in capital flows also calls for corrective action but what we can do in the short run is limited. Portfolio investment is known to be volatile and Indian P/E ratios were over valued earlier. We can only assume these flows will come back as the world economy normalises and the India story comes back into play. The fall in net FDI is more worrying and calls for some re-

evaluation of our policy. An area where we can take early steps relates to improving the ease of doing business.

Some months ago, newspapers reported that the Committee examining the ease of doing business under Rajiv Gauba (former Cabinet Secretary and now Member NITI Aayog) had recommended withdrawal of almost 700 Quality Control Orders (QCOs). I thought this was an excellent recommendation but I believe only about 200 QCOs have been removed. QCOs are a disguised form of the import licence permit raj. It would send a very good signal if the government implemented the Gauba Committee recommendation in full. This can be done immediately. Open-ended reliance on QCOs creates uncertainty about policy.

The unilateral decision in 2015 to scrap all existing Bilateral Investment Treaties (BITs) may also account for what has happened to FDI flows. Investments already made under the old BITs would continue to receive protection for some years, but for all new investments there is no protection. It was announced a year ago that a new BIT would be released but it has not yet happened.

The absence of a BIT may not matter when the country is experiencing high growth, FDI is flowing in, and investors have a good story to tell. It is a different matter if there are more exits than entries. The negative effect is magnified if we have acquired a reputation of being ‘investor unfriendly’ action, because of retrospective taxation, and arbitrary changes of policy

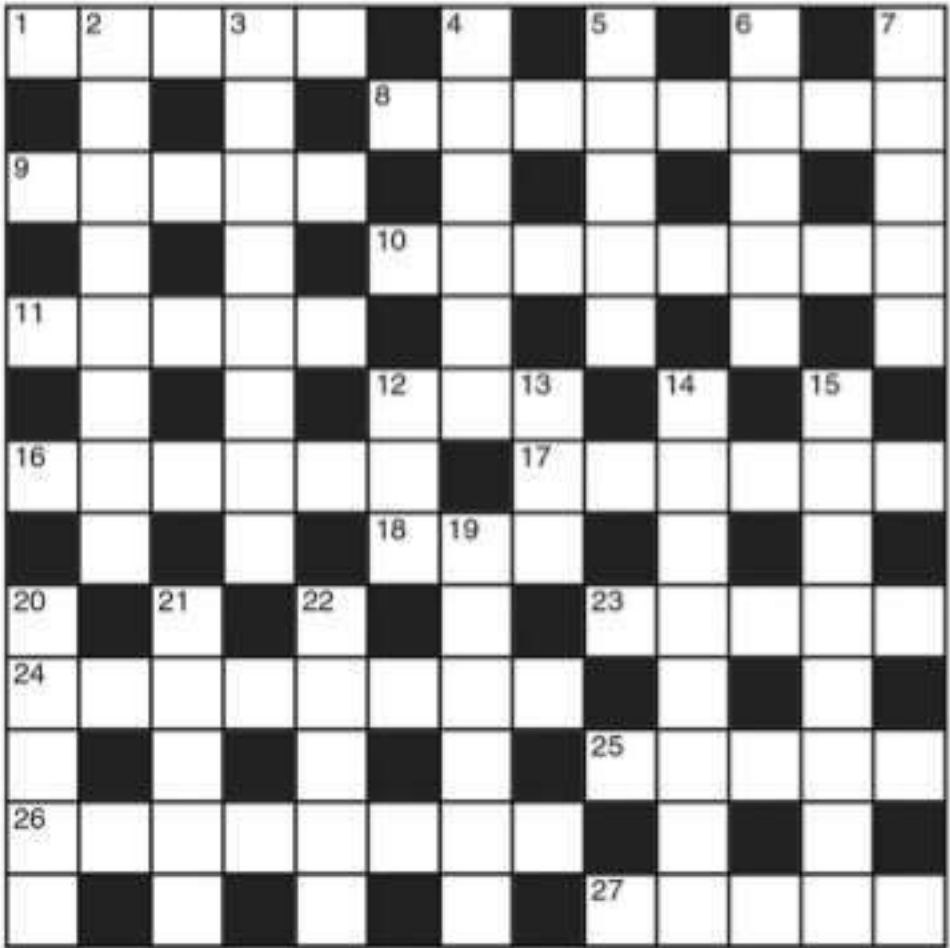
ON FUEL PRICE DEREGULATION

As the number of vehicles increases, we need to ensure that more of them are electric vehicles (EVs). Raising the price of petroleum products is a way of encouraging EVs. It is better than subsidising them



SCAN THE QR CODE TO WATCH THE VIDEO

CROSSWORD



- ACROSS**
1 Spring tide say (5)
8 Spring maintained in good order (4,4)
9 Stone made entrance (5)
10 Storage place for a trophy near the table (8)
11 At home help is given back to the country (5)
12 Deep black stream (3)
16 Complaint about Ma's hat (6)
17 Dead or possibly worshipped (6)
18 Be sociable and create a stir (3)
23 Admit pound note is forged (3,2)
24 Shanties add spice to Gilbert and Sullivan (3,5)
25 Flat country lacking beauty (5)
26 New form of travel in space (8)
27 Solid in form, they may have fragile footing (5)
- DOWN**
2 Trio sang composition of this musician (8)
3 Left in error? (3,5)
4 Read through and turn to account (6)
5 All countries appear bent on it (5)
6 Don't allow an untidy beard (5)
7 Room for some learning (5)
12 Preserve congestion (3)
13 It has to be paid when I leave the cab (3)
14 The mannequin went ahead and posed (8)
15 Something to remind one in passing (8)
19 Dressed up and ready to go? (2,4)
20 Moving out of bed (5)
21 It may be called for as the situation changes (5)
22 Meals provided for the directors (5)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6002 **ACROSS:** 1 Manipulate, 6 Clef, 10 Dogma, 11 Destroyer, 12 Stampede, 13 Tarot, 15 Maidens, 17 Aerosol, 19 Re-enter, 21 Seaways, 22 Pasta, 24 Pea green, 27 Principal, 28 Chair, 29 Rank, 30 Crowd scene **DOWN:** 1 Made, 2 Night life, 3 Psalm, 4 Ladders, 5 Tessera, 7 Layer, 8 First flush, 9 Criteria, 14 Emery paper, 16 Entrance, 18 Space race, 20 Repaper, 21 Swallow, 23 Scion, 25 Racks, 26 Brie

JUMBLLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

What appears ___ today will be ___ tomorrow. - Franz Marc (8,..7)

BSAAE

AARRS

EILLTT

OOCNPU

ANSWER: What appears spectral today will be natural tomorrow. - Franz Marc

OVER THE HEDGE



CALVIN & HOBBS



MARVIN



DIFFICULTY LEVEL 5s
INSTRUCTIONS
To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

SUDOKU 6336

			9					
		3		8		7	2	
							5	4
4				6	7			
	6		8		4		1	
			2	3				6
1	7	4						
	2	5		7		3		
					8			

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6335

2	5	4	1	8	9	6	3	7
3	7	1	2	4	6	8	5	9
6	8	9	3	7	5	2	1	4
4	1	5	7	2	3	9	8	6
8	2	6	5	9	4	3	7	1
9	3	7	8	6	1	5	4	2
7	4	2	9	5	8	1	6	3
5	9	3	6	1	7	4	2	8
1	6	8	4	3	2	7	9	5

NHSRCL National High Speed Rail Corporation Limited organised a two-day workshop on High-Speed Rail Signalling & Telecommunication (S&T) Technologies, aimed at strengthening India's high-speed rail infrastructure. The workshop brought together industry leaders, global technology companies, experts, academicians, and policymakers to deliberate on standards and specifications for High-Speed Rail S&T systems. Participants engaged in technical presentations, case studies, and interactive knowledge-sharing sessions focusing on interoperability, localisation, safety, innovation, and global best practices. The discussions highlighted the need for future-ready technologies tailored to India's evolving transportation ecosystem. The workshop marked an important milestone towards building a robust, sustainable, and self-reliant high-speed rail network in the country.

PNB Punjab National Bank has signed a MoU with the Directorate General Assam Rifles in Shillong to provide enhanced banking and insurance benefits to serving personnel and pensioners under its "PNB Rakshak Plus" scheme. The agreement was exchanged in the presence of Lt General Vikas Lakhera, AVSM, SM, Director General Assam Rifles, senior defence officials, and bank representatives. Under the scheme, Assam Rifles personnel will receive accidental insurance coverage up to Rs 150 lakh, disability protection, and additional operational death cover. PNB will also offer health insurance benefits, concessions on retail loans, and special schemes for dependents and families. The bank reaffirmed its commitment to supporting and honouring India's uniformed services.

SCOPE Standing Conference of Public Enterprises, led by Director General Shri Atul Sobti, hosted a high-level meeting with the Deutsche Gesellschaft für Internationale Zusammenarbeit (GIZ) India team led by Country Director Ms. Ulrike Ebeling. The meeting focused on strengthening collaboration to support Public Sector Enterprises (PSEs) in climate mitigation, industrial decarbonisation, knowledge exchange, and climate capacity building. Senior officials from both organisations discussed future strategic collaborations aimed at accelerating climate action and sustainability initiatives across PSEs. The partnership reflects the shared commitment of SCOPE and GIZ to enhance technical capacities and advance long-term environmental goals.

SAIL Steel Authority of India Limited signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with Management Development Institute Gurgaon (MDI Gurgaon) on May 20, 2026, at SAIL Corporate Office in New Delhi to collaborate on Executive Education Programmes aimed at developing future-ready leaders within the organisation. The partnership will focus on customised leadership programmes, innovation-driven learning, overseas learning initiatives, joint research, consulting, and case studies tailored for SAIL executives. The MoU was signed by Shri Sanjay Dhar, ED (HR-L&D), MTI, SAIL and Prof Sumita Rai, Dean-Industry Connect, MDI Gurgaon, in the presence of Shri K. K. Singh, Director (Personnel), and senior officials from both organisations.

Rotary Club of Delhi Imperial organised a large-scale Cycle Donation Drive at Kerala School, RK Puram, distributing over 500 bicycles to meritorious Class 12 students who scored 80% and above in board examinations. Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta attended the event as Chief Guest and praised the initiative for supporting education and student mobility. The programme was also attended by Bansuri Swaraj, MLA Anil Kumar Sharma, and District Governor Rtn. Dr. Amita Mohindru. Convenor Dinesh Gupta said the initiative aimed to ensure deserving students are not hindered by transportation challenges while also promoting health and environmental awareness.

NBCC (India) Limited signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with State Bank of India (SBI) on May 15, 2026, to extend a comprehensive Corporate Salary Package (CSP) to NBCC employees. The agreement was signed by Smt. Jyostna Rani Moharana, DGM, SBI, and Shri Sanjeev Kumar, CGM (HRM), NBCC, in the presence of senior officials from both organisations, including Shri Anjeev Kumar Jain, Director (Finance), NBCC. Under the MoU, employees will receive a range of financial protection benefits, including personal and accident insurance, permanent and temporary disability group term life insurance, health insurance, top-up facilities, and concessions on loan facilities. The initiative aims to enhance employee welfare and financial security through customised banking and insurance solutions.

POWERGRID Power Grid Corporation of India Limited, a Maharashtra PSU under the Ministry of Power, organised its analysts meet in Mumbai where CMD Shri Vamsi Rama Mohan Burra, along with senior directors and officials, interacted with analysts and shared the company's operational achievements and growth plans. As of April 30, 2026, POWERGRID has commissioned and is operating 291 substations, more than 1,85,102 circuit kilometres of transmission lines, and 6,28,516 MVA transformation capacity across the country. The company stated that the adoption of advanced technologies, automation, and digital solutions has helped maintain an average transmission system availability of over 99.78%, reinforcing its leadership in India's power transmission sector.

Calendar

BY MICHAEL FRY & T LEWIS

ROYAL STARS

BY GEORGIA NICOLS

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): For the next month, home and family will be a stronger focus for you. Family discussions will take place and, no doubt, many of you will explore doing repairs and DIY projects. Short trips and a chance to meet new faces. Tonight: You're admired.

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): You have the energy to work and accomplish what you want. Financial matters are a focus for you. Enjoy the beauty of your daily surroundings. Group discussions and conversations will increase. Tonight: Explore and learn.

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): This is a strong time. It's your turn to recharge your batteries for the rest of year. Today Mercury enters your Money House, turning your attention to whatever you value in life. Tonight: Check your finances

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): Today Mercury enters your sign to stay until it goes retrograde on the 29th. Finally, on July 23, it will move forward until it leaves your sign on Aug. 10. This long sojourn will make you keen to talk, travel and learn more. Tonight: Listen and cooperate.

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): You're popular this week, which means you'll be more involved with friends, groups and organisations. However, you will also be doing work behind the scenes either doing research. Tonight: Work and get organised.

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): You make a favourable impression on everyone this week. Today, Mercury moves into your house of friendships highlighting group ideals and standards. You might encounter younger people. You will definitely give thought to your goals. Tonight: Socialise.

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): You're eager for a change of scenery and a chance to break free of your routine, which is why many of you want to travel. Meanwhile, today you will also make plans for your future. Tonight: Relax at home.

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): Continue to be patient with partners, close friends and spouses while fiery Mars is opposite your sign this month. Meanwhile, today Mercury will encourage you to study and learn as much as possible in the next six weeks. Tonight: A lively discussion.

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): You need more rest this month. Nevertheless, you will find energy to work and accomplish a lot. Mercury changes signs, which will highlight discussions and negotiations about shared property, taxes and debt. Tonight: Check your money.

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): You're keen to work hard and get things done; however, you also want to socialise and get involved in competitive sports. Romance will be hot. Discussions with partners and close friends are encouraged. Tonight: You win.

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): The tone of the next several weeks is pleasure and fun. Socialise as much as possible. Enjoy fun outings. You will accomplish a lot at work because you're ready to dig in. Tonight: Enjoy privacy.

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): Home and family are your focus. Travel appeals and your conversations with others are enthusiastic. Mercury changes signs and moves into the most playful part of your chart, encouraging social outings and romance. Tonight: Be friendly.

CORPORATE BRIEFS

IIT Jodhpur Researchers at Indian Institute of Technology Jodhpur are advancing futuristic materials science through atom-scale engineering of advanced two-dimensional (2D) materials. Led by Dr. Pranay Ranjan at the NanoSense Lab, the team is pioneering research on borophene, an ultra-light metallic material with applications in high-performance batteries, supercapacitors, gas sensors, and nanoelectronics. The researchers have successfully synthesized freestanding borophene and are also working on graphene, graphene oxide, and hematene for applications in hydrogen generation, coatings, and electronics. In collaboration with the New Materials Division of Tata Group, IIT Jodhpur is scaling up indigenous production of advanced materials for defence, electronics, and energy storage sectors. The lab has also developed a self-glowing paint technology that emits light at night without electricity, offering applications in road safety and smart infrastructure. Additionally, borophene-based gas sensors are being developed for industrial safety and environmental monitoring.

DAV School Noida achieved a major milestone at the MATE Counsellors' Conclave jointly organised by All India Institute of Medical Sciences and Central Board of Secondary Education. Under the guidance of Principal Ms. Upasana Sharma, the school's initiative "Stories of Strength and Best Practices in Counselling" secured First Prize among more than 49 CBSE schools. Mentor Ms. Swati and the participants celebrated the achievement with great enthusiasm. The award was presented by Mr. Himanshu Gupta, Secretary, CBSE, in the presence of Dr. Niti Mohan Sharma, Head - Counselling and PR, CBSE. The accomplishment once again highlighted the school's excellence in nurturing talent and promoting innovative counselling practices.

Convocation Dr. B. R. Ambedkar University Delhi celebrated its 14th Annual Convocation Ceremony on 14 May 2026 at the University of Delhi's Multipurpose Hall. The event was attended by Lt. Governor and Chancellor Sardar Taranjit Singh Sandhu, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, and Education Minister Ashish Sood. Vice Chancellor Anu Singh Lather announced that 1,030 students completed various academic programmes, including undergraduate, postgraduate, PhD, and diploma courses. She highlighted the university's commitment to gender equity, noting strong women representation among graduates. Dignitaries encouraged students to combine academic excellence with social responsibility and contribute meaningfully towards the vision of Viksit Bharat 2047.

Bank of India's Field General Manager Office (FGMO), New Delhi, organised a Customer Outreach Programme under the ECLGS 5.0 scheme in the presence of Executive Director Shri Subrat Kumar and General Manager Shri Mukesh Kumar Jha. More than 80 customers from the New Delhi and Delhi-NCR zones attended the event. Bank officials presented various SME and retail banking schemes, while loan sanction letters were distributed to customers. The programme also featured an interactive session where customer queries and suggestions were addressed by senior officials.

KRIBHCO organized a "Run for Fun" event on 16 May 2026 near Sector 33, Noida, to promote fitness, wellness, and team spirit among employees. The 3 km run, exclusively for staff members, witnessed enthusiastic participation from around 100 employees of KRIBHCO and its subsidiaries. The event aimed to encourage regular physical activity and spread awareness about the importance of a healthy lifestyle and workplace positivity. Shri S. S. Yadav, Managing Director, attended as Chief Guest and flagged off the run. Senior officials including Mr. Manish Kumar, Mr. C. S. Azad, Mr. R. Venkat, and others motivated participants with their presence. Winners across various categories were felicitated, making the event more exciting and inspiring for all participants.

POWERGRID Power Grid Corporation of India Limited, a Maharashtra company under the Ministry of Power, reported strong financial results for Q4FY26 and FY26. On a standalone basis, the company posted Profit After Tax (PAT) of Rs. 15,921 crore and total income of Rs. 46,996 crore for FY26. Consolidated PAT stood at Rs. 15,928 crore with total income of Rs. 47,684 crore. For Q4FY26, standalone PAT was reported at Rs. 4,553 crore with total income of Rs. 11,955 crore. The company also proposed a final dividend of Rs. 1.25 per share, taking the total dividend for FY26 to Rs. 9 per share, including interim dividend already paid. At the end of FY26, POWERGRID operated 1,84,960 circuit kilometres of transmission lines, 291 substations, and 6,24,016 MVA transformation capacity, while maintaining transmission system availability of 99.84%. The company also approved the merger of several subsidiaries to improve operational efficiency and governance.

SAIL Steel Authority of India Limited reported a strong financial performance for FY 2025-26, achieving its highest-ever production, sales volume, and revenue from operations. The company's crude steel production increased to 19.43 million tonnes, while sales volume rose 11.4% to 19.93 million tonnes. Revenue from operations grew to Rs. 1,10,810 crore compared to Rs. 1,02,478 crore in FY25. SAIL's Profit After Tax (PAT) surged 50.5% to Rs. 3,233 crore, supported by improved operational efficiency, inventory reduction, cost optimisation, and better techno-economic performance. The company also reduced debt by Rs. 8,148 crore during the year. For Q4 FY26, PAT stood at Rs. 1,680 crore against Rs. 1,178 crore in the corresponding quarter last year, while revenue from operations increased to Rs. 30,813 crore. The Board recommended a final dividend of Rs. 2.35 per equity share. CMD A.K. Panda said the company will focus on increasing the share of value-added and special steel while leveraging growing domestic demand driven by infrastructure development.

Punjab & Sind Bank aims to achieve total business of Rs. 3 lakh crore by March 2027, said MD & CEO Swarup Kumar Saha during a Town Hall Meeting held in Dehradun under the theme "One Team, One Mission." The event witnessed participation from over 140 staff members from the Dehradun region. The bank reported its highest-ever net profit of Rs. 1,322 crore and total business of Rs. 2.63 lakh crore during FY 2025-26, along with 18% growth in advances and 29% growth in MSME lending. The MD & CEO also cautioned citizens against cyber fraud and digital arrest scams. Bank officials highlighted new digital loan facilities through a single QR code and expansion plans across Uttarakhand to improve customer banking services.

Almawakening Foundation, in collaboration with Dr. Shroff's Charity Eye Hospital, organised a special empowerment programme under its "Enable Program" to support visually impaired individuals through assistive technology. During the event, 26 beneficiaries received AI-enabled smart vision glasses designed to assist with mobility, reading, navigation, object recognition, facial recognition, currency detection, emergency SOS, and independent living. The programme was attended by Dr. Alma Chopra, founder of Almawakening Foundation, officials from Dr. Shroff's Charity Eye Hospital, and other dignitaries. Live demonstrations showcased how the devices enhance accessibility, confidence, and safety for visually impaired users. The initiative reflects the shared commitment of both organisations to promoting inclusion, accessibility, and innovation through technology-driven solutions for persons with disabilities.

Uttarakhand Gramin Bank reported strong growth during the financial year with total business reaching Rs. 14,403 crore and net profit rising to Rs. 83.79 crore. The bank opened nine new branches and achieved 93% digital transactions. It maintained Net NPA at zero and strengthened financial inclusion through SHG financing and PMJDY accounts while expanding customer outreach across Uttarakhand.

Central Bank of India organised a Mega MSME Credit Outreach Program in Dehradun under the leadership of Deputy Zonal Head Shri T.C. Meena. Held at the Development Block Office on Tapovan Road, the programme witnessed participation from around 80 beneficiaries, with loan sanction letters worth Rs. 83 crore distributed during the event. Shri Sanjeev Rai, Joint Director, attended as Chief Guest along with Regional Head Shri Rajat Bajaj and senior bank officials. The bank highlighted various MSME-focused schemes including Cent Hotel, Cent Business, and Cent Shop, offering competitive interest rates and minimal processing charges. Officials encouraged entrepreneurs to take advantage of the bank's credit outreach initiatives and assured prompt grievance resolution and customer support.

Punjab National Bank organised a Mega Agricultural Expo at Selauqui, Dehradun, to promote farmers, SHGs, and rural entrepreneurs. The event was inaugurated by D. Surendran in the presence of senior bank officials. SHGs displayed agricultural produce, handicrafts, and self-employment products. Agricultural loan sanction letters were distributed to beneficiaries. The expo generated 80 leads worth Rs. 14 crore for the Circle Office and 540 leads worth Rs. 130 crore for the Zonal Office, Dehradun.

REC Limited will provide Rs. 1.40 crore under its CSR initiative for the "Green Innovator Immersive Learning Lab" project in 10 government schools in Karnal, Haryana. Implemented by I-Hub Foundation for Cobotics, the project will promote AR, VR, STEM education, coding, robotics, and digital literacy among students.

HURL Hindustan Urvarak & Rasayan Limited Barauni inaugurated a Multiskilling Centre at Chakballi and a modern Health ATM at UPHC Sokhara, Barauni, under its CSR initiatives aimed at promoting healthcare and skill development. The programmes were inaugurated by the Plant Head, Barauni, in the presence of healthcare officials, local representatives, and community members. The Multiskilling Centre will provide industry-relevant vocational training to around 875 beneficiaries, enhancing employability and supporting self-reliance among local youth. Meanwhile, the Health ATM has been equipped with advanced digital diagnostic facilities capable of conducting multiple health check-ups within minutes, improving preventive healthcare and early disease detection. HURL reiterated its commitment to inclusive growth, community welfare, and sustainable social development in the region.

{ WEEKLY CAPSULE }

Drug to stop fatty liver disease

SCIENTISTS AT the University of San Diego have unveiled a potentially game-changing treatment for people with metabolic dysfunction-associated steatohepatitis (MASH), an aggressive form of fatty liver disease strongly linked to obesity and Type 2 diabetes. The condition can quietly progress for years before leading to cirrhosis, liver failure or liver cancer. The experimental drug, ION224, blocks a liver enzyme that drives fat buildup and inflammation, two key forces behind liver damage. In clinical trials, patients showed striking improvements in liver health, even without losing weight.



Beet juice lowers BP in 2 weeks

DRINKING NITRATE-RICH beetroot juice may do more than support heart health — it could actually reshape the bacteria living in the mouth in ways that help lower blood pressure in older adults. In the largest study of its kind, researchers at the University of Exeter found that older people who drank concentrated beetroot juice twice daily for two weeks experienced noticeable blood pressure reductions, while younger adults did not. Oral bacteria help convert nitrate from food into compounds that eventually support the production of nitric oxide. This helps blood vessels relax and function properly.



Reverse brain ageing with nose spray

WHAT IF some of the mental decline linked to ageing could actually be undone? Researchers at Texas A&M University have found a way to do just that using a simple nasal spray designed to reduce inflammation in the brain. They showed how the treatment restored memory, reduced chronic inflammation and improved brain cell function after just two doses. The findings could lead to new therapies for conditions tied to ageing and cognitive decline, including dementia and Alzheimer's Disease. The therapy relies on microscopic particles loaded with microRNAs, molecules that help regulate key biological processes.



Obesity attacks facial nerves

SCIENTISTS AT Helmholtz Munich and Ludwig Maximilians University Munich (LMU), have created an AI-powered system that can scan and map an entire mouse body in extraordinary detail — and it just uncovered a surprising new effect of obesity. Beyond disrupting metabolism, obesity appears to damage facial sensory nerves linked to touch and sensation, while also triggering widespread inflammation across the body. The study also identified similar molecular patterns in human tissue, suggesting that important aspects of obesity-related nerve damage may occur in both mice and people.



Junk food rewires brain for life

EATING TOO much junk food early in life may rewire the brain in ways that last into adulthood, even after switching to a healthier diet. Scientists found that high-fat, high-sugar diets changed feeding behaviour and disrupted appetite-control regions in the brain. Researchers at University College Cork (UCC) also found that beneficial gut bacteria and prebiotic fibres could help reduce some of these long-term effects and support healthier eating behaviour later in life. The team linked these behavioural effects to disruptions in the hypothalamus, a brain region responsible for regulating appetite and energy balance.



Researchers find a protein that halts brain decline

Low levels of a brain protein called Menin drive ageing & inflammation

SCIENTISTS MAY have uncovered a hidden biological switch that helps control how quickly the body ages. Research published in *PLOS Biology* suggests that declining levels of a brain protein called Menin can trigger inflammation, memory decline and other age-related changes throughout the body. In experiments with mice, restoring the protein reversed several signs of ageing, while a simple amino acid supplement improved cognitive function.

The findings add to growing evidence that ageing may be strongly influenced by the hypothalamus, a small but powerful brain region that regulates metabolism, hormones, body temperature, sleep and stress responses. Researchers increasingly view the hypothalamus as a central command centre for aging itself.

The study, led by Lige Leng and colleagues at Xiamen University in China, focused on Menin, a protein that helps suppress inflammation in the brain. Earlier work had already shown that Menin plays an important role in controlling neuroinflammatory activity. The team wanted to know whether losing this protective protein might contribute to ageing. Their experiments revealed that Menin levels dropped sharply in the hypothalamus as mice grew older. The decline occurred specifically in neurons within the ventromedial hypothalamus (VMH), a region linked to metabolism and systemic ageing. Interestingly, Menin levels did not significantly decrease in nearby support cells such as astrocytes or microglia.

Menin levels dropped sharply in the hypothalamus of lab mice as they grew older. It's a protein that helps suppress inflammation

To investigate what this loss might mean, the researchers engineered mice in which Menin activity could be selectively reduced. The effects were striking. Younger mice with lower Menin levels developed increased brain inflammation, thinning skin, lower bone mass, impaired balance, memory problems and a shorter lifespan compared to normal mice. The results suggest that Menin may act as a protective "anti-ageing" factor inside the brain. One of the most surprising discoveries involved D-serine, an amino acid that also functions as a neurotransmitter in the brain. D-serine helps regulate communication between neurons and is important for learning and memory. When Menin levels fell, D-serine production also dropped. The researchers traced this effect to reduced activity of an enzyme required for D-serine synthesis, which itself appears to be regulated by Menin. D-serine naturally occurs in foods including soybeans, eggs, fish and nuts, and is also sold as a dietary supplement.

The connection caught the attention of researchers because other studies have linked declining D-serine levels with ageing-related cognitive impairment and reduced synaptic plasticity, which means the brain's ability to strengthen neural connections involved in memory and learning.

After 60, they return to class to take care of themselves and peers

Elderly citizens at TISS, Mumbai, are learning how to navigate ageing with dignity, companionship and a fresh sense of purpose

Purnima Sah

ON A Friday evening in Mumbai's Tata Institute of Social Sciences (TISS), long after most college campuses begin to empty out, a different kind of classroom fills up. A retired Bhabha Atomic Research Centre (BARC) scientist walks in carrying handwritten notes. Beside him sits a former schoolteacher from Hyderabad. A homemaker in her 60s quietly adjusts her spectacles before opening a notebook. Someone else has rushed in after finishing caregiving duties at home.

There are no discussions about second life placements or corporate careers. Instead, the lesson begins with a question: How to manage the process of growing old, specially when one is alone? A faculty member projects an image of the human brain and begins explaining dementia and cognitive decline. The discussion quickly moves beyond medicine. Students speak about parents forgetting names, elderly relatives repeating stories or withdrawing after their children migrate abroad. One student recalls watching his father age rapidly after his mother died. Another talks about the silent exhaustion of caregiving. In another session, soft music fills the room as students participate in dance therapy and art exercises, later explained as methods used to stimulate memory and emotional expression among older adults. Many laugh awkwardly at first. Weeks later, the same group will be staging a street play on ageing and loneliness.

These are among the experiences shaping students enrolled in TISS' one-year diploma in gerontology, a part-time programme, where elderly Indians are learning not only about ageing but also about survival, companionship and purpose in later life. "India is witnessing a major demographic shift with people aged 60 and above projected to form nearly 20 per cent of the population by 2050. Loneliness, caregiving stress, emotional neglect, social isolation and the need for dignified ageing are emerging as critical concerns," says Dr Saigita Chituru, assistant professor at the Centre for Lifelong Learning and faculty coordinator for the programme, which was launched in 2008. Open to candidates above 25 years of age, it combines classroom teaching with field-based experiential learning focused on the biological, psychological, social and economic dimensions of ageing. Over the



Elderly participants at a class on gerontology at TISS, Mumbai AMIT CHAKRAVARTY

last couple of years, it has opened to the elderly, helping them help themselves. The programme currently admits around 30 students each year. Classes are held on Friday evenings and Saturdays over two semesters, with course fees of around Rs 63,000.

Learning to teaching

At 67, when most people are expected to settle into retirement, Prakash Apte walks into the classroom to study ageing. "For years, I have seen older people around me struggling with loneliness and neglect. I wanted to understand what ageing really means and how society can respond to it," says Apte, a student from the 2021-22 batch of TISS' diploma in gerontology programme. A yoga teacher, the course has given him a structured understanding of the challenges faced by senior citizens, from loneliness and declining health to the absence of support systems. "India's elderly population is rising rapidly but support for them is still extremely limited. Most policies remain on paper," he says. He now conducts awareness sessions for senior citizen groups, combining gerontology lessons with yoga practices suited for older adults. He also hopes to launch a social enterprise focused on helping elderly people living alone.

Students are allowed to ask the most uncomfortable of questions, from retirement planning and elder abuse to grief, emotional neglect and the fear of dependency — Who will care for you in old age? What happens when children move away? How does one emotionally prepare for ageing?

For 76-year-old Arun Rahulkar, a retired senior scientific officer from BARC, the course has been a way to renew a sense of purpose. "Retirement creates a vacuum. Your children move away and suddenly you are left wondering what your purpose is. This course taught me how to age with dignity and meaning," he says. After completing the diploma, Rahulkar enrolled in a



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three-year light music course. He now spends time travelling, practising music and conducting awareness sessions for senior citizens. "People think retirement means sitting idle. But if you remain engaged and socially connected, ageing gets easier," he says.

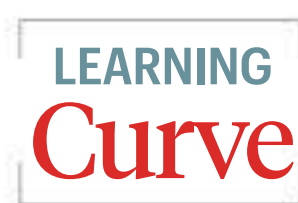
For Millind Patil, 59, who works in the oil and gas sector, the course helped him process years of caregiving stress after caring for ageing parents. His mother died in 2020, while his 95-year-old father continues to live with him. "I have seen ageing very closely in my own house," says Patil, a student from the 2024-25 batch. He is now building a senior citizens' community in Amravati. "Migration has left elderly people in villages and small towns alone," he says.

Practical life lessons

The learning often extends beyond the classroom. Students visit old age homes, NGOs, hospitals and low-income settlements, including Dharavi, where they spend time listening to elderly residents speak about abandonment, illness and isolation. One student recalls interviewing an elderly woman while her son repeatedly shouted at her in front of them. Another remembers bedridden seniors who simply wanted someone to sit beside them without rushing away. The course has introduced students to concepts such as neuroplasticity, cognitive stimulation and dementia care, while field visits exposed them to the realities faced by economically weaker elderly populations.

Patil says modules involving art therapy, music therapy and street theatre have helped students like him overcome social hesitation and reconnect emotionally with themselves. "I had never performed before an audience. At 59, I have gained confidence and empathy," he says.

For many women, the classroom has become a space for rediscovering identity after decades spent caring for others. Ela Thakur



CUTTING EDGE

How AI maps are helping India find hidden TB cases before it's too late

Technology is changing how healthcare workers amp up the national TB screening programme

Anonna Dutt

ON THE first floor of a polyclinic in Haryana's Ambala, a health worker logs into the government TB programme's Ni-kshay portal. She clicks on a map of Haryana to check where she should plan her screening camps. All the villages and wards are colour coded red, yellow or green to show the density of the vulnerable population, indicating people who are more likely to have TB. She narrows down on a red patch, a high-risk zone.

This AI-generated map is a new tool in the arsenal of health workers under the National TB Elimination programme. It uses data from nearly 30 open-source geospatial datasets such as population density, nutritional profile, access to health centres — proxies for vulnerability of a population to TB — to create a map of places where health

workers are likely to find more TB cases. Called Vulnerability Mapping for Tuberculosis (VMTB), it was piloted in Haryana and Assam before being rolled out across the country under the ongoing 100-day campaign. Smokers, people with diabetes or other respiratory conditions and those who are malnourished are considered to be vulnerable populations for TB. The challenge, however, is that there is no nationwide registry for these conditions. So, how do you find the at-risk population?

"VMTB takes about 30 open-source datasets of socio-demographic and geospatial data. This includes nutrition profiles, NFHS-4 data, presence of night lights and so on. Along with data on historically confirmed TB cases, the AI can predict geospatial vulnerability down to the village and ward level, in fact, down to a 500x500 metre tile," says Dr Neeraj Agrawal, chief programme officer



A district programme coordinator uses the tool to identify sites for her next camp

at Wadhvani AI, which developed the programme for the government.

This helps health workers concentrate their resources on areas where more people are likely to get diagnosed during active screening camps, where more cases are

likely to be found by testing fewer people. This would ensure early diagnosis of many and fewer people missing from the treatment net. This is essential as the country moves towards eliminating the condition — while India's 2025 deadline has been missed,

the global deadline of 2030 remains.

Dr Rajesh Raju, state TB officer for Haryana, says, "There are 6,237 gram panchayats in Haryana. Last year, 35 per cent of these were declared TB-free as they had an incidence of less than one per million population. That leaves us with 4,080 gram panchayats where we would need to focus, something that can be very challenging. This tool has helped us identify 1,968 villages and some more wards, a total of 2,111 high-risk areas where we would be concentrating during the current 100-day campaign. So we can focus 100 per cent of our efforts on 50 per cent of the areas. This has increased our efficiency as well as effectiveness."

This decreased workload has also led to a change in strategy during the current 100-day programme. Instead of testing only the vulnerable populations, the health workers are now screening everyone in these high-risk villages. "With VMTB, now 100 per cent X-ray coverage of the adult population is being attempted in these villages," he adds.

This effort is aided by another AI-technology — a portable hand-held X-ray machine that can screen a person within sec-

onds with an AI-aided tool. Those who show positive indicators for TB have to then give a sputum sample for a confirmatory test. "Our camps look neutral; we do not screen people only for TB. We also conduct routine tests such as BP and blood sugar so that there is less stigma around getting a medical check-up. Getting an X-ray report within minutes — instead of travelling several kilometres to the nearest health centre — is a big draw for patients," says community health officer Avaneeta Sandhu. Patients get their diagnosis the next day. The mapping tool has another use, says Dr Seema Tanwar, civil surgeon, Ambala. "Once the focused activity is over, we can choose the green or yellow villages and screen vulnerable populations to make these villages TB-free."

The tool was trialled in Haryana and Assam. Data from these two states show that there was a 251 per cent relative increase in the yield of TB cases in Haryana and 61 per cent in Assam last year. More than two lakh TB cases were diagnosed, accounting for nearly 10 per cent of the 25 lakh cases detected last year.

I said to a few of the boys that it doesn't feel like the same pressure as last year. We knew what kind of ability we have in the group. There's a reason why we got here first. And we just said one thing... If we stick to our cricket, if we execute our plans, we are the best team in the competition.

VIRAT KOHLI, ON ROYAL CHALLENGERS BENGALURU'S CONFIDENCE IN THE PLAYOFFS

INDIAN PREMIER LEAGUE FINAL

Wait for ages... then two come along



Virat Kohli's 75 from 42 balls helped Royal Challengers Bengaluru chase down a target of 156 at the Narendra Modi Stadium on Sunday. PRAVEEN KHANNA

Short story: How RCB sniped Titans' batters

Shankar Narayan
Ahmedabad, May 31

THE ROYAL Challengers Bengaluru attack in IPL 2026 had built a reputation for leaving opposition teams in trouble by swinging the new ball, finding outside edges and rattling stumps. It was a method opponents had seen repeatedly through the season.

Gujarat Titans, however, appeared to arrive with a different plan on Sunday. Rather than allowing RCB's pacers to dictate terms, Shubman Gill and B Sai Sudharsan looked to attack the swinging ball and put the bowlers under pressure. The first two overs yielded 18 runs as the pair pierced a packed off-side field with a series of crisp strokes.

Strong teams recognise early when conditions are not unfolding as expected. RCB were about to demonstrate why they have become one of the most efficient sides in the tournament - not just because of their skills with bat and ball, but because of their awareness of when a game demands a change in approach.

The short-ball switch

Realising that pitching the ball up was not producing the desired results, Bhuvneshwar Kumar and Josh Hazlewood, led by the latter, switched plans as early as the third over and began attacking the pitch. The adjustment paid off immediately.



Bhuvneshwar Kumar (R) celebrates a wicket. PRAVEEN KHANNA

After being struck for four off the first ball of the over, Hazlewood produced a delivery that climbed sharply from a length. Gill had premeditated the pull and charged down the pitch, only for the extra bounce to rush him. The result was a sliced stroke that ballooned towards mid-off. Rajat Patidar sprinted past both the bowler and umpire before completing an excellent catch to end Gill's stay at the crease. Bhuvneshwar has never relied on pace throughout his career, but he has often been capable of surprising batters with bounce when he bends his back and hits the surface harder than expected. That became the basis for the second breakthrough.

Sudharsan had begun fluently with two boundaries,

but a leg-side caught-behind appeal - initially given out before being overturned - appeared to disrupt his rhythm. Twice afterwards, his bottom hand came off the bat, thereby threatening the same mode of dismissals from the previous two matches. Bhuvneshwar sensed an opportunity and followed the same blueprint.

Bounce does damage

The short delivery outside off in the fourth over forced Sudharsan to reach for the ball rather than attack it from a comfortable position. The connection was poor, and Jitesh Sharma covered significant ground to short fine-leg to complete another fine catch. At 26/2, GT were in trouble. RCB had once again

Number Plate

45

● GT were only able to score 45 runs in their final Powerplay of the 2026 IPL season. It is their second-lowest PP score this season, ahead of the 36 they managed against SRH at the same venue.

cracked open an innings inside the powerplay, but this time not through swing or seam movement. It was bounce that did the damage.

The tactic was not limited to the new ball. Washington Sundar nearly fell to a rising Jacob Duffy delivery in the 10th over, only for substitute fielder Jordan Coxto not take the catch cleanly. Even though the wicket did not come, the moment served as a reminder that the surface still had life despite the older ball.

Arshad Khan, brought into the side for R Sai Kishore, attempted to counterattack. Two sixes in his first four balls off Duffy suggested he might shift momentum.

Instead, Hazlewood shut the door. Reintroduced in the 15th over with a semi-new ball, the Australian banged one hard into the pitch. Arshad was cramped for room, top-edged the pull, and picked out Rasikh Salam Dar at short fine leg.

Nor was he the last batter undone by bounce. Even Jason Holder, whose height and back-foot game would normally make him well equipped to handle short-pitched bowling, fell to a Bhuvneshwar delivery that kicked sharply from the middle of the pitch.

What connected the dismissals of Gill, Sudharsan and Holder was not merely the length but the line.

All three possess strong back-foot games and are comfortable pulling or cutting deliveries aimed at the body. By directing the short ball outside off stump, RCB denied them that comfort. Instead of playing naturally from a middle-and-leg line, they were forced to drag the ball from outside off, increasing the likelihood of mistimed strokes. The lack of clean contact ultimately led to their downfall.

It was a tactic GT may not have anticipated, but it highlighted how quickly Hazlewood and Bhuvneshwar assessed the conditions and adapted. Previous RCB sides have often been criticised for failing to react swiftly when Plan A stopped working. This team did the opposite. Their willingness to abandon convention and embrace what the surface demanded was another reminder of why they were champions in 2025 and why they earned their place in yet another IPL final.

Just 4 singles in their first 55 runs for Bengaluru

With Gujarat Titans having to defend the fifth highest total to win the title in IPL history, Royal Challengers openers Venkatesh Iyer and Virat Kohli seemed to be only dealing in boundaries and sixes during the run-chase.

In the first four overs of the chase, Iyer and Kohli smashed a total of two sixes and nine boundaries to propel the Bengaluru side to 55 for 0.

The pair had only ran four singles along with one leg-bye in the first 24 balls of the chase with the Titans' bowlers being treated with belligerence. In contrast, Titans had five singles to show in their first four overs having lost two wickets for 30 runs. RCB finished with 70/2 in the Powerplay and the boundaries did not let up for the Titans as Virat Kohli kept pushing on at an easy clip.



Despite RCB losing wickets, Virat Kohli steered their chase. PRAVEEN KHANNA

Once the wickets fell, Kohli eventually slowed down. 40 off 18, he would then get into his familiar job of finishing it. But even then the boundaries never dried up for Kohli. He finished what he started, his unbeaten 75 off 42 leading Bengaluru's run chase, defining his role once again as the chase master.

Kohli scores his fastest IPL fifty in his 19th season, and stays till the end to guide RCB to second consecutive title

SYNOPSIS: A Virat Kohli chasing masterclass leads RCB to second straight IPL win in Ahmedabad.

Shankar Narayan
Ahmedabad, May 31

For years, the Royal Challengers Bengaluru (RCB) carried the tag of perennial under-achievers in the IPL. Despite boasting some of the league's finest batsmen, they never quite had the complete team needed to truly challenge for the crown.

That changed dramatically after a stellar 2024 auction, where a shrewdly assembled, well-balanced squad addressed their long-standing weaknesses and sparked a sensational turnaround - culminating in a second consecutive IPL title, this team beating Gujarat Titans in the final on Sunday.

The name 'Rajat' means silver in Hindi, but under Rajat Patidar's captaincy, his achievements will be etched in gold whenever the history of the IPL is rewritten. The 32-year-old may be a quiet, unassuming personality off the field, but his leadership on it, both with the bat and in tactics, is now converting RCB from an underachieving unit into the team to beat.

Less than 24 hours ago, another perennial under-achiever - Paris Saint-Germain - won their second straight title. On Sunday, it was RCB's turn.

Kohli show

There was a time when, even at the peak of his powers, Kohli's failures in knockout matches often mirrored his teams.

Over the last few years, however, the script has changed. Whenever India have found themselves in a high-pressure knockout or final, Kohli has repeatedly delivered performances of significance. On Sunday, with RCB chasing a second IPL title, it was time to produce one of those innings.

The target of 157 was not daunting, but the surface offered enough assistance to ensure there would be no straightforward chase. Fortunately for RCB, Venkatesh Iyer got off to a flying start, smashing 32 off just 16 balls and immediately put Gujarat Titans on the back foot. GT's pacers, who had enjoyed success throughout the season by bowling Test-match lengths and probing outside off stump, altered their plans against Kohli. They targeted the stumps more often and mixed up their lengths between full and short deliveries.

It played straight into his strengths. The veteran quickly got into rhythm, whipping de-

liveries through the leg side and pulling anything short. Every boundary was met with a deafening roar from the overwhelmingly pro-RCB crowd.

Yet, once the foundation had been laid, Kohli recognised that the chase demanded something different. As wickets fell around him, aggression gave way to a more measured approach.

Between the seventh and eleventh overs, RCB lost both Rajat Patidar and Krunal Pandya, threatening to hand GT a route back. Kohli responded by shutting down risk. Seven singles, a couple of twos and a boundary off Jason Holder ensured the scoreboard kept moving. It was not a phase that would dominate highlight reels, but it may well have been the most important period of the innings.

His half-century arrived in the 11th over from just 25 deliveries. Even after Tim David's dismissal shortly afterwards, Kohli ensured RCB remained firmly in control. As he raised his bat towards all corners of the stadium, there appeared to be an appreciation of what this innings meant - not just another fifty, but one crafted specifically for the occasion.

Fittingly, it was Kohli who completed the job. Arshad Khan erred in length, and Kohli swatted him over long-on for six. His unbeaten 75 off 42 balls was not his most explosive T20 innings. It may, however, have been among his most valuable. On the biggest day of the season, Kohli delivered an innings paced with intelligence, composure and authority.

Combined effort

For much of their history, RCB's identity revolved around batting talent. The likes of Virat Kohli, Chris Gayle and AB de Villiers often carried the side, only for bowling shortcomings to undo their efforts. This RCB side wins differently. Bhuvneshwar Kumar and Josh Hazlewood set the tone by removing both Shubman Gill and Sai Sudharsan. GT's decision to promote Nishant Sindhu backfired as Rasikh Salam Dar dismissed him in the eighth over. The pressure never eased. Hazlewood accounted for the dangerous Arshad Khan, while Bhuvneshwar removed Jason Holder. Rasikh finished with figures of 3/27, capping another influential display from a bowler who has become one of the finds of RCB's rebuild.

BRIEF SCORES: Gujarat Titans 155 for 8 in 20 overs (Washington Sundar 50 not out; Rasikh Salam 3/27) lost to Royal Challengers Bengaluru 161/5 in 18 overs (Virat Kohli 75 not out; Rasikh Khan 2/25) by 5 wkts.



PRAVEEN KHANNA

Rasikh, unsung stinging beetle

The canny Rasikh Salam has been the black and white telly in the high definition RCB seam show. He is not express quick; he doesn't have a hat of tricks; he doesn't always get the new ball; batsmen perceive him as the one to hit, after the stifle and strangle of Bhuvneshwar Kumar-Josh Hazlewood-Jacob Duffy. But he has a large menu of useful balls, as he hurries batsmen off the surface. He moves the ball a shade either way. He is quicker than most batsmen think he is. Titans' Nishant Sindhu underestimated his pace and paid the price by dragging a hard length ball straight to long-on. The ball arrived a wee bit quicker than he had judged. Marginally, and Rasikh deals with fine margins. He has quietly emerged as a bankable wicket-taker too, plucking 17, his side's second highest wicket-taker of the tournament, the unsung stinging fourth beetle.

Gill-Kohli crackle over claimed catch near end

It wasn't the first low catch that went to the third umpire in the game. But its authenticity set the Ahmedabad grass blades on fire, as Indian cricket's two biggest stars - Virat Kohli and Shubman Gill found themselves in a situation where sparks crackled. Kohli missed the timing on lofting an Arshad Khan full length delivery as the bat toe end chipped at the ball. The popping ball found Gill at mid-on as the India ODI captain dived in front clutching the claimed catch in his fingers. He celebrated promptly, but Kohli would watch the big screen replay and worked up a frenzy. The umpire was called upon to look at it, and he confirmed the catch wasn't clean. Gill looked chagrined and shared a few words with Kohli - though nothing unsavory. He would walk off with flared nostrils.

Kohli goes for the kill at the right time

This IPL has seen a different side of Kohli. Having already shown last season that he isn't going to play the anchor role, this season he has taken his attacking approach to another level. Kohli, of the old, when he waits and gets his eye in, preferred to finish games off. It meant he took fewer risks. Not anymore. Here when Rabada and Siraj attacked with short deliveries, he went for the kill — all statement shots that showed he meant business and wants to finish the chase early. Going at a strike-rate of over 200 he ensured even when GT took wickets, RCB were able to put the pressure back on the opposition. Apart from Venkatesh Iyer, it was Kohli who provided the much needed impetus for the defending champions trying to nail down this tricky target. And it wasn't wild slogging, but all crisp shots, defining his batsmanship.

We've got great balance, strength in group: Kohli

Express News Service
Ahmedabad, May 31

VIRAT KOHLI'S six No. 25, over the long-on fence, confirmed Royal Challengers Bengaluru's second IPL title. Having waited 18 years for their first, they now join Chennai Super Kings and Mumbai Indians as the third team to successfully defend the crown. But Kohli said the pressure on the franchise was less than the previous season when they finally ended a long drought.

Having started the tournament as favourites, they played like a champion team from the word go, never showing any signs of struggle. And Kohli, who top-scored with 75 off 42 deliveries in the final, said the road to the title this season was relatively easy.

"I said to a few of the boys that it doesn't feel like the same pressure like last year. We topped the group stage, if we stick to our strengths, we're the best," he said soon after the five-wicket win over Gujarat Titans. In a long tournament, there were a couple of defeats, but RCB never looked like a team that was going to collapse at the first sign of pressure.

"To be fair, after the break we had one loss and then a close win against MI before a clinical win against KKR. That was a tricky week for us and then we ended up topping the league stage. You look at the group, don't feel like you need to step up every time and there are guys in front and behind you. World-class bowlers - (Josh) Hazlewood, Bhuvu (Bhuvneshwar Kumar), (Jacob) Duffy - the player of the match awards spread around. I feel great in a group like this, we have got great balance and strength," he said.

Krunal Pandya, another key member of the squad who too had an outstanding season with the ball and also scored vital runs, said half of the job was done at the auctions and the results showed. "There's no doubt about it, everything is special. It's like having kids, winning IPL titles is also hard to achieve.," Pandya, who had won three titles with Mumbai Indians, said.

You look at the group and don't feel like you need to step up every time. There are guys in front and behind you. Hazlewood, Bhuvu, Duffy the player of the match awards spread around. I feel great in a group like this, we have got great balance and strength"

VIRAT KOHLI
ON THE RCB IPL-WINNING TEAM

EMOTIONAL rollercoaster

Personal duel, short but sweet

The first ball, delivered with a wobble seam, had Shubman Gill groping and made contact with the inside half of the bat. The next one, with an upright seam, moved away just enough to beat Gill's outside edge, prompting oohs and aahs from the connoisseurs.

But if one thought Bhuvneshwar Kumar would have things his way in the early personal clash, Gill provided an immediate riposte with a dreamy on-the-up cover drive that left fielders rooted to the spot.

The next delivery was under-edged to short third before Gill took matters into his own hand by making room to cut to the offside sweeper for a single.

Just to make the point that Bhuvu has no real preference in bowling to right- and left-handers, the last ball of the over went past southpaw Sai Sudharsan's bat on the offside,



Shubman Gill was dismissed by Josh Hazlewood. PRAVEEN KHANNA

though the batter may have intentionally played inside the line. The early skirmish in the big final was always going to be the key, and with Josh Hazlewood taking out Gill in the next over, fans were denied Round 2 of his duel with Bhuvu.

UNASSUMING SKIPPER WHO BROUGHT CLARITY

Patidar, RCB's mane man

Devendra Pandey
Ahmedabad, May 31

BEFORE TAKING over as captain of Royal Challengers Bengaluru (RCB), Rajat Patidar, in a casual conversation with a friend, had wondered whether he could be the man to break their IPL title jinx.

“Kya pata mein captaan banoo aur RCB jeet jaye (Who knows, I become captain and RCB wins),” childhood friend Abhishek Pathrod remembers what the Madhya Pradesh batsman had said.

Patidar may or may not have the ability to see the future, but he has indeed led RCB to back-to-back titles after suffering repeated heartbreaks over the previous 17 seasons.

The conversation took place after the franchise had offered him captaincy, a left-field decision as Patidar hadn't even led at the domestic level.

“We are seeing you as a cap-

The son of an Indore trader who deals in motor pumps and pipes had his own ideas on how to end the title drought. The boy who doesn't open up easily opened the doors to the winner's circle.

tain from next season, the franchise had told him at the end of the 2024 season, something the unassuming cricketer wasn't expecting.

Patidar was given some time to consider the offer. “So, when he came home, I told him that he should definitely do it,” recalls Pathrod.

However, Patidar didn't rush to a decision nor showed any excitement on his face.

“His reaction was that 'no, first I will do it for the state and see what I feel. After that, I will say yes to them. It's not like I got an offer from there and I said yes.' So, he took that decision after a lot of thinking and consideration. It was only after leading his state team that he took the RCB role,” his friend recalled.

Madhya Pradesh made him the captain for the Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy and the Vijay Hazare Trophy. Patidar quickly

A left-field choice for captaincy, the Madhya Pradesh batsman took his time before accepting the offer, but has since transformed the fortunes of the team



(Above) Rajat Patidar on the eve of the final; (Left) Patidar with his childhood friend Abhishek Pathrod. PRAVEEN KHANNA, EXPRESS

who deals in motor pumps and pipes had his own ideas on how to end the title drought. The boy who doesn't open up easily opened the doors to the winner's circle.

It was not just the captaincy; Patidar did more than his share with the bat as well. Those who have seen him since his younger days aren't surprised by his clarity of thought. Former Madhya Pradesh teammate and pacer Ishwar Pandey explains.

“He will face countless balls to perfect his art. He is now getting rewarded for the hard work

and sweat he has put in. Another person who should get credit is Amey Khurasiya, for making him what he is today,” Pandey says.

Early days

No player becomes big overnight, and no player does it alone. Patidar was picked for a Madhya Pradesh Cricket Association (MPCA) under-14 camp where Khurasiya, a former India batsman, took him under his wing.

“He (Patidar) was always a man of few words and more action. He was always committed personified,” Khurasiya says.

It was Khurasiya who went about chiselling the raw talent. If Patidar was asked to play only drives for hours, he did it. Next day, if the drill was to improve his back-foot play, he followed instructions like an obedient soldier.

“Rajat is a child of process and relentless pursuit of excellence. He has sweated a lot,” the coach adds.

As a batter, what differentiates him from others is his ability to judge length quickly.

“It's a very big quality for a batsman to see the ball a millisecond early. He takes up his execution position a little early.”

His unbeaten 93 in Qualifier 1 against Gujarat Titans had many people amazed but back in Raipur, Khurasiya wasn't.

“We have a term called situational effectiveness. You can only be effective when you are mentally aware. Patidar just followed what he has done over the years,” he explains.

During his junior days, every coach in Indore used to tell their students that ‘Rajat ke batting *dekho* (watch Rajat's batting)’. Pathrod says there was one game where he played with a torn ACL but scored 297. One trait that he continues to display is calmness.

“He loves to stay in the moment. You would have seen it in his captaincy too. He may say what needs to be done in the future, but will focus on the present. His calmness hasn't changed. He opens only to his family and a few friends. He loves to spend time at home,” Pathrod, who has now become a coach in Indore, says.

From being unsure about captaincy to finding success as a leader, Patidar has come a long way.

Satwik-Chirag end 2-year title drought with Singapore triumph

Shivani Naik
Mumbai, May 31

IT'S BEEN two long years since Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty won a big badminton title. When it finally came in Singapore after a fight back for a 18-21, 21-17, 21-16 victory in 72 minutes, their iconic racquet-twirling and bhanga jigs were back. So was a rocking cradle celebration.

It was also two years of heartbreaking tragedy when Satwik lost his father. On Sunday as they beat World No.3 Fajar Alfian and Muhammad Shohibul Fikri to win a Super 750, Satwik would explain the coordinated baby-celebration.

“Singapore is happy, because after Olympics we have been battling with that (lack of titles). Chasing for that one win. And when we thought we were on the right track, personal things happened. But suddenly one good thing was, last week my brother was blessed with a baby. So the celebration was dedicated to her. We felt like my father was reborn. So she was lucky. This win is dedicated to my family, with brother and mom in the US,” Satwik said.

Braving a first set loss and playing the decider for the fourth time this week, the Indians put up a show in fast, furious badminton to win the Super 750, becoming India's first pairing to win Singapore. Their loss at Thailand finals had cast doubts. But their ability to problem-solve and come up trumps even when dragged into a flat game, blazed through this week.

The Indians lost a close first set after 18-18 as the two playmaking Indonesians aced the crisscross exchanges when closing out. But the Indians have hardly been thwarted by these early setbacks this week.

The Indonesians targeted Satwik who was scratchy in defense early on, with even his smashes going into the net. But the Indians have been sticking to their plan of Satwik getting used to front court duties till the halfway point in the match. Fajar-Fikri (Fifa) would also realise that he grows in confidence exponentially as the match progresses.

While the rallies stayed short mostly, the pace of the exchanges was breathless. Fifa are known for their flat crosses and surgical attacks as action remains concentrated on the



Satwiksairaj Rankireddy (L) and Chirag Shetty celebrate after winning the Singapore Open Super 750 on Sunday. BADMINTON PHOTO

Braving a first set loss and playing the decider for the fourth time this week, the Indians put up a show in fast, furious badminton.

front court. A 10-second rally could literally have 20 shots in play, and the Indian crouch defense was put to the test.

Once Chirag stepped forward, the Indians picked up pace, but Satwik was also finding bisecting cross drives, even as the Indian serves swung between faults and fabulous.

“These matches you don't get so many smashes to hit,” Satwik told BWF. “So you have to prove yourself you can play at the net as well. My job is to serve and catch first shot then hand it over to Chirag. I felt they were under pressure when we were chasing up and playing very much simple. When a few net chords helped us I thought today is our day. I was so happy.”

Opening up a 18-15 lead in the second set gave Indians the impetus and deflated Fikri who made a bunch of rush-of-blood errors. Fifa were anyway struggling to keep shuttle in bounds on the backlines. But coach Tan had also told Satwik-Chirag to be alert to the first three shots.

“With Indonesians, Malaysians it's mainly about first four shots,” Satwik told BWF. “If they keep us under pressure they are on top, they are very good in those first 4 shots. So coach said don't worry about back court, focus on front court.”

In the finishing stages of the second, Satwik found the line on a lofted shot and pushed a decider with a lucky net chord. The Indian attack by then had composed itself — absorbing pressure of the flat crisscrosses in defense, and pouncing on lifts given Satwik smashes were impossible to defend for the Indonesians.

Even as the Indonesians correctly attacked Satwik chasing him like a tracker about the court, he came up with the best point of the Singapore smashing success. On a dipping shuttle in front of him, when it was inches off the ground, he curled his wrists exquisitely with the racquet head pointing down to send the swishing lift to the back line for 9-5 in the decider.

When Fikri got going and reduced gap to 13-15, the Indian soaring attack was back. Three smashes from Chirag got dug out by Alfian, but they had no answer to the 4th from Satwik.

At 16-13 and 20-15, Satwik unleashed a hat-tip to India's obsessed sport — cricket. With his version of yorker-smashes. No matter how good your defense — and the Indonesians have very good retrieving capabilities — there's little you can do when the smash is aimed right at the toes. Alfian could only sweep it away on the floor — such was the precision. Satwik snuck in a yellow card in the middle of all this for not being ready quick enough to receive serve. But his last down hit was sent flying wide by a grimacing, glum Alfian.

“I've put in a lot of effort and energy in my celebration. Jokes aside, we knew the wins would come. Just a matter of time,” Chirag said.

Kostyuk stuns Swiatek; Zverev cruises into quarters

Reuters
Paris, May 31

IGA SWIATEK'S 25th birthday celebrations turned sour at the French Open on Sunday when the former champion lost to 15th seed Marta Kostyuk in the fourth round and her quest for a fifth title ended just when she had looked to be rediscovering her form. Swiatek's shock 7-5-6-11 loss came amid a chaotic spell at Roland Garros, with men's world number one Jannik Sinner, 24-times Grand Slam winner Novak Djokovic and defending women's champion Coco Gauff all going out in the previous three days.

It leaves world number one Aryna Sabalenka as the favourite to lift her first title in Paris, though Ukrainian Kostyuk will be one to watch as she builds on the momentum that has helped her to sparkle on clay this season.

The French Open will crown new champions in both the men's and women's draws for the first time since Djokovic and Garbine Muguruza triumphed a decade ago. One of the dark horses for the Musketeers' Cup will be teenager Rafael Nadal, who battled back from two sets down to beat veteran Pablo Carreno Busta 4-6-4-6-6-1-6-2-6-2 in their all-Spanish battle of the generations.

His next opponent, Alexander Zverev, is a more established contender with three trips to Grand Slam finals, and the German remained on track for an elusive maiden major by beating lucky loser and birthday boy Jesper De Jong 7-6(3)-6-4-6-1.

The lightness of Divya, top of Norway Chess leaderboard

Amit Kamath
Oslo, May 31

AT THE press conference a day before the start of the Norway Chess tournament, Divya Deshmukh found herself answering the familiar question again. Did she still not consider chess her full-time profession?

Flanked by 11 players who definitely consider themselves as full-time chess pros, Divya answered with nuance refreshing for a 20-year-old.

“You don't need to make something a profession to give it a 100 percent. For me, it doesn't matter if I call it a profession or not,” answered Divya, who has spoken about pursuing psychology as a profession. “Just trying to do my best.”

After five rounds of the Norway Chess Women's tournament, Divya's best had taken her to the top of the standings, with her latest win in the classical format over Chinese star Zhu Jiner being her best performance yet. In her previous four rounds, she had four draws and won three of her Armageddon games.

Against Zhu, who's being touted as a future women's world champion and is already a world No.4, Divya, playing with black pieces, was struggling out of the opening. But at the end, she overpowered her opponent after finding herself a pawn up. With Divya fighting with a rook and a knight and Zhu having a rook and a bishop, things were tricky before the Indian managed to break through in 84 moves.

Fellow competitors like Koneru Humpy and Anna Muzychuk have this year's Norway Chess Women as one of the



Divya Deshmukh cruising on a motorboat at the Oslofjord inlet. NORWAY CHESS/MICHAŁ WALUSZA

strongest women's fields ever assembled. Leading the tournament at the halfway mark is an indicator that Divya hasn't let the occasion overwhelm her, despite this being her first appearance at the event. She, after all, won the FIDE Women's World Cup the previous year and competed in the high-stakes Women's Candidates a couple of months ago. She also competed in multiple open tournaments, opting to play against stronger male players, which was detrimental to her rating but helped her gain strength on the board.

There is a remarkable lightness around Divya at a chess tournament. Unlike other Indian prodigies who speed-walk past fans before the start of a game, she stops to indulge selfie-seekers and autograph-hunters with a smile, without it feeling like an obligation.

Most Indians have avoided wandering into the confession booth — an innovation at Nor-

Leading the tournament at the halfway mark is an indicator that Divya hasn't let the occasion overwhelm her, despite this being her first appearance at the event.

way Chess, where players walk into a sound-proof booth and speak their minds about anything under the sun without being asked a question — but Divya became a regular during her early games.

“It's a great stress relief,” she said. “Especially after you have been playing for so many hours and cannot talk. You have to just listen to the voices in your head.”

On Friday, after the mandatory day of sailing at the Oslofjord was done, all other female players had made their way to the players' hotel. Divya, on the other hand, was cruising on a motorboat, taking over the steering wheel with R Praggnanandhaa and Vincent Keymer standing in the boat. On the day she lost the Armageddon battle in the fourth round, Divya was asked about her flashy white shoes with bows on them, and what it said about her fashion sense. It's not usually a question asked of a chess player in the playing hall. “For me, (my fashion) is kind of a stress-relieving thing before a game. When I get ready, chess is the last thing on my mind,” said Divya.

(The writer is in Oslo at the invitation of Norway Chess)

New weight class, no problem for Deepak

Pritish Raj
Lucknow, May 31

TOKYO OLYMPIAN wrestler Deepak Punia has experienced a series of misfortunes.

In 2024, he missed a flight to Olympic qualifiers and a potential berth. In 2025, he suffered an injury after the World Championships. Now, in 2026, he had to change his weight category due to a muscle injury. Deepak, who has competed in the 86kg and 92kg categories, entered the fray in 97kg at the Asian Games trials in Lucknow on Sunday.

However, it didn't matter much at the end of the day as he pinned Jointy Kumar in the final to book his Asian Games berth. “I didn't want to change the weight category. I was prepared for the 86kg category, but for six days, due to a muscle tear, I couldn't train. My weight was around 92 kg. As I had no option apart from recovery, I decided to go for the 97 kg category,” Deepak told *The Indian Express*.

Deepak started a little rusty against Sahil Jaglan in the first round but won the bout 4-0. “I knew it was not going to be easy but I had planned to take it one bout at a time,” he said.

In his second bout of the day, Deepak pinned his namesake, Deepak Chahal, to enter the semis. His semi-final opponent was recently crowned U-23 Asian Champion Vicky Hooda, who has been one of the rising stars in the category. Deepak looked much better in the bout against Vicky and used all his experience against the youngster.

He won 7-3 despite Vicky trying multiple takedowns but failing. Deepak also expertly reversed two pushouts and booked his berth in the final.

“Wrestlers like Vicky and



Deepak Punia pinned Jointy Kumar in the final of the trials. PTI

Jointy are doing well and I know that their level is going to be good. I had good coaches on my side,” said Deepak.

He was constantly guided by Azamat, a Russian coach hired by the Services Sports Control Board. “I'm an athlete of Services and coach Amzat looks after the wrestlers there. While I train in Chhatrasal, I keep consulting him about training and guidance. Today also, he guided me well against Vicky. He asked me to not give him any chance to push me out or attack my legs,” explained Deepak.

While the duo hasn't trained together yet, Deepak and Azamat plan to train ahead of the Asian Games. “Haven't trained Deepak yet but he is a good wrestler,” Azamat said. “I want to train with him and we will see what we can do before the Asian Games,” Deepak said.

Till four days back, Deepak was ineligible to compete at the trials due to his absence from the Federation Cup and the National Championships. He competed in 92kg at the National Ranking Series. However, Wrestling Federation of India allowed the medalists at the Ranking Series to be eligible

for the trials on May 27.

For the past two years, Deepak has been inconsistent due to injuries but he believes that small changes will help him in the 97 kg category.

“I don't have any options now. I will compete in the 97 kg category and give my 100 percent. There are small changes I need to make which will further help me,” said Deepak.

It is not going to be easy for Deepak who will be facing the likes of Arash Yoshida of Japan and Akhmed Tazhudinov (Bahrain) in the Asian Games but he is confident of doing well and will also work with free-style coach Bentindis Shako. “Yes, I have worked with coach Shako when he was here last time. I think his arrival is going to help me as he knows my game,” said Deepak.

Asian Games squad: FREESTYLE: Aman Sehrawat (57 kg), Sajeet Kalkal (65 kg), Sagar Jaglan (74 kg), Mukul Dahiya (86 kg), Deepak Punia (97 kg), Rajat Ruhlal (125 kg) **GRECO-ROMAN:** Sumit (60 kg), Deepak (67 kg), Aman (77 kg), Sunil Kumar (87 kg), Nitesh (97 kg), Deepanshu (130 kg)

NADA finds unused syringes, Russian meds during checks

Pritish Raj
Lucknow, May 31

UNUSED SYRINGES and Russian medicines were found in the bag of a support staff member when the National Anti-Doping Agency's (NADA) Intelligence and Investigations (I&I) unit conducted random checks during the Asian Games wrestling trials at the SAI Center in Lucknow on Sunday. National camps have a strict no-needle policy.

However, a NADA official said they were unable to identify the owner of the bag as nobody had come forward to claim it following the random checks.

“We don't know who the bag belongs to, but we have made a report and sent it to our office,” said the NADA official.

The medicines listed on the report were: Neoton, Pregma 75, and Atorbet, according to the official.

The SAI center hosts the men's wrestling camp.

“Today, for the trials, a lot of kids have come, and we don't know who is carrying what.”

“We can't check their bags. But there is a no-needle policy in the national camp,” said one of the coaches at the camp.

NADA's intelligence unit has increased the number of surprise bag checks after the World Anti-Doping Agency (WADA) flagged India as the country with the highest number of dope cheats.

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